Vereinsamt

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The Secret of the Diagonal

7TH-01

Vereinsamt

The Secret of the Diagonal

Thirty-seven: Mama, I have a question.

Thirty-seven: Why don't people like the "irrational numbers"?

The woman turns around, gazing her daughter with warm affection.

77: Mmm, do you feel the same about them, 37?

Thirty-seven: Mmm, maybe a little?

37 looks down and kicks away a pebble.

Thirty-seven: You see, Mama. I can count to 3, and to 17, but I can never count to something like 0.0100100010000 1, let alone use it in calculations.

Thirty-seven: The endless, non-repeating decimals would make a mess of the results, and I can't keep the equations as simple and elegant as I want.

77: But your favorite, the circle—the ratio of its circumference to diameter is also an irrational number, is it not?

Thirty-seven: π is special. I know how it was found and what it represents, so I trust it and use it in my calculations. The same with e, log2, and $\sqrt{2}$.

Thirty-seven: But not many irrational numbers are this convenient to work with.

Thirty-seven: Some have no patterns, no simplest forms, and no end. I can't work out their digits, write them out, or calculate them.

Thirty-seven: Not only are they impossible to pinpoint on the number axis, but there's an infinite amount of these irrational numbers!

77: Haha.

Thirty-seven: What's so funny, Mama?

77: You're a clever, silly goose, my dear.

77: You don't dislike them. You just don't understand them enough.

Leaning down, she picks up a soggy twig.

Her hand moves, sliding the tip of the twig across the sand.

Four equal perpendicular lines are drawn, with two more diagonal lines intersecting in the middle.

It is the shape of the familiar square.

77: Take our old friend $\sqrt{2}$ for instance.

77: The irrationality of this number can be proven through basic arithmetic, as it cannot be expressed as an irreducible fraction of integers a/b ...

77: A simple proof by contradiction is enough, with no knowledge of irrational numbers required.

77: The presence of $\sqrt{2}$ is prevalent in nature, and it is particularly noticeable along the diagonals of a square. This means—

Thirty-seven: Oh, I know!

Thirty-seven: This means the system built solely on the ratio of integers was flawed!

77: Yes. √2 is simple, elegant, and one of the greatest discoveries in mathematics. It showed the existence of infinite incommensurable numbers, with √2 being the most obvious one to find.

77: This was how the tower of old ideas crumbled, paving the way for revolutionary breakthroughs that catapulted mathematical analysis into uncharted frontiers.

77: We discovered a kingdom beyond our traditional methods—one that is immeasurable, incommensurable, and inexhaustible.

77: And the key to its gates is hidden in plain sight—in the diagonal of a square.

Thirty-seven: A kingdom of irrationality?

The girl listens intently. As always, she understands quickly.

Thirty-seven: I see now, Mama. We are not all-knowing beings. There will always be numbers beyond our awareness. Such is the nature of irrational numbers.

Thirty-seven: So, if we get to know the irrational numbers better, we can be friends with them, too!

Thirty-seven: But, you haven't told me why people on the island hate them.

77: ...

The image of her mother's face fractures.

But her smile is clear—gentle, quiet, and almost ... pitying.

Thirty-seven: Mama?

Sophia: ...!

Sophia: 37, you're awake!

The girl sits upright in bed, her eyes staring into the air in dismay.

Thirty-seven: ...

Thirty-seven: Sophia, how long was I out?

Sophia: You've been in a coma for a week. We ...

Her words are cut off as 37 jumps off the bed, rushing her way out.

Sophia: No, stop! You're not well yet!

Thirty-seven: There's no time!

Thirty-seven: I have to find 6. I have to tell them now—

Thirty-seven: Our "circle" has been broken.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Animal Symbolism

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Now, we've learned some manners in Apeiron, haven't we? Namely, to abstain from beans, never parcel off a loaf, and stay away from the white roosters on the road.

It's been so long since we last talked about these things. How time does fly! This rusty brain of mine is struggling to keep up ...

We should have waited until dawn to light the candles. The sun would have mistaken the day for night and delayed its appearance in the morning. That way, we would have had more time to talk.

Choices

1. I don't think that's possible.

Indeed. You possess a far greater understanding of the laws of nature than your ancestors. It's only natural that you wouldn't relate candlelight to sunrise. But, for the people of earlier times, there was a commonly understood connection between the two.

Did the trees not bear fruit after the Horn of Plenty was filled at the harvest festival? Did the field not wave with grain?

Does the lighting of a match not illuminate the moon?

It's human nature to try to understand the world. Of course, at that time mistakes were made, and some phenomena were attributed to the wrong causes; some theories were developed from false facts.

It was a time of symbols, you see.

Choices

1. Such as?

The flower represented blessings and harvest, the ouroboros the eternal cycle, the hawk wit and astuteness, and the soil safety and protection.

Aside from nature, the circle symbolized protection, the triangle stability, and the triple helix ascendance, change, and the unity of mind, body, and soul.

As time went on, things became associated with one another, and more and more symbols were created.

Choices

1. It's not a very methodological approach.

You can see the cause and effect with your own eyes, dear. It's clear when something is related and when it isn't. If the outcome isn't what we expect, these symbols must be incorrect.

But it's not their physical form that's wrong. Physical objects never lie. It's the meaning and concept given to them that are wrong, you see.

Objects are just objects. A match is just a match, not the illuminator of the moon. An animal is just an animal; the circle and triangle are only shapes ...

... and "you" are just "you".

Animal Symbolism

The Blue and the Grey

7TH-02

The Blue and the Grey

The Hall of Apeiron

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Nothing's happening?

The Hall of Truth is as crowded as ever.

Ideas, noises, and arguments are all crammed into one space.

???: Ms. Vertin, your attention, please!

???: This is a public inquiry, and your answer determines the fate of you and your friends.

???: There will be a vote on your punishment, considering the leak of the island's coordinates and the damages caused by you and Manus Vindictae.

???: Yet, in the past two hours, you've looked at your watch ten times. Forgive me for being blunt. What could possibly bother you more than your sentence?

Vertin: My apologies.

A mocking click of the tongue can be heard from the crowd.

210: Let her look, 888. Doesn't it occur to you that time is also in the form of numbers?

210: Perhaps she's waiting for her lucky number to come.

His words cause a ripple of chuckles throughout the hall.

Clearly, after hours of debate and discussion, this lighthearted moment brings a much-needed sense of relief.

210: Besides, what conclusions have the good people here made?

210: We were brought together in this great hall today, for misfortunes have struck us in the past week: Manus followers were found dead in our sacred place, the Gorgon Current was cut off, and a human army has invaded our land.

210: There were also the territorial disputes, the threats from external powers, and the conflicts between our guests.

210: As you can see, our guests have brought us quite the unexpected "gifts."

210: They will give us their explanations. But whose words should we trust—those of the Foundation, or Manus Vindictae?

He bows slightly, gesturing to the left of the stage.

Vertin: I swear on the Stone of Truth that I have no knowledge of the leak.

Vertin: We never gave any information to the humans. As we speak, the St. Pavlov Foundation is taking measures to mediate the territorial disputes from outside the island.

888: But you did report everything here to the Foundation.

888: And you don't know what they did with the information, do you?

Vertin: Right.

210: A questionable defense, a doubtful explanation. Why should we trust her? We all know that the Foundation is closely associated with the humans.

210: They are the false friends of the arcanists, with their crocodile tears and broken vows. While many may have changed over time, their nefarious human taint lingers.

210: Besides, why should we seek collaboration and assistance from an organization that's seven years behind us on the study of the "Emanation"?

His words evoke a murmur of agreement.

210: But rush not, brothers and sisters! The moment of decision has not yet arrived. Let's give our old friend Manus Vindictae a fair and equal hearing before casting our pebbles into the pot.

He stretches out his right hand, directing the audience's attention across the stage.

On the right, there sits a quiet figure in black and blue.

Arcana: ...

210: Indeed, the Foundation's understanding of the "Emanation" is seven years behind ours.

210: However, our Manus friends here are unable to speak at all, let alone understand complex mathematical principles.

210: Please enlighten us, Ms. Arcana. Why were swaths of your followers found dead at the door of our sacred place?

210: Did our math lessons drive them to madness, causing them to bash their heads against the gate of Truth like martyrs?

Arcana: So it would seem.

Believer II: What?

Her quick and straight answer causes a commotion in the crowd.

Yet she only gently closes the book on her lap, uncaring of the suspicious stares around her.

Arcana: One must confess that our followers were ill-prepared to take on the wisdom of the island.

Arcana: But we didst come seek mutual development with sincerity.

Arcana: I trust you are aware of the assistance we have provided o'er the years in this World of Matters, which you, though reluctantly, relied upon.

Arcana: As to this debate,

Arcana: I was once told a story that now seems fitting to recount.

Her gaze falls on the bench.

The fair-haired judge has not spoken a word since the debate began.

Six: Pray, share with us.

Arcana: Thank you kindly.

Arcana: 'Tis the story of the "circle." A young artist told it to me before I arrived on this island.

Arcana: In the ancient past, amid a world of primitive instincts and ignorance, the first intelligent mind awaken'd.

Arcana: Overwhelmed by the enormity of nature and dismayed by its own insignificance, the creature was shaken to its core.

Arcana: In an act of defiance, it drew a magick circle, shielding its powerless self from the formidable world beyond.

Arcana: This was the first magick, when the primitive man mastered the pneuma within and wielded it against the relentless forces of nature.

Arcana: In that process, man hath gained a deeper understanding of the boundaries and limitations of its power.

Arcana: This is the tale of the first "circle."

Arcana: The "circle" shielded us, and its protection benefits thee to this day.

Arcana: What I find intriguing in this story:

Arcana: Man hath established its existence, recognized its boundaries, and learned the purpose of life, all by relying upon this very circle.

Bang!

The hall gate bursts open. The intruder with a small figure leans weakly against the doorframe.

Thirty-seven: *panting*

Vertin: 37?

All eyes are fixed on the young girl; some have even risen to their feet in surprise.

The leader on the bench breaks the silence.

Six: What's wrong, 37?

Thirty-seven: The island ...

Her pale lips tremble, struggling to get the words out.

Thirty-seven: Our island has fallen ill.

Even the slightest sound is gone. An eerie silence descends upon the hall.

Thud!

Another dull, muffled thump, as if something's struck a hard surface.

But it's enough to get the rest of the crowd to their feet. They look up at the roof—the thud came from up there.

Thud, thud thud thud!

More thumps follow.

It's as if the hall has turned into a drum, with an out-of-control drummer playing frantically on the dome.

Believer IV: Argh, what is going on?!

Believer IV: Is that a hailstorm?

Sophia: No, I don't think so.

Standing outside the gate, the numberless Corrector looks up at the sky.

Being barred from entering the hall, she can see better from where she stands.

Sophia: Those are Abraxases,

Sophia: falling from the sky.

Vertin: ...!

Another look at the watch—it's become something of a habit over the last few hours.

This is it. The long-anticipated moment has finally arrived.

Vertin: It's the "Storm."

Vertin: The "Storm" of this era is here.

TO BE CONTINUED...

"Storm" Shelter Notice

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"Storm" Shelter Notice

Emergency notice—for your personal safety, please stop what you are doing and read this report in its entirety, unless your life is in immediate danger:

The Timekeeper has issued a 24-hour "Storm" warning. All investigators are to abandon their current tasks upon receiving this notice and return to headquarters to seek shelter.

"Storm" Shelter Precautions:

• We will prioritize space for the preservation of personal items that comply with regulations, but note that space at headquarters is limited—please do not bring unregistered personnel or personal items over 20 kilograms back to headquarters. Note that family

members of investigators who are not members of the Foundation are also considered unaffiliated personnel.

• In special circumstances, such as having to bring unregistered personnel or extra items back to headquarters to protect the Foundation's core principles, please first contact the headquarters through the nearest device with sound functionality and a dial (must have a round movable part and sound, such as a car radio), and we will respond as soon as possible. For the Foundation's core principles, please refer to the Foundation Investigator's Code of Conduct, Chapters 1 through 3.

• Since the Storm Syndrome is currently irreversible, for the safety of the Foundation, returning personnel must undergo an inspection. High levels of infection will restrict your entry, and we will place you in a special isolation area until the "Storm" ends.

• If you are in a critical situation and require assistance, the various rescue methods outlined in the Field Mission Evacuation Instructions will remain in effect. Reasonable rescue requests that comply with regulations will be responded to immediately."

Bring the Gavel Down

7TH-03

Bring the Gavel Down

Believer II: Ms. Vertin, did you just say the "Emanation" has happened?

Believer II: Just now?

Vertin: More precisely, its 24-hour countdown has begun.

Vertin: There's always a buffer period before the "Storm," during which the Storm Syndrome gradually spreads from the Critical Point across the globe. The symptoms are different every time, and we have yet to discern a pattern.

Vertin: With the help of Laplace Scientific Computing Center, the best we can do now is to send a 24-hour warning prior to the "Storm."

Vertin: Another minute has passed.

The hall is once again filled with the whispers of the white robes.

On this island dedicated solely to the study of the "Emanation," the situation has far surpassed their imaginations.

888: Please remain seated, everyone. We are still in the middle of a vote!

888: The "Emanation" holds no influence on this island. The discussion must continue until a satisfactory conclusion is reached. No other subjects shall be brought up until then.

The banshee, acting as Custodian of the assembly, raises her voice, drowning out the arguments.

Despite the unforeseen turn of events, she remains committed to her duty—the debate must go on.

888: Come here, 37. Can someone please bring her a blanket?

Her voice softens as she looks at the frail, slender girl in front of her.

888: 42, go with Sophia and check on those Abraxases.

Believer I: ...

The man bows and leaves.

Order is restored under the dome once more.

210: Ah, good news, good news indeed!

210: We are freed from the pain of choosing whom to blame, are we not?

888: What?

The rhetorician raises a hand with a triumphant smile.

As usual, he's offering a new perspective, or what some might call another attempt at stirring up the crowd.

210: The "Emanation" is coming. The tides of pneuma will pour from above and wash away all trivialities.

210: By then, human intruders and the international powers of this era, along with the turmoil they brought,

210: will all be dissolved and poured into the ditches like gunk.

210: And we will regain our shores and return to the study of essence and Forms.

His words are met with silence.

The crowd is lost in thought. Having long detached themselves from the phenomenal world, 210's words are striking a chord.

Thirty-seven: No, it's different this time!

The petite figure stands on her feet.

She is pale as snow from her coma, and did not bother to put on the blanket given to her.

Thirty-seven: The island has fallen ill!

Thirty-seven: It's getting bloated, stagnant, and sluggish, drifting into the World of Matters where ignorance reigns.

Thirty-seven: Soon, the tides of pneuma will wash over us, sweeping away the fragments of the phenomenal world.

Believer IV: What did you say?!

Believer IV: In other words, we will all be taken by the "Emanation"? This ...

Believer V: This is unthinkable!

This is terrible news, one that nobody wants to hear right now.

The impact is like a bomb going off, the crowd is buzzing with fearful whispers.

The lady next to 37 stands up, still holding the unused blanket.

Believer II: 37, you just woke up from a coma. You're not well.

Believer II: Why don't you take another rest?

Thirty-seven: No, no time for that. I'm here to warn you.

Thirty-seven: Apeiron is gone. I can no longer sense It. This has never happened before!

888: Why are you so surprised, 37?

The question is asked softly, but it cuts like ice.

888: You should know the reason of Its alienation.

888: You brought outsiders to the sacred place. You betrayed the Scriptures' teachings and angered Apeiron!

Thirty-seven: ...!

888: Of course, I may have jumped to this accusation, as Manus Vindictae also intruded our sacred place without permission.

888: People! As of now, there's no proof that the "Emanation" will influence the island. 37's account is lacking.

888: And we are still plagued by suspicions, accusations, and the damages done to our home.

888: We are to proceed with the hearing and reach a final verdict on both the Foundation and Manus Vindictae.

The attempt to refocus the assembly fails as half the audience turns their attention to the gate.

Sophia has returned, standing hesitantly in front of the entrance.

Sophia: I'm sorry. Please forgive me. I shouldn't have intruded the Hall of Truth, but ...

Though irritated by the constant interruptions, the Custodian immediately notices her peculiar expression.

888: Sophia, weren't you and 42 checking on the Abraxases?

888: What is the matter?

The Corrector gestures in the air, her voice shaking.

Sophia: The Abraxases don't look right! Their beaks, no, their entire heads are melting into oil paints.

Sophia: And 42 ... We were on the beach, suddenly, he ...

Her words trail off.

Beyond the open gate, the screeching of the bird monsters completes her sentence.

The other believer appears behind her, shoving Sophia aside as he flails and stumbles into the hall. His face is melting, colorful oil paints forming a puddle on the floor.

Believer I: Hahaha! Now I see, it finally all makes sense!

Believer I: There never was the Truth, nor the transcendental! Everything is a lie! Nothing but shadows on walls, flickers of fire, and fragments of reality!

Believer I: No one will survive the oblivion! The island will be destroyed amid its conflict!

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: Is that the Storm Syndrome?

888: 42, your face ...

Completely disregarding those around him, he bursts into maniacal laughter, casting an arcane glow in his palms.

He jumps onto a seat and knocks over a row of torches.

Believer I: NO ONE!

Vertin: 888, stop conversing with him!

Vertin: We must subdue him, now!

The Hall of Apeiron

Vertin: He has the Storm Syndrome!

Vertin: Please, listen, everyone. 37 is right. Something's changed on this island. Your immunity to the "Emanation" has been weakened!

42 lies motionless on the floor, his face still a mess of colorful paint.

Fear and uncertainty quickly arise around him.

Believer IV: How? That's never happened in the last eight times!

210: A feeble induction, my friend. Just because you've never seen a purple cow, doesn't mean it doesn't exist.

Believer IV: Must we talk of logic now?! 42 has literally been "emanated"!

Believer II: First the army, then the "Emanation." Everything's been falling apart since the outsiders arrived on this island.

Believer II: The Foundation and Manus Vindictae—one of them must answer for this.

Believer IV: Then you should also ask 37 and number "0" what they've done in the sacred place to anger Apeiron so much!

Thirty-seven: I ...

Vertin: No, 37 didn't cause this. I told you. It was Manus Vindictae!

Vertin: They broke the peace agreement and launched suicide attacks. They forced their way into the cave.

Believer IV: You and them are equally responsible on this matter!

Believer IV: They at least paid with their lives. What about you?

Believer IV: You claim that 42's abnormality was caused by the "Emanation," but how are we to believe that it isn't, in fact, the work of your arcane skills?

Believer IV: As we went through your belongings, Ms. Vertin, we found a golden sampling device. Enlighten us: What exactly is the Foundation looking for here?

Vertin: That's ...

Arcana: Heh-heh.

From the other side of the hall comes a soft chuckle.

Arcana: Good, Vertin. Good.

Arcana: Let the confrontations be louder and the struggles be harder.

Arcana: I wonder what shall come of this.

Six: Silence!

The gavel slams down with a heavy, undeniable thud.

The host of the assembly rises to his feet, his face unusually grave.

Six: The debate will end now.

Six: Since we were unable to come to an agreement, further discussion is pointless. There are more pressing matters to attend to.

Six: This will be the end of the assembly, and my decision will be the final ruling:

Six: I demand that both parties leave this island at once.

The decision is clear and final.

As the number of reconciliation, 6 has been mindful of his use of unilateral authority.

Yet, there are no objections this time.

Vertin: ...

The hall falls into a silence—a silence that demands a decision.

What to do?

Choices

1. Accept 6's verdict.

2. Wait for Arcana's move.

Branch 1

The outcome is still acceptable, things will just go back to square one.

Besides, the concepts exchanged on the "Storm" and the samples of asymmetrical nuclide R are already significant advancements for subsequent research.

More importantly, if the School of Apeiron cannot form an alliance with the Foundation, they must be stopped from joining forces with the enemy instead.

This is a chance to take the initiative and avoid being caught in a reactive position.

All that's needed is to stand up and nod.

Vertin: I respectfully accept your verdict.

Agreeing was the easy part.

Now comes the real issue—what will she choose to do?

Arcana: My choice matches that of Vertin's.

Vertin: ...!

Branch 2

Leaving the island would be a huge loss. The discussion about the "Storm" has only just begun, and the depths of the cave is yet to be explored.

Worst of all, the leader of Manus Vindictae—she can't be left here with the School of Apeiron.

Will she accept the verdict? Will she appeal?

Just what exactly is she after?

It's a zero-sum game, where the first one to react is more likely to lose.

The best course of action is to wait.

Arcana: The decisions of my fellow brethren shall be respected.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I also agree with your verdict.

Shared continuation

She casually agrees, just as she did when asked to pledge on the stone bangles.

Arcana: But may I ask for one small doubt to be dispelled?

Arcana: Ms. Vertin and I will depart ere long. Do you truly not desirest aid from us?

Six: You're kind to ask, miss.

Six: It is true that our circle has been disturbed, but we see it as a mere turbulence of the phenomenal world.

Six: He who holds the compass decides the circle. This will not shift the center of our focus, nor change the shape of our beliefs.

6 bends down, laying his hand on 42's forehead.

Six: Μηδὲν ἄγαν.

Believer I: ...

Believer I: *breathes peacefully*

Vertin: He purged the Storm Syndrome with an arcane skill?!

Vertin: I never thought it'd be possible.

The leader straightens up, looking as composed as ever.

Six: The light of intelligence has cleansed 42 of confusion. It is also what the island needs.

Six: The incident will be properly handled, and my ruling stays unchanged.

Six: I expect your words to be matched by actions, Ms. Arcana.

His tone is cold, leaving no room for negotiation.

Arcana: Certainly. It was a fair and just decision,

Arcana: if only one could depart amidst such unfavorable weather.

Arcana: I presume Ms. Vertin will also appreciate more time to prepare for the journey, what sayest thou?

Vertin: ...

It is a reasonable request, and her expression is nothing but decent and sincere.

Six: The hourglass empties in two hours. Please leave before that.

Vertin: Thank you for your thoughtful consideration.

The decision is met with no further objection from the people.

6 puts away the hourglass and looks at the silent audience.

Six: Lastly, I would like to share a story,

Six: to conclude today's meeting, and respond to Ms. Arcana's tale.

Arcana: I am most honored.

The leader raises his hands and faces the people.

Six: I, too, have heard the story of the first circle. But in my version, more followed.

Six: The first of man were intimidated by the enormity of nature and constantly tried to defy and escape it.

Six: Our ancestors, however, had the opposite reaction. They found solace in nature, which welcomed them with a nourishing embrace, sharing its vastness and sublimity without reservation.

Six: It was the perfect harmony. The moment the circle ceased to represent confrontation and avoidance.

Six: As we bathed in Apollo's illumination and wandered the tranquil shores, our souls resonated, and we were lifted to a higher wisdom.

Six: This was how we conquered our fears, emerged from ignorance, and allowed ourselves to indulge on the essence and Forms.

Six: This was the rise of the "classic man."

Six: May you all be blessed with the courage for reconciliation, the determination for peace, and the devotion to nature—qualities no less noble than caution and defiance.

Six: You may all leave now.

Thirty-seven: Please, just a moment!

A clear voice rings across the hall, stopping 6 in his tracks.

Her robe flutters as she stands up on the high podium.

Thirty-seven: I will fix our circle!

Thirty-seven: 888 was right. I have enraged Apeiron. I am responsible.

Thirty-seven: I will go back to the sacred place, pass Its test, and ask It to share the divine light of Gnosis, so we can learn the Truth about the essence.

Thirty-seven: I will make up for what I've done, I promise!

6 turns around, his eyes meeting the gaze of the determined star.

Six: It has been three hundred years since the last challenger had their success in the cave.

Six: 37, are you aware that we have other means to cleanse the island, even if you don't bring the matter to Apeiron?

Thirty-seven: Yes, I'm aware.

Six: Then are you aware of the price you will pay, should you fail Its test?

Thirty-seven: Yes, I am.

Six: Then you shall have my blessing.

He leaves, ignoring the murmurs of shock.

The gavel is thus brought down.

The long debate has finally come to an end.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Storm Syndrome Investigation Record

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Storm Syndrome Investigation Record

The symptoms of the current Storm Syndrome can be roughly summarized as oil painting transformation and heightened delirium. Depending on the region, the severity of the Storm Syndrome also varies:

Vienna

Expressionistic oil painting transformation pervades the body uncontrollably. At the same time, emotional stability is severely impaired—irritability and abnormal behavior occur, including but not limited to:

- Using deadly force to correct pronunciation.[1]
- Declaring oneself as an independent nation and founding a country by family unit.
- Identifying parties by the color of their oil paintings and persecuting people of different colors.

...

Athens

Oil painting transformation symptoms only appear on the face, with a few cases of recovery reported, specific reasons unknown. Aggressiveness increases, especially a strong destructive impulse toward olive trees.[2]

Democratic votes on whether to go to war have occurred several times in different squares, often splitting into two factions and starting a war during the vote.

Cairo

Oil painting transformation symptoms are limited to parts of the facial organs, with minor actual effects on the body, which can largely be ignored. The main mental effect is reflected in an increase in swearing.

The local military, severely affected, has begun attempting to convert the pyramids into war fortifications.

…

…

…

Based on feedback from investigators around the world, it has been tentatively concluded that the epicenter of this "Storm" is Vienna, and the closer the physical distance to the epicenter, the more severe the symptoms of the Storm Syndrome.

[1]Example: German speakers with non-Austrian accents have been attacked by Austrians.

[2]To be more precise, this is an act of rebellion against peace.

The Beginning of a Proof

7TH-04

The Beginning of a Proof

Sonetto: The headquarters has issued a notice. The Critical Point of the "Storm" is in Vienna.

The chief assistant puts down Ms. Radio and turns around with a somber expression.

Sonetto: This type of Storm Syndrome involves a bodily transformation into oil paintings, primarily affecting the face but sometimes spreading to the torso. It is often accompanied by delirium and an intense obsession with war.

Sonetto: Like the "Storm" of 1929, it was accelerated by social upheavals resulting from the constant tensions Manus Vindictae created between nations.

Vertin: This era …

The color of the sky has changed.

The Storm Syndrome has finally reached this island.

No one on the team's caught it yet, but that could soon change.

Regulus: This is absurd!

With a bag filled with alchemy materials over her shoulders, the young pirate remains spirited despite a week in underground captivity.

Regulus: We went through all that trouble, sweated our guts out, and finally got to a place where the "Storm" can be kept out. But now you're telling me that immunity is going to disappear like a fart in the wind?

Regulus: I was planning to stay here for a while. There might be alchemic materials and pieces of books the Abraxases left behind from their meals.

Regulus: Ugh! Now that is frustrating, mate!

Sonetto: *sigh* Such is the nature of arcanum?

Vertin: The immunity hasn't "disappeared." It's just waning. For now, only the beach has lost the effect. We're still safe around the Hall of Apeiron.

Lilya: But there's no guarantee that we'll be safe here forever, right?

Lilya: Hah. Reminds me of Zeno's survival test.

Vertin: Sonetto and I talked about this. We think the island is protected by a large-scale arcane ritual.

Vertin: The sudden decay of the island's "Storm" immunity might be the result of its changes, though I'm unsure of the specifics.

Regulus: Those people are doing something about it, right? That leader with the rock star hair—shouldn't he be taking action by now?

Vertin: 6 has gathered all integers after the assembly. They're going to perform a mass cleansing ceremony.

Vertin: 37 also mentioned a test. I think they have more than one way to deal with the changes.

APPLe: To the best of this APPLe's knowledge, secluded pure-blood arcanist groups often have rituals that they keep to themselves.

APPLe: These islanders impart Truth based on intellect and rationality, yet their doctrines are highly religious. Perhaps their arcane skills are passed down in a religious manner.

Lilya: Oh, very mysterious, very arcane. I hope they're not all huddled together doing math at a time like this.

Lilya: And I'm more worried about us, Captain.

Lilya changes her tone, unusually serious.

Lilya: Arcana asked for more time for both sides to withdraw, didn't she?

Vertin: Yes. 6 gave us two hours to leave. That is to say ...

Vertin: We must set out when the "Storm" countdown reaches 20:00.

Lilya: And before that, the stone bangle on your wrist still works, right?

Vertin: Yes. I can feel it.

Vertin: It would scald me whenever I thought about going to war with them.

Lilya: Hah. I see.

Lilya: So we only have two hours for the plan.

Regulus: Plan? What plan?

Regulus: Aren't we sneaking away from all this?

Sonetto: Sorry, Regulus, your, uhm, "accommodation" was a long way from ours, so we haven't given you the latest updates.

Sonetto: To put it simply ...

Thirty-seven: Where are you going?

Sonetto: Uhm!

The sudden appearance of the girl startles the crowd.

37 stands there with a curious look on her face.

Sonetto: Ahh, 37, we ...

Vertin: We are discussing how to leave this place, 37.

Regulus: Precisely! I was just about to say, your chief wants us gone in a jiffy, but we don't even have a piece of wood to sail with!

Regulus: Vertin is sizing us up to see if we can fit in her suitcase. She's going to swim across the Aegean Sea using her tiny arms! Right, Vertin?

Regulus squints and eagerly pokes her elbow in.

Vertin: Right.

Thirty-seven: Hmm. Sounds like a lot of fun!

Thirty-seven: Then you must leave from the north side of the beach, jump off the cliff there, and head south. The cliff is on the tangent line of the Hall of Apeiron, which is a good sign for your journey!

She nods confidently, fully convinced of her own conclusion.

Thirty-seven: I will show you where to jump. But you'll have to wait till Vertin and I return.

Vertin: Me? Where are we going?

Thirty-seven: What kind of question is that?

Thirty-seven: The only place worth going.

She extends her hand with a light and happy tone.

Thirty-seven: You're the one and only 0. We'll go see Apeiron together!

Guest Room, Island

Marta: Aren't you going to look for 37?

Marta: You took such good care of her while she was in a coma.

In the darkness, the figure trembles ever so slightly.

She tries to steady herself.

Sophia: I don't know.

Sophia: I don't know what I should do, Madam Marta.

Sophia: She's going back to the cave for the test, where I can't help her.

She looks down, trying her best to press her shaking hands together.

Sophia: All I can do is pray for her, for I have no adequate knowledge or power to assist her.

Sophia: As ever.

Marta: Perhaps you needn't worry so much.

Marta: 37 is the one favored by Truth. She will be fine.

Sophia: I know. It's just ...

Sophia lets out a long, helpless sigh and buries her face deep in her palms.

Sophia: She is also of mortal flesh. She could get hurt, bleed, or die.

She avoids looking at the beach, seeing it as a battlefield where she lacks the skills to engage.

Sophia: You haven't been with us for long, Madam Marta. Apeiron and Its test might be new to you.

Sophia: Here on this island, we spent years theorizing, proving, and constructing models based on our mortal comprehension, defining the boundaries of what man is capable of understanding.

Sophia: But when it comes to the "essence" and "Forms," we are unable to make any definitive statements. So we humbly approach the temple and inquire about the correctness of our beliefs.

Sophia: And our answer is delivered as a "yes" or "no," reverberating in the form of echoes.

Marta: Is that the "submission of proof" 6 mentioned before?

The Corrector nods, knowing her friend has a natural talent for this.

Sophia: Validating one's essence and soul with a number and verifying the authenticity of one's claims are simple feats for us.

Sophia: But Apeiron's test is different.

Sophia: "Those who succeed will obtain the transcendental Truth."

Sophia: "Those who fail will pay a terrible price."

Marta: ...!

Sophia: Everything has its limits and boundaries.

Sophia: Those who overstep their bounds will only court their own misfortune.

Sophia: We must respect and be wary of our limits, so our souls will be adequate for our bodies, and all things be refrained from excess.

Sophia: The "boundless," "limitless," and "infinity" are not of our realm to tread. They belong only to ancient beings that we cannot utter. We can only stand in awe, offering our admiration, humility, and reverence.

Sophia: Now 37 is going to knock on Its door and ask to be indulged with the transcendental Truth. But, if she fails, if she can't bear the weight of the boundless infinity ...

She can't go on.

Sophia: I wish I knew a better way, or could even do it in her place.

Sophia: But only she can do it. It has to be her, 37.

Thirty-seven: I'm sure this is the perfect solution to finally put an end to all our problems!

Thirty-seven: If I pass the test, Apeiron will grant me the answer to one question. It can be any question I don't have an answer to, even about the "essence" and "everything."

Thirty-seven: At least that's what Mama told me.

37 nods with confidence.

Thirty-seven: I just have to choose the right question to ask, and we will be rid of all the troubles. Whether it be the "Emanation," the turmoil of the phenomenal world, or the dangers threatening the island, all will be gone!

Thirty-seven: I have 6's blessing. He agrees with me. So, Vertin ...

Regulus: Ah-uh, not so fast! You can't just steal away our helmswoman like that!

Regulus: This "thing," it's too good to be without any risks, don't you think? What if Vertin doesn't make it back? Huh? Who's going to swim us across the sea then?

Thirty-seven: Hmm? It could be risky, but not for Vertin, only for me. 0 multiplied by any number will still be 0.

Thirty-seven: And we have validated that proof!

Regulus: Well, that's not good enough for this Pirate! Besides, Vertin doesn't seem like a 0 to me.

Vertin: It's okay, Regulus. I think I'll be safe there.

Vertin: But 37, isn't this a sacred test for your people? I have never taken the oath. I'm not one of you.

Thirty-seven: That does not matter, Vertin.

She gently shakes her head in determination.

Thirty-seven: But you must know that once we enter the temple, we cannot turn back. The path to the Truth is a one-way road.

Thirty-seven: Our last visit was interrupted, remember? You didn't get to ask your question, and I didn't get my answer.

Thirty-seven: And now, I don't need to ask my question anymore.

She bites her lip, holding her own arms tight.

Thirty-seven: You and your friends were right, Vertin. The discord in the phenomenal world does have an effect on essence and Forms. No one can argue against this when facing the "Emanation."

Thirty-seven: But there's more I'd like to know, and I believe you feel the same.

Thirty-seven: I will tell 6 that you're coming with me. I will tell everyone and persuade them, because this is the right thing to do.

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: Go, Timekeeper. While you're out, Lilya and I will ready us for evacuation.

Lilya: We will liaise with the Foundation from here.

Vertin: Thank you both. I'm ready.

Vertin: Before we go, 37, I have a question.

Thirty-seven: Hmm?

A golden opportunity has arisen.

This could be a chance to level the playing field against Manus Vindictae.

Vertin: You just said that Apeiron will grant an answer to whoever passes the test.

Vertin: Will It answer my question?

Vertin: If I asked for a way to become immune to the "Storm"?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Four Cross-Checks

7TH-05

Four Cross-Checks

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Researcher I: Damn! You narcissistic, fat-headed, humanocentrist freaks!

Researcher I: You are the crazy ones! And I, I will prove myself right!

Researcher II: Seriously!? Can someone please bring Matthew back to the rehab center? That mask has made him crazy!

The researcher's arms flail wildly as he stumbles across the shiny silver floor, adding more to the chaos.

Amidst the mayhem, a bottle of alcohol on the ground bursts into bright blue flames.

And then, two metal feet stomp across the fire without hesitation.

Lucy: Any progress?

Cryptography Lead: Not much. We've called all the experts here, but so far it's been a waste of time. Not even a bodily reaction when reciting the text.

Cryptography Lead: It doesn't belong to any known language, nor follow any linguistic rules.

Cryptography Lead: Many are starting to doubt the accuracy of the incantation. After all, it was copied down by a novice investigator with her arcane skill, not her supervisor.

The door is pushed open.

The spacious room is now packed with people.

They're all gathered around a radio on the table.

Liaison Staff I: Ms. Marcus, can you confirm that the incantation you dictated was correct?

Marcus: I ...

Liaison Staff I: We also learned that you witnessed a visual recording of Arcana performing her arcane skill, depicted through images recreated by a pure-blooded arcanist. Is that right?

Marcus: Yes, to be precise, I saw it in the memories of Isolde, a former member of Manus Vindictae, using Ms. Kakania's arcane mirror.

Liaison Staff I: Can you attest to the accuracy of this memory?

Marcus: I can't say.

Liaison Staff I: Do you deem the reflection of Ms. Kakania's arcane mirror to be accurate, factual, and without misinterpretation?

Marcus: I'm not sure.

Liaison Staff I: Can you confirm that your arcane skill, "Read," was performed correctly, and provided an unbiased, objective, and flawless interpretation?

Marcus: I, I don't know about that either.

Marcus: But I saw it with my own eyes. I heard the chanting.

Marcus: I don't know what language that was, but that's how I heard it, and I've written it down phonetically!

Liaison Staff I: Please calm down. We are only verifying the details.

Liaison Staff I: The Foundation has dispatched a special operations squad to you in Vienna. Please make sure the two other arcanists involved will return to the Foundation with you.

Marcus: I ... Understood.

The call ends. The liaison removes the headset.

The result is far from ideal. Her face is pale, as lifeless as her mechanical colleagues.

???: This? Is this it?

A sarcastic voice cuts through the air as a man pushes through to the front.

Enigma: "An ancient miracle, a circle of salvation!"

Enigma: /eɪ uː.nə 'sa.kəʊ/ ... a Tuna Psycho?

Enigma: An inexplicable incantation transcribed by an arcanist based on what she saw in the memory of another arcanist recreated by yet another arcanist.

Enigma: That's as convoluted as a dream within a dream within a dream. To think they wanted an "objective restoration."

Enigma: I mean, if Gnosis is so reliable and can really cross-check not only once, but FOUR times, it should have long replaced science by now.

Enigma: With this level of uncertainty, we might have better luck asking typewriter monkeys to randomly give us the answer to the "Storm" immunity!

Cryptography Lead: Adler?! Why are you here?

Lucy: I requested his participation on the cryptography team.

Lucy: He is a human, but he excels in the field of cryptography.

Cryptography Lead: But ...

The man takes a grim step forward.

Enigma: And why can't I be here?

Enigma: Is it because Greta Hofmann's my sister?

Enigma: And this—is this what a respectable and honorable member of the Foundation gave her life to retrieve? Is this the ritual she died for?

Enigma: Oh, riiight. It wasn't even her who retrieved the ritual. It was her student.

Lucy: You are not currently on the official roster. You can leave at any time.

Enigma: Leave? Why should I leave?

Enigma: I have every right to know what my sister died for!

Enigma: Well, now. Get to work, people. Let's decipher this great mystery and see what it'll bring us.

Enigma: Salvation, or oblivion?

He leaves sneering, waving the note with the phonetic spelling in his hand.

The farce is finally over. The room is at peace again.

The cryptography team turns to the robot, awaiting her instructions.

Lucy: Return to your stations, please.

Lucy: Let us not dismiss its credibility until we have exhausted every possibility.

Lucy: Also ...

She calmly turns her head.

Lucy: Add Adler Hofmann into the cryptography team roster.

Cryptography Lead: The cryptography lead hesitates for a moment, surprised. Nevertheless, he nods and quickly leaves the room.

The phone on the wall, used for internal communication, begins to ring.

Liaison Staff I: "Storm" Observation and Research Center.

Liaison Staff I: Noted. I will make sure Ms. Lucy is aware of that.

The liaison puts down the phone and turns to the robot, a flicker of panic on her face.

Lucy: What is the matter?

Liaison Staff I: It's a call from the rehab center, about the previous study on the Manus mask.

Liaison Staff I: Ma'am, I think you should go see this in person.

Assistant Simone: Very good, Matthew. Now tell us, what did you hear?

The already narrow corridor is now filled with security guards.

The room they're guarding is heavily secured, isolated behind three layers of tempered glass.

A patient sits in the room with a mask on his face.

Researcher I: Voices, those voices! The inaudible murmurs, the frightening whispers, they worm into my ears!

Researcher I: I told you before. I wrote about this before! But you dismissed them as manic episodes. Haha, hahahaha!

Assistant Simone: Did you put on the mask?

Researcher I: Yes. How else would I know that I was right?

Researcher I: And now I know! And never have I heard them so clearly. They are screaming inside my head!

Researcher I: Their temptations, their promises! I just have to let go of my brain. Can you hear it? The benevolent Mother is speaking!

His nails dig deep into his palms, as if fighting an overwhelming impulse.

Researcher I: Now, I can write the ultimate paper!

Assistant Simone: Who is this "Mother"?

She is answered by a loud crash. The researcher throws himself against the glass, gasping in horror and scratching helplessly at the surface.

Researcher I: No, I can't say any more! They see me. They've come for me.

Researcher I: Kill me! Kill me now!

It is too late to beg for mercy. His scream is abruptly silenced as his head explodes open behind the glass barrier.

Amidst the splatter of blood and brain, a new being emerges from the remnants of his flesh.

Manus Follower: *roar*

The alarm blares loudly.

A Manus follower wriggles up from the bloody floor, holding a triangle in hand. He lets out a loud cry, reminiscent of a newborn's first wail.

The liaison ends the call, cutting off the horrid sounds on the other end of the phone.

Lucy: Suspend all research on the Manus mask at once. Its dangers far outweigh the potential benefits.

Lucy: Seal away all equipment and share only a controlled account of the incident with others. We cannot afford to have another researcher try on the mask again.

Lucy: Now. Clean this up.

Laplace Safety Officer: Yes, ma'am.

The airlock door hisses open, a squad of armed guards storms into the room under the cover of sleeping gas.

On the other side of the glass, the robot turns away from the scene, categorizing yet another set of "Storm" research data as irrelevant and filing it away as waste in her memory.

Lucy: Hm.

Lucy: Another dead end.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Decryption Team Personnel List

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Decryption Team Personnel List

※ Ulrich—Approved

Reasons for selection: The most skilled cryptologist in Laplace, also the most brilliant expert in arcane cryptography. In addition, his energy consumption ratio is excellent, capable of high quality work for 72 hours with only two supplies needed. Recommended for selection as the leader of the decryption team.

Team leader's comments: This assessment of mine is incorrect; this record has since been updated to 360 hours. Nevertheless, I agreed.

※ Dawkins—Approved

Reasons for selection: Dawkins is an expert in linguistics. We need more of such people when the origin of incantations is unknown.

Team leader's comments: Dawkins is talented but lacks a sense of seriousness, as evidenced by his inappropriate jokes. Do not let him work alone—assign a serious staff member to supervise him, and also use a cold humor punishment device, setting the penalty at 3 pounds a joke.

※ Richard—Approved

Reasons for selection: Richard is an excellent theoretical mathematician and is able to provide us with advice from a mathematical perspective.

Team leader's comments: Richard is only cautious when solving math problems, but averages three collisions with table corners per day. He also needs a supervisor to prevent such accidents during experiments.

※ Matthew—Approved

Reasons for selection: Matthew has excellent decision-making skills. His fighting spirit will surely bring about important breakthroughs in our decryption work.

Team leader's comments: He's just too impulsive. I do not recommend letting him make any decisions, otherwise an explosion in the lab will be the least of our worries.

※ Williams—Approved

Reasons for selection: Williams has a meticulous thought process. He excels at finding loopholes that others cannot—perhaps he can assist Matthew and prevent him from making any egregious mistakes.

Team leader's comments: Williams is what we call an introvert. His penchant for discovery doesn't mean he'll be good at communicating his findings. He should be left alone to deal with verification.

※ Victor—Approved

Reasons for selection: Victor has a leapfrogging thinking pattern and can keep research from getting stuck.

Team leader's comments: Victor is good, sure, it's just that his ideas are sometimes incomprehensible. Do NOT let him team up with Dawkins—he will definitely end up paying 3

pounds for Dawkins to tell a joke. I can assure you, putting a weirdo and a dark humor fanatic together will cause us problems.

※ Adler—Pending

Reasons for selection: Adler's recommendation is not only because he is an excellent cryptologist, but also because this decryption is not just a task for arcanists—we need opinions from humans as well.

Team leader's comments: I have my reservations. It's not that the team doesn't need humans, but it shouldn't be a silent enigma who hasn't been seen in public for eight years.

Equipment Failure Repair Record

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Equipment Failure Repair Record

Conway Automaton V, also known as LifeGame V. It is the most popular mind expansion tool in Laplace, capable of simulating cell life and death calculations within a maximum of 2^16 pixels with predefined rules, and supporting modular assembly and custom interfaces, among other features. It has been proven to maintain the mental agility of researchers and can simulate most current popular games.

Almost all Conway Automatons were lost in the "Storm" or scrapped to make room for important instruments—this is the last remaining one in the Scientific Computing Center. Although the Conway Automaton V cannot play a practical role in password decryption, to ensure the enthusiasm of the decryption team's work, an urgent repair request is hereby made.

If the repairs cannot be completed in a short period of time, it is hoped that a substitute can be allowed during the repair period, such as the latest handheld console, the Game Dude Color.

Pride and Prejudice

7TH-06

Pride and Prejudice

Office of Director, Laplace

An unknown incantation.

A mask that has proven to be extremely dangerous.

These are the only leads they currently have on the "Storm."

Lucy: …

Her metallic fingers pick up another stack of files.

These are the test results of the Manus mask, confirming the presence of asymmetrical nuclide R.

The robot studies them carefully. The slit on her face pulses in contemplation.

Lucy: What is the status of the sampling, Simone? Any updates from the Timekeeper?

Assistant Simone: For the moment, no. The people on the island are still suspicious of the Foundation's motives, so she hasn't had a second chance to collect any samples.

Assistant Simone: But she has called in an hour ago. We were informed that she will return to the cave shortly.

Assistant Simone: She also warned us that the immunity zone on the island appears to be shrinking. The safe zone is not stable.

Lucy: Hm.

The robot did not put on a face today. Simone can only read her mood from the narrow slit.

Assistant Simone: Ma'am, have you noticed something?

Lucy: They are unrelated, Simone.

Lucy: The mask and the incantation are indeed related to Manus Vindictae, but they are unrelated to each other.

She moves the sealed Manus mask aside.

Lucy: If the account of the Vienna investigator is correct, one cannot help but question:

Lucy: Why would Arcana not simply give the masks to Isolde and her brother?

Assistant Simone: Investigator Marcus's report was highly lacking, making it challenging for us to infer what truly happened.

Lucy: I suppose we can be skeptical that the report is incomplete. But it is all we have for now.

Lucy: She did a good job. I could not have asked for more.

Lucy: We all heard it. "An ancient miracle, a circle of salvation."

The robot extends her hand, drawing an imaginary circle in the air.

Lucy: The leader of Manus Vindictae promised a miracle, but the mask is far from it.

Lucy: The mask is a tool of control, designed to identify and enslave the believers. Matthew has demonstrated its effects for us.

Lucy: But this ritual is different.

Assistant Simone: Do you mean the ritual is more sophisticated than the mask?

The robot nods approvingly.

Lucy: Perhaps, but it is not entirely definitive.

Lucy: The investigators in Vienna completed their mission spectacularly, and now Matthew has proven that the mask is useless for our purposes. Its immunity was only a cover for its other functions.

Lucy: And the mask has powerful and irreversible side effects. Even if we find out how it protects the wearer from the "Storm," we cannot use it on our colleagues.

She picks up the scrip.

Lucy: If this incantation is verified to be true,

Lucy: it will be our Promethean fire.

Cryptography Team's Office

Enigma: This ritual is useless to us.

Enigma: Save yourself the trouble. We're not getting anywhere with this.

Cryptography Lead: What?

The room is cluttered with all sorts of sophisticated equipment.

The floor is littered with scrap paper. The researchers haven't lifted their heads or taken a break for quite some time.

The cryptography lead stares at Enigma, a fresh cup of coffee in his hand. His patience is wearing thin as the metaphorical string labeled "tolerance" in his mind is finally about to snap.

Cryptography Lead: Explain yourself, Adler. What do you mean the ritual is useless?

Cryptography Lead: You barely sat down! My coffee's still hot!

The cryptographer solemnly hands the lead a stack of papers from his desk.

Enigma: I don't need to waste any more time. It's simple logic.

Enigma: The current information is insufficient for cryptographic decryption. We're attempting an exhaustive brute force, comparing every ancient text and record to find the language or corresponding text. It's like looking for a needle in a colossal haystack.

Enigma: Even if we stumble onto a match, none of us can validate such a thing. A breakthrough in this regard is simply not possible—

Researcher II: You can't be serious.

Across the room, a man stands up abruptly from his chair, clenching a pen in his hand.

Researcher II: And what is the basis of your reasoning? Have you figured out the mechanics behind the ritual?

Enigma: I didn't need to understand the intricacies of arcanum to deduce this. It was simple log- ...

Researcher II: So you never even tried to understand it. With your supposedly superior human reasoning, you dismissed all of our dedication and hard work, just like that.

Researcher II: Who the f*** do you think you are!?

Before anyone can react, the researcher lunges at Enigma and punches him right in the face.

Enigma: Wh—?

Enigma brings a hand up to his cheek, looking more confused than angry.

Researcher II: Matthew was right. You arrogant fools, clueless morons!

Researcher II: Get out of my face, you humanocentric narcissist. Go to hell!

The researcher snarls, brandishing his pen like a soldier brandishing a dagger.

Much to his frustration, his swing loses power mid-air—another casualty of the neck and shoulder pain that plagues this office.

Enigma narrowly avoids the attack, bewildered by the turn of events.

Enigma: Was this really necessary? I was just sharing my conclusion.

Cryptography Lead: Ugh, it was the mask! I should've thought of that. He worked in the same lab as Matthew, and he must've been exposed to the mask.

Enigma: But his physical exam seemed fine. Is there an incubation period!?

Cryptography Lead: Does he seem fine to you now? Huh?

Cryptography Lead: No, Williams, put that down! That's the only Conway Automaton V left after the "Storm"!

He is met with a guttural growl, followed by the deafening crash of metal against wall.

The machine whizzes past his head and shatters to pieces on impact.

The cryptography lead can feel his sanity teetering on the brink. He staggers towards the door, frantically smacking the big red button on the wall.

Cryptography Lead: Security! Security! We've got a code red!!!

Lucy: So, what are the implications for the decryption?

Cryptography Lead: There were no unintended consequences. We were able to control Williams in time, and the Conway Automaton V he destroyed wasn't useful to our work anyway.

Lucy: I am glad you kept the damages to a minimum.

Lucy turns off the screen in front of her and turns around.

Lucy: Since you are still here, Mr. Ulrich, I take it as a sign that you have more to report?

In a secluded area of the hallway, an emotionally charged complaint is about to take place.

The cryptography lead tries to keep his voice low, looking completely disheveled from the turmoil he has just endured.

Cryptography Lead: Williams was merely an accident, ma'am, but Adler is a loose cannon on the team. We need to talk about this.

Cryptography Lead: With all due respect, I still don't understand why you put him on the team.

Cryptography Lead: He may have made his contributions to Laplace, but that was eight years ago. Now he's just an irritating defeatist and a staunch supporter of humanocentrism.

Every particle of ferrofluid in his helmet is vibrating with rage, his voice rising involuntarily.

Cryptography Lead: He never understood the arcanum, or tried. He's still stuck in the time before the first "Storm" and refuses to acknowledge that his small, beautiful world is gone!

Cryptography Lead: How can someone like that help us?

The robot senses his doubt and frustration—there may be more sentiments and underlying issues at play. She pauses for a moment before answering, as if deep in thought.

Lucy: I understand your concern, but I have not heard anything about the incapacitation of Adler Hofmann.

Cryptography Lead: Incapaci—What? He got a few scratches at most. The guy barely touched him.

Lucy: So he is fine. I am glad we agree. Is there anything else you would like to report?

Cryptography Lead: ...

The robot waits 5 seconds for an answer. But there isn't one.

This must be the social cue that it is her turn to speak.

Lucy: His lack of knowledge on arcanum is exactly why we need him. His human perspective will offer valuable insights on arcane rituals.

Lucy: The results of this study will not only be used to save arcanists,

Lucy: but also humans who share the same world with us.

The cryptography lead tries to argue further, but Lucy is certain the issue has been sufficiently addressed.

Lucy: We are racing against the clock, mister, and your report on personal disputes and racial conflicts has wasted 2 minutes and 37 seconds of our time.

Lucy: If he refuses to cooperate, you have every right to remove him from the team. That is your responsibility.

Lucy: Oh.

From the other end of the corridor, the subject of their argument approaches, looking deeply upset and clutching a stack of papers.

Clearly, he has heard every word they just said.

Lucy: I am relieved that you survived your altercation.

Lucy: What would you like to report?

Enigma: ...

Cryptography Lead: ...

Their eyes meet, making both of them squirm uncomfortably. This is undoubtedly one of the most awkward moments in both of their careers.

After a prolonged silence, Ulrich steps back and walks away.

Without even looking back at him, Enigma begins his report in a low voice.

Enigma: I'm fed up with wasting time, ma'am. The setback with the mask has already driven too many people insane.

Enigma: That's why you should take a look at this.

He hands the stack of files to Lucy.

Enigma: I can logically deduce that our current direction is another dead end. The incantation isn't long enough for cryptographic decryption.

Enigma: We will have to turn to ancient records. Perhaps we'll find something in age-old manuscripts, in tablet inscriptions, or in the memories of powerful arcanists.

Enigma: But even if we find it, we can't validate it because none of us can cast the skill.

The robot remains silent during his pessimistic remarks, flipping through each page of the file.

Enigma: Low-ranking arcanists can't cast high-ranking skills, even if they know the exact pronunciation and meaning of the incantation.

Enigma: Gnosis is beyond reason like that and cannot be debated. It stems from raw intuition rather than logic and intellect, is shaped by personal experiences and natural abilities, and cannot be intentionally replicated.

Enigma: And the most determining factor—it relies on the arcanist's purity of blood.

Enigma: The miracle ritual you hold such hopes for belongs to the leader of Manus Vindictae, a pure-blooded arcanist whose power is beyond our imagination.

Enigma: It's like asking a toddler to solve Goldbach's conjecture. It's completely beyond the boundaries of our limits!

Lucy: But you are not an arcanist.

Lucy: Why should you play by their rules?

Enigma: ...

The man is taken aback by her question. It's something he's never considered before.

Lucy: You are right. Arcanists differ due to their purity of blood.

Lucy: Researcher Medicine Pocket has already reported the linear correlation between the bloodline of an arcanist and their abilities, and has drawn a conclusion ten times more extreme.

Enigma: Then you should listen. That's their area of expertise.

Her neck moves subtly, almost like shaking her head.

Lucy: We know that our cryptographers do not have the power to validate the ritual.

Lucy: And we do not expect you to do that. All I ask of you is to come up with a feasible plan, and to do it as a team.

Enigma turns away, repulsed at the mention of "team."

Lucy finishes reading the report and hands it back to him.

Lucy: Your deduction is logical, but not practical or actionable.

Lucy: So I should return this to you.

Enigma: What?

The glow in her eye slit is strangely reassuring, almost like a smile.

She looks out of the window.

Lucy: Your logic is impressive, Adler. But do not let it limit your thinking.

Lucy: You spoke of the boundaries of arcane power, but logic has its limits too, no?

Lucy: Knowledge can be obtained through various means, such as intuition, logical reasoning, empirical observations, and teachings from others.

Lucy: Your team is not the only one cracking the ritual through their own means. If you fail, we will turn to the others. And if that approach is wrong, we will try another. If no solution is found before the "Storm," we will simply wait for the next one.

Lucy: What matters is we keep moving forward, no matter the cost. We must keep to the path, or we will be swept away like dust in the rain.

For once, the researcher does not argue.

He whispers, as if talking to himself.

Enigma: If one team fails, you can still turn to the others.

Enigma: Then why? Why did it have to be Greta?

Lucy: What?

Enigma: Forget it. Just a bitter, irrational thought.

Enigma: This marks the end of my efforts. Hopefully, "the others" will bring you the needed breakthroughs.

The man walks away in anger.

But after only a few steps, a question comes to mind.

Enigma: You've been waiting here for a while. Are you expecting someone?

Enigma: You aren't the type to waste time listening to us whine, so there must be something here worthy of your attention.

Enigma: Is someone close to a breakthrough?

Lucy: Nothing of the sort.

Lucy: I am recharging. We have a public power outlet here.

Enigma: ...

She moves her joints as if standing for so long has stiffened her body.

Lucy: But I am indeed waiting.

Lucy: The doves of the White Stone House are here.

The sound of flapping wings fills the air.

The researcher is astonished as the creature, with a texture similar to plaster, perches on her metal finger.

Lucy: Good.

Lucy: Someone closer to the "limit" has given us aid.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Fire Safety

小径

Be ever so careful, dear. The fiery thirst for knowledge is blazing bright within you; be careful not to put it out.

Once, many fire thieves sat here, sipping coffee, as they tried to decipher the best angle to hold up their reeds to jam the burning wheel of Helios and steal his flame.

The gods are selfish. They're stingy with their might.

Choices

1. Shouldn't the gods be more generous?

2. Some will receive it. First come, first served.

Branch 1

That's easy to say when the power's not yours to give. Knowing how to share is a rare virtue. Knowing how to share knowledge is a rarer virtue still.

"How can we transfer our wisdom into mortal minds?" The gods pondered.

Can inspiration be duplicated from one brain to another? It comes and goes like a gust of wind, so what can be done?

Branch 2

True. I'm sure the early customers of the bakery share the same philosophy.

The line must be respected, however hungry the latecomers may be.

There are many fire thieves in the field of science—many more than the bread buyers in the bakery. Take a look at these geeks in uniforms made of aerospace materials.

Among them are arcanists in love with science who spend most of their time studying diodes and machines, and humans who are passionate about the future, always finding new inspirations ...

Elements, lightning, atoms ... Perhaps you've forgotten their counterparts in arcanum, but you must be familiar with them as scientific discoveries.

These discoveries are the milestones of progress, sweetheart. The fire thieves firmly believed that they would be able to bring about many more technical revolutions: the fourth, the fifth, the 65535th ...

Choices

1. Sounds like a twist to the story is coming.

Not yet, darling. We've only finished the prologue. However, there is a "but" waiting down the road.

A sudden rain dampened people's enthusiasm for the future. The floppy disks and many clever minds perished in it.

Some of the fire thieves grieved the loss. They screamed and swore to retrieve what was lost.

What about the rest of them?

They returned to primitive chaos, like coelacanths crawling back into the ocean after thousands of years of evolution. Once again, they became the proteges of arcanum.

Perhaps they made the right choice by leaving that useless science behind. Who knows?

The story of the fire thieves has only gone this far, darling. At this point, no one knows what will happen to Prometheus or what's inside Pandora's box.

Shared continuation

Fire Safety

Maze of The Minotaur

7TH-07

Maze of The Minotaur

Lilya: Any news from Zeno?

Sonetto: They are moving as planned. The deployment will be complete within two hours.

Sonetto: What about Arcana?

Lilya: Same old. Standing still on the rock as if she's a part of it. Soaking up the salt in the wind, I guess.

Sonetto fiddles with the communication device, making sure Lilya's voice is loud and clear.

Now Regulus can hear their exchange with perfect clarity.

Lilya: She's found herself a good spot, overlooking all of us from up there.

Lilya: The center of the island where the "number people" are heading, the entrance to the cave where Vertin and 37 are going, and the beaches in the "Storm" ... Nothing escapes her sight.

Regulus: Ha! Impressive! Maybe she's planning her escape?

Lilya: Is she also going to swim? Hah, it seems like we're in for a swimming competition.

Lilya: Speaking of which, it would be nice if those "tortoise" slowpokes could swim a little faster!

She hangs up and resumes surveillance of her target.

The next two hours are critical.

The islanders are busy with the cleansing ceremony, while the outsiders are preparing for their departure.

Regulus: Look, Sonetto, I understand your plan now.

Regulus: But I still can't shake off a bad feeling about all this.

Sonetto: Don't worry, Regulus. We have gone over this many times.

Sonetto: The margin of error should be below 0.00025%. I'm confident that it will work.

Regulus: I know, I know! Spare me with the numbers. I know I can rely on you!

She waves her hand quickly, as if swatting away the numbers like flies.

Regulus: I'm still worried about Vertin. Will she make it back in two hours?

Regulus: If she doesn't come back in time, who's going to take charge and guide us? We'll have to steer our own course, won't we?

Sonetto: Yes.

Sonetto nods.

Sonetto: Laplace is gathering every piece of information they can find on the "Storm." The discovery of the asymmetrical nuclide R was already a remarkable breakthrough.

Sonetto: It would help the immunity research a lot if the Timekeeper could find something useful in that cave.

The pirate is not satisfied with the answer. Evidently, she has a strong opinion on the matter.

Regulus: Hmm. I don't think she's going to have a lovely time there, judging by what happened to me last time.

Having spent the longest time there, she's undoubtedly the most qualified to comment on the subject.

Regulus: Is it just me, or do you also find this a bit fishy? The dangers aside, using an "answer" as a reward?

Regulus: What?! Is this deity some sort of answering machine?

APPLe: In fact, Apeiron is a philosophical concept introduced by the ancient Greek philosopher Anaximander, which means "the origin of everything."

APPLe: It is the physical manifestation of the "boundless," the "indeterminate," and the "infinite." Everything arises from it and returns to it.

APPLe: But it appears to serve a more practical purpose for the believers on this island.

Sonetto: Ms. Marta told me about this. There are limits to the knowledge one can acquire, even when using "numbers," which are considered closest to the essence.

Sonetto: But Apeiron is a boundless, limitless existence. If we wish to seek knowledge beyond our own limitations, we must turn to It for help.

She faithfully recites what she learned from the teachings of Apeiron.

APPLe adjusts his bow tie, grateful for her contribution.

APPLe: To the best of this APPLe's recollection, the more ancient, abstract, and intangible an entity is, the more likely it possesses arcane powers beyond our fathom.

APPLe: By communing with the supreme existences through sympathetic magic, worshipers could gain the guidance of their transcendental Gnosis.

APPLe: They would, of course, exact a price from the worshipers as well.

Sonetto: Price?

Just hearing the word makes her heart sink.

Sonetto: Could you be more specific on that, Mr. APPLe?

Sonetto: What's the price? Lives? Or ...

Sonetto: Something else?

Thirty-seven: Vertin, jump over here!

Underground Labyrinth, the Island

Thirty-seven: Very good! Now you are on number 1.

Thirty-seven: And you should jump to 7! This is a 4 by 4 magic square. You just need to make sure every 4 steps you take adds up to 34.

Howling wind fills the air. The unstable footing is the only solid thing they can rely on.

The path into the cave is completely different than before.

The transparent stairs are gone, as are the swirling golden lines in the air. Now only cold rock walls surround them, and numbered bricks lie beneath their feet.

It's a game of hopscotch unlike any other.

Vertin: I don't understand, 37. This place was different the last time we were here.

Thirty-seven: It has changed because the test has begun! The path to new knowledge is always harder than verifying a known result.

Thirty-seven: Don't worry. This is like a labyrinth with a Minotaur. There is always a way to the center.

Vertin: But weren't those labyrinth walkers offerings to the Minotaur?

Unfortunately, she doesn't seem to care or be concerned at all.

Thirty-seven: Now we're going to solve the magic square! Vertin, the next number is 10.

Whoosh!

The world churns around them, a space is revealed.

As the magic square is solved, the maze shifts once more.

Thirty-seven: Oh, no. It turned into a magic circle! We have to calculate again.

Thirty-seven: This one's easy. The sum of the numbers on each circle should be equal to the sum of the numbers on its diameter plus the number in the middle.

Thirty-seven: We're just going from a square to a circle. It's not that difficult.

Thirty-seven: You are now on 32. We need to find 17 or 21.

Completely absorbed in solving the puzzle, she doesn't notice what's coming up behind her.

A geometric figure with the number "21" hurtles toward her. For a moment, she thought she heard it chuckle.

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: Careful, 37!

Vertin: The numbers are coming to life. We need to put them back in place!

The ground ceases to shake, and everything comes to a standstill once again. The numbers have returned to their original positions.

37 breezes past them with a cheerful smile, making a beeline for the exit.

Thirty-seven: Like I said, it's not that big of a deal!

Thirty-seven: Hm?

She stops.

Before the gate stands a familiar figure.

Thirty-seven: I thought the next question would be the Ford Circle, the Monster Group, or Hilbert's Infinite Grand Hotel.

Thirty-seven: I never thought it would be 6!

Thirty-seven: Hello, 6! Are you the real thing?

Six: ...

Six: Yes, I'm the real 6.

Thirty-seven: Mm. I wouldn't be so sure. When it comes to the essence, we are all shadows cast on a wall by a flickering fire. How do you know you're the real 6?

Six: Heh.

That was too much to take in. Even 37 can't help but step back.

Thirty-seven: Urh, did you just smile?

Thirty-seven: Hmm. Now I very much doubt that you are real.

Six: I didn't. And I am the true 6.

Six: This gate has always been guarded by a 6.

The leader reverts back to a blank expression.

37 doesn't seem too thrilled to see her friend here.

Thirty-seven: I have a bad feeling about this—I think the question we're about to answer will be very simple!

Thirty-seven: It's just a formality, isn't it? You'll ask a question and let us through. I've seen you do that on other tests before.

Six: Formality is also important.

Thirty-seven: No, only the essence is important, only the Forms are important!

6 shakes his head, showing no inclination to continue the debate.

Six: This is a question about the essence and Forms, 37.

Six: Please pay heed to it.

Six: As for Ms. Vertin, we only expect you to lend a patient ear.

Vertin: Very well.

37 looks at 6 with determination, the same look she had when she faced that challenge in the game of kottabos.

She's confident that she can solve any problem that comes her way.

Six: 37.

Six: If your pursuit of Truth were to lead to the destruction of your faith and beliefs,

Six: would you still keep going?

Thirty-seven: What?

She exclaims involuntarily.

Thirty-seven: What kind of question is that?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Oracles at Delphi

7TH-08

Oracles at Delphi

Thirty-seven: If my pursuit of Truth will be the destruction of my beliefs?

She shakes her head repeatedly, looking more perplexed than when she checked the Manus followers' math homework.

Thirty-seven: I came for the Truth, and my faith is the Truth. Why would the Truth be destroyed by the Truth?

Thirty-seven: If it's because I did the calculation wrong, I'll go back and do it again!

Thirty-seven: And next time, I will do better!

An answer without hesitation, causing the gatekeeper to pause for an extra moment of silence.

Six: What if the essence of Truth is there is no "Truth"?

Thirty-seven: Hm, isn't that also a form of the "Truth"? Its non-existence is an answer in itself, is it not?

Thirty-seven: You're speaking like 210. Are you really 6?

37 has clearly run out of patience with the sophistry.

She stares at 6 in annoyance, trying to detect any sign on his face that he might be playing a joke on her.

Six: I should be more specific. You may see it as another allegory.

Six: A gate stands before you. Open it, you will find the "Truth" you seek.

Six: But at the same time, the world as you know it will crumble. Will you still open it?

37 blinks. This time, her answer is even more clear and resolute.

Thirty-seven: Yes!

Thirty-seven: If my world changes because the Truth is revealed, doesn't that mean my previous understanding was wrong and should be corrected?

Thirty-seven: If what's behind the gate is really the Truth, why would I give up the Truth for falsehood?

Vertin: ...!

Six: I see.

Six: You've passed. As a reward, I will bestow upon you this sacred ritual.

Six: It will bridge the gap between you and the supreme existence during communion.

A gilded scroll is presented to her.

But the winner only furrows her brows even harder.

Thirty-seven: Was that it? You didn't even ask a question that posed a real challenge!

Thirty-seven: See, Vertin? I knew this was just a formality.

Thirty-seven: Vertin?

Vertin: No, 37, I think this question ...

Six: 37.

6 interjects.

Six: There are some words I'd like to share with you.

Six: Not as 6, but myself, who used to live under the name "Atticus."

Six: We know the story of Socrates's life, how Truth and politics are at odds with each other.

Six: Either be wise, uninvolved, and look on; or be practical, involved, and suffer.

Six: I hope you will remember your answer when the defining moment comes for you.

He leaves.

The game has been a disappointment. 37 frowns in frustration, but she keeps a tight grip on the scroll.

The gate in the center of the circle has swung open, but the path ahead is still shrouded in mist.

Thirty-seven: We should go, Vertin. There's a long way ahead.

Thirty-seven: I hope the next question will be more fun.

Thirty-seven: Nothing I haven't expected so far! Just like what Mom told me.

Thirty-seven: They're just games, like skipping rocks, kottabos, and hopscotch. I've always been good at games!

Thirty-seven: Look, there's the gate, Vertin. We're almost at the end!

37 claps her hands with satisfaction, having resolved yet another obstacle.

But her companion is much more pensive.

Vertin: ...

Thirty-seven: What's the matter, Vertin? You've been quiet since we met 6.

Thirty-seven: But you're number 0, not 6. You have no common factor with him.

Vertin: No, I'm only thinking ...

Vertin: What's the question you're going to ask? We've only got one chance.

Thirty-seven: The most important question of all, of course!

Vertin: About the "essence" of the "Emanation," right?

It was not a hard guess.

The islanders devote their lives to the study and service of "the essence." Nothing is more important than this question.

The "essence" reveals the ultimate truth that underlies all existence. Everything else is just fragments of the phenomenal world.

It might not directly solve the issue of the "Storm" immunity, but knowing its nature will certainly help with that aspect.

And it's the key to solving not just one problem, but many others.

Thirty-seven: Well, the essence of it is important.

Thirty-seven: But one day, we will eventually come to understand it. Even if we leave it alone for now, it will still be there, yes?

Vertin: I think so?

She seems to have something else in mind.

Thirty-seven: I can't stop thinking about Regulus. Despite being so close to the answer, she turned back in the cave, determined to earn the answer rather than receive it on a silver platter.

Thirty-seven: It's like covering your ears in front of the oracles at Delphi! How typical of an irrational number.

Thirty-seven: But she was also right, wasn't she? None of the precepts forbids one from doing so.

Thirty-seven: People like her may fall behind or get distracted along the way, learning at a slower pace. But in the end, we will all converge. It doesn't matter if some arrive sooner than others.

Vertin: So, are you going to ask something else?

This time she nods.

Thirty-seven: Yes, I have come up with a better question!

Thirty-seven: A question that will solve all our problems once and for all, and free everyone from the "Emanation"!

Thirty-seven: It's not as profound as my first question, but it's an equally good one.

Vertin: I see.

Vertin: I will stop here then.

Thirty-seven: Hm?

She turns around, eyes wide with surprise.

Thirty-seven: Vertin, are you turning back like Regulus?

Thirty-seven: But you're a 0. You're not an irrational!

Vertin: No, I won't go far. I will wait for you here.

Vertin: This is your gate to open. It is your question, your answer.

Vertin: I will stay here and watch over you. If you encounter any danger in there, I will come to your aid at once.

Thirty-seven: But don't you also have a question to ask Apeiron?

Thirty-seven: Aren't your doubts unresolved?

Vertin: No. I don't need to ask anymore.

Vertin: The question you're going to ask, the one that will free us all from the "Emanation,"

Vertin: is exactly the question I want to ask, 37.

37 tilts her head curiously, but her confusion soon fades.

She quickly understands, as she does with most things in life.

Thirty-seven: I see! So you're choosing to be the one who looks on, like the third kind of men in the Olympic Games!

Thirty-seven: A choice of insight, most appropriate for the number 0!

Without further hesitation, she turns and steps into the final gate.

Thirty-seven: In that case, I will see you later then, Vertin!

Vertin: See you soon, 37.

Put the suitcase down, and breathe. Be ready for anything.

Vertin: Will this really be the collapse of her world as she knew it, like 6 said? If that happens ...

Vertin: I'll be here to hold the umbrella for her.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Outside the Limits

7TH-09

Outside the Limits

The cave is basked in warm, flickering candlelight. Preparations for the cleansing ceremony are finally complete.

The integers are waiting for their leader to return.

888: Do you think 37 is going to make it?

888 lowers her voice, concealing her worry.

210: Who knows?

Leaning against the cavern wall, 210 absentmindedly adjusts the grapevine on his hair out of boredom.

210: 6 should be the easiest one to pass. The math puzzles in the labyrinth shouldn't be a problem for our little star either.

210: The only tricky question is from Apeiron, and no one knows what it will be.

210: It is a fair game. Answer Apeiron's question, and It will answer yours.

210: But if you give the wrong answer, oops.

He pinches a grape between his fingers and crushes it, its juice splattering onto his hand.

210: It'll hardly be a graceful end.

888: You're gross.

888 shakes her head, not even bothering to hide her disgust.

Believer II: We know little about the test. The last person to pass the test was three hundred years ago.

Believer II: The price of failure was high. For the longest time, the 6s forbade people from risking their lives for it.

888: Well, 6 lied.

888: Someone passed the test four years ago.

An unexpected piece of information. Even 210 straightens up in attention.

The banshee gazes into the distance, watching the shadows cast by candles dance on walls.

888: The two of them are so much alike—their talents, their mindsets, even their first thoughts when facing an impossible challenge.

888: It is an irresistible temptation indeed.

888: With a path to all Truths right in front of you, just within reach,

888: who wouldn't want to give it a try?

Deep in the Labyrinth, the Island

Amid the swirling lights and shadows, the trial is reaching its conclusion.

She has reached the heart of the maze, the lair of Minotaur, where the final challenge awaits.

Through the mist, a form gradually takes shape.

First it appears to be a scholar, then a soldier. But it continues to transform—into a king, a farmer, a child, an elder.

Finally, it stops and solidifies into a young woman with a sharp and chilling smile.

Thirty-seven: Mama?

Thirty-seven: How are you here?

A soft chuckle slips out from the shadow.

77?: No, I'm not who you think I am, child.

77?: I am but a shadow, a flicker of fire, a projection before you.

77?: The finite cannot comprehend the infinite. Your limited senses cannot imagine what you've never seen, nor fathom what you've never heard.

77?: I am the answer to your desperate prayers. I am the blindfold before you see daylight. I am the reflection of your confused, hollow faces in the water.

77?: I am the lingering echo of the last visitor.

Thirty-seven: But you look just like Mama!

Eagerly, 37 steps forward.

Thirty-seven: This is the last obstacle of the test. The gate of Truth is just ahead, right?

Thirty-seven: And here you are, standing in front of me. Does that mean that you finally reached the transcendental realm?

Thirty-seven: So my conjecture was right, and our model did not fail, correct?

77?: The transcendental realm?

The woman's laugh is strange and unsettling.

77?: You speak adorable nonsense, my dear daughter. Did you really believe what I said?

77?: You silly little goose!

37 stops in her tracks and lifts her head in disbelief.

She locks eyes with those aquamarine orbs that are unmistakably her mother's eyes.

77?: Have you not doubted, even for a moment?

77?: You did. You wavered when you strolled the shores at night, when you inevitably gazed at the geometric bodies.

77?: "If they really are manifestations of the transcendental world, why can't I find Mama's number in the broken pieces?" You thought.

77?: "Why can't I hear her voice? Why can't I see their patterns? The darkness blinds me!"

77?: "I miss you, Mama!"

Thirty-seven: ...!

77?: Oh, my poor, sweet daughter.

77?: You are too young and naive, too attached to what is familiar, and too trusting of your teachings.

77?: You should have continued doubting instead of following my outdated footsteps.

77?: Was the conjecture wrong? Was the model correct? It does not matter, child. The rules of the game have changed.

77?: The chaos-makers, the fear-mongers, and the rule-shapers—they have already outpaced us.

77?: We were not wrong. We simply fell behind. We were blinded by the dream of the transcendental realm and could not see through reality.

77?: But worry not, my daughter. You have made it here, and that is all that matters.

77?: We will do the calculations together. This time, the results will be more accurate than ever.

Thirty-seven: Mama.

With a gentle smile, the woman tucks her hair behind her ears and reaches out a hand to the girl.

77?: This world is an enormous wasteland, 37.

77?: Look at the creations in it. The congested, silent herds that scurry to and fro in their meaningless lives.

77?: Never have they looked at the stars above, nor bent to smell the flowers. The melodies of the patterns above go unheard by them, their souls unresonant to their wisdom.

77?: They are the prisoners of their bodies, complacent in their dulled senses, and conceited over their success of ruling the planet through violence and bloodshed.

77?: They mocked us, shunned us, and slaughtered us. They discriminated against us throughout the ages, branded us as lunatics, and spat on what we held dear.

77?: But we never gave up once. We were never truly defeated. One day, they will be proven wrong, and they will be forced to admit it.

77?: My daughter, my precious little pearl.

77?: Come to me, back in your mother's arms. Let us return to a time before disputes and disasters, when it was just you and me wandering the boundless beach.

77?: I will share with you the infinite secrets of this world, the essence of all things, and the Truth that transcends everything.

77?: That's what you came for, yes?

Her eyes are earnest and sincere.

37 slowly climbs the stairs, longing to reach out and grasp her mother's hands.

She suddenly looks up, confused, and asks a question.

Thirty-seven: But, Mama.

Thirty-seven: I am 37, not infinity.

Thirty-seven: Why would I want an infinite number of secrets?

77?: ...!

Vertin: The ground is shaking.

Vertin: Did she give the wrong answer?

The cavern's illusory landscape shifts again.

A fierce wind abruptly rises around her.

Amidst the howling gale, 37 looks defiantly up into the air, her eyes peering past her mother's silhouette.

Thirty-seven: I don't long for the infinite secrets, for it is not within the scope of my number!

Thirty-seven: I know who I am. I am only 37, a finite number, a pebble in the sand. The tides could wash over me, engulf me, and crush me at any moment.

Thirty-seven: Even so, I am glad to be 37, for I know my limits, I know my boundaries—a concept the supreme existences cannot even fathom.

Her mother's shadow shatters, the shards shimmering and pulsing in the air as if they were alive.

The wind picks up, whipping her hair around and forcing her to narrow her eyes against the current.

But she stands her ground, refusing to yield.

Thirty-seven: Apeiron, the Boundless One! I am here for a simple question!

Thirty-seven: How can we escape the darkness of the phenomenal world, and be freed from the "Emanation" forever?

Her voice disappears into the wind, like a pebble sinking into a pond.

But then, the ripples echo back.

???: ...

???: A worthy reply.

???: Thou hast heeded thy boundaries. Through humility shall thou ascend to higher wisdom.

???: Thou shalt be answered.

???: ...

Thirty-seven: Ugh!

Incomprehensible sounds assault her ears, like ancient echoes rising from the depths of the ocean.

They aren't recognizable syllables of any known language, but more like reverberations between layers of rock walls, each note stabbing through her like a dagger.

Her breathing becomes labored and blood trickles from her nose.

Dizziness churns in her head, causing her vision to blur and double.

Thirty-seven: How ...? It clearly promised me an answer.

Thirty-seven: Is it because ... the answer to my question ... the transcendental Truth ...

Thirty-seven: ... is outside of our limits, too?

Cryptography Lead: Make way! Move!

Cryptography Lead: Madam Lucy, we have the right pronunciation!

Cryptography Lead: The scrip you gave me was correct. This is the arcane language of the incantation! Where did you get it?

Lucy: Very well. Give it to me.

Lucy: Inform all research teams that we are moving on to the next phase of the project.

Swift and sure footsteps stride past glass-walled rooms, stopping at the main control room of the "Storm" observation and research initiative.

The control station is bustling with activity as liaisons send messages through electrical signals and pneumatic tubes to various offices, all part of a well-oiled routine.

Enigma is here too.

Enigma: If you're here to check on the progress, there is none.

Enigma: I'm afraid you'll leave disappointed, Madam Lucy.

The robot hardly notices the mockery in his tone.

She approaches one of the liaisons and holds out her hand. In her palm is the scrip brought by the dove.

Lucy: Send this to everyone.

Lucy: It has been verified. This is the correct pronunciation of the immunity ritual.

Enigma: ... ?! This is ...

His hands tremble.

Despite its size, the tiny slip of paper holds great importance.

Following the pronunciation guidelines, he carefully spells out the first word.

Enigma: La unua ...

The scrip is taken from his grasp.

Standing next to him, the liaison holds the scrip in her hand, also trembling with excitement.

Liaison Staff I: We must share this with everyone.

She trots over to the control station.

The scrip is transposed onto the screen. The liaison meticulously checks every detail, ensuring that nothing is overlooked.

Liaison Staff I: La unua ... cirklo ...

Liaison Staff I: She reads into the microphone, her voice confident and clear. With a final press of the send button, she turns away with a satisfied smile on her face.

Liaison Staff I: Ahhh. Help!

Without warning, her torso cracks apart and her entire form crumbles, shattering to the ground in pieces.

Enigma: What was that?

Lucy: ...!

All hell breaks loose.

Chairs scrape loudly against the floor, coffee cups clatter to the ground, and people scramble about in a frenzy.

The director of Laplace remains still, her eyes fixed on the rapidly flashing lights on the screen.

Enigma: Stop the transmission! The ritual is wrong!!!

Lucy: ...

She pauses.

In the face of chaos and turmoil, it falls on someone to step up and take action.

Lucy: No.

Lucy: The incantation is indeed correct.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Returned to the Earth

7TH-10

Returned to the Earth

Cryptographer III: What is going on?

In other glass-walled rooms, researchers look up from their work in confusion.

The airlock doors have been sealed tight, and their electronic equipment is flashing erratically.

Broadcast: Warning, warning.

At the same time, all of their screens light up simultaneously, indicating the arrival of a new message.

Cryptographer IV: Hey, Dawkins, forget the outside, come look at this!

Cryptographer IV: Some guy's cracked it! They found the correct pronunciation!

Cryptographer III: For real?! They better be serious. If this is some kind of prank ...

Despite the blaring alarms, the staff gathers around their screens, eagerly reading aloud the incantation that was just sent.

Cryptographer III: La unua ... cirklo ...?

Laplace Hallway

Enigma: Damn it! Damn it! S**t!!!

He runs down the corridor at full speed, gasping for air. Just as the airlock doors begin to close, he flings himself through.

The closest room with glass walls is filled with thick white smoke.

He sprints to the door and frantically pounds on it.

Enigma: Ulrich! Dawkins! Victor! Richard! Are you in there?!

Enigma: Listen, if you receive the pronunciation of the incantation, do not recite it! Do not write it down! Do not pass it on!

Enigma: I know we've had our differences, but you have to trust me. I'm trying to save you!

A chilling silence looms on the opposite side of the door.

The only noise that can be heard is Lucy's emotionless voice coming through the speakers.

Broadcast: Warning, warning.

Broadcast: All personnel stay away from their communication terminals. Do not recite any messages on the screen.

Broadcast: Repeat. Do not recite the incantation. Do not recite the incantation. Do not recite ...

The door suddenly opens. The smoke pouring out nearly chokes him.

Enigma: *cough*

Enigma: Richard?

Cryptographer IV: ...

A cryptographer emerges from the thick smoke, his movements stiff and his face expressionless.

As he opens his mouth to speak, a small crack forms at the corner of his lips and quickly spreads across his entire face, as if he were made of clay.

Cryptographer IV: Daw—

Suddenly he collapses, his skin splitting and cracking like parched earth.

Enigma: RICHARD!

Enigma quickly moves to support him, preventing his colleague from breaking into pieces on the hard floor.

He checks his vitals—still alive; only his skin has been affected by the mutation. Underneath the cracked exterior, he can still see human flesh and blood.

Enigma: Don't speak. We're going to the rehab center!

Cryptographer IV: No ... You ... Go ... Daw ... kins ...

Lifting a muddy finger, he manages to point toward the room.

Slowly, a monumental figure emerges from the hazy entrance.

It is a mud golem, with thick clumps of mud dripping off its body.

The only remaining human element is Dawkins's nameplate, barely clinging to its chest.

Cryptographer III: Urh, urrrrrh.

Cryptographer III: I'm ...

Enigma: Dawkins! No, no. No!!

The airlock door at the end of the hallway hisses open. A squad of security guards with hypno bullets and restraint nets barge their way in.

Laplace Safety Officer: Researcher Adler, please evacuate immediately!

Laplace Safety Officer: We will take over from here!

Enigma: I thought the worst case would be that the ritual is useless, since no one here can wield it.

Enigma: I was wrong, so terribly wrong. The reality is a million times worse.

Enigma: We have invited a disaster. It is a curse—even more unpredictable, unstable, and uncontrollable than the mask!

He grips his hair tightly, his voice hoarse as he shouts.

Enigma: Dora crumbled to dust. Richard cracked like dry land, and Dawkins turned into a statue of mud.

Enigma: And Victor, he vanished. We've tried everything, but he's nowhere to be found. Yet he's here, typing, sending e-mails, getting the door for me.

Enigma: All of these catastrophic events, and only three words were uttered. Three.

He shakes his head and laughs bitterly, not even in the mood for mockery after all that's happened.

Enigma: What are we dealing with, Madam Lucy? Which deity are we provoking and stealing from?

No one can answer his question.

The security guards are busy cleaning up the mess, while liaisons are frantically issuing warnings and confirming the extent of the casualties.

The rehab center personnel have also arrived, and as they leave, their stretchers are filled with injured people.

His supervisor finishes up a call and hangs up the phone on the wall.

Lucy: Get some rest, Mr. Adler.

Lucy: Your mission is complete. Other researchers will take it from here.

Enigma: You what?

He asks in disbelief, anger swelling in his chest.

Enigma: Are you not going to call it off? After all that's happened?

Lucy: The research must go on.

The robot's answer is concise and cold.

Lucy: The authenticity of the incantation, and the fact that any arcanist can recite it, were revealed to us through this unexpected mishap.

Lucy: Now, a new question arises: how can we eliminate the side effects?

Lucy: From now on, we no longer require the help of human researchers.

Her tone is calm and gentle, yet with authority. The decision has been made.

Lucy: **Only arcanum can lift a curse of arcanum.**

Vertin: 37!

The eerie sounds continue to reverberate in the cave.

37 kneels on the transparent stairs, blood seeping from her mouth and nose.

Vertin: Stay with me! I'll get you out!

The suitcase. The noises wouldn't reach her in there.

It could be her refuge.

Thirty-seven: Uhm!

37 suddenly jerks. Slowly, an ornate scroll rises from her bosom.

Vertin: Is this 6's scroll?

The strange noises begin to fade.

In its place is an ancient melody.

Thirty-seven: +1, -1, +2, -3, 3, -3, +2, -1, +1 ...

Thirty-seven: I see. I understand now.

Vertin: What did you say? 37, are you feeling better now?

She nods, having regained her clarity.

Thirty-seven: They're numbers, Vertin.

Thirty-seven: 6's scroll reconciled the gap between the supreme existence and me. I can now hear and understand.

Thirty-seven: The answer to my question, the solution to free us from the "Emanation," the response Apeiron promised me ...

Thirty-seven: ... is a string of numbers.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Funeral Postponement Notice

小径

Funeral Postponement Notice

> We regret to report tragic news today—a large number of researchers have been injured and even killed in an accident caused by the spread of "Storm" immunity incantations. Due to special emergency management regulations, the funerals of the deceased personnel will be temporarily postponed. Please remember the names of the victims, remember their sacrifice, and remember that our research is not over:
>
> Dora, Evans, Gary—obliterated
>
> ...
>
> Richard, Vincent—skin transformed
>
> Dawkins—entire body turned to mud, lost the ability to speak
>
> Victor—disappeared from existence, no longer physically detectable
>
> Margaret—shrunk
>
> Louis—dissolved into a puddle of goo

The Rolling Boulder

7TH-11

The Rolling Boulder

The winds died down. The cave is quiet again.

The trial is over. As usual, the Star of Hermes has found her answer.

Thirty-seven: We got it! The key to the gate of Truth!

Thirty-seven: Apeiron has answered me! This is the final solution!

She chirps with delight as the scroll completes its task and lands back in her hand.

Thirty-seven: We must leave here at once. We have to tell everyone!

Vertin: I am so proud of you, 37.

Vertin: We will save everyone.

There is finally room to breathe, if only for a brief moment.

Yet, the feeling of unease remains.

Vertin: But there's one thing I don't understand.

Thirty-seven: And that is?

She pauses mid-step and looks back, tilting her head inquisitively.

Vertin: 6. His scroll saved your life.

Vertin: Maybe he foresaw the dangers and protected you from it, so you can leave there almost unharmed.

Vertin: But what was he trying to tell you,

Vertin: when he warned you about "the collapse of your world as you know it"?

Underground Passageway, the Island

Six: ...

888: ...

210: ...

The walk to the cleansing site is long.

Only the sounds of dripping water and soft footsteps can be heard in the tunnel.

Believer II: Mind your step, everyone. We are passing the Wall of Truth.

Believer II: The wall will come crashing down if false words are spoken. Silence is advised here, unless circumstances dictate otherwise.

The followers nod with respect.

They have walked past the Walls of Silence, Goodness, and Wisdom respectively as part of the ritual.

Only those who embody these virtues can find safe passage to the final cleansing.

Believer II: 888?

The Custodian suddenly steps up in front of the leader, blocking his path.

888: Forgive me, but this seems to be the right moment,

888: for some long-neglected questions to be answered.

Six: ...

As she speaks, a few others emerge from the crowd and surround 6.

On the narrow pathway, there is no way to get around them.

Six: Perhaps. But hardly appropriate or righteous.

888: We will talk of righteousness after you've shared what you know, 6.

888: You've been silent for too long. Four years have passed since you became 6, and for four years, you have been hiding things from us.

888: The long-neglected questions have created a cloud of doubt between us. And now, the boulder of fate is falling on us, and we are teetering on the brink of destruction. It's time to be honest and true to your people—while you still have them.

888: We are the seekers of Truth. It is unjust to keep us from it.

888 extends an arm, gesturing to the silent cavern walls that surround them.

888: Let the Wall of Truth bear witness! I want nothing but an answer from you. I am not here to provoke untimely conflicts.

The wall stands firm. The genuineness of her words is not to be doubted.

210: Answer her, 6. You should be glad that I am not the interrogator here, because the wall would have collapsed immediately.

The wall remains silent, seemingly confirming the rhetorician's mocking words as truth.

Six: ...

210: You may lie, but the wall will fall. You may stay silent, then I will lie to break the silence and the wall.

210: Or maybe you could outwit the wall with the liar's paradox. Only sadly, I have tested it for you —one cannot deceive it by stating "I'm lying."

210: After all, it's a test of morality, not logic. It needs your honesty, not your wit or anything else.

It's a delicate situation, one that requires precision. The leader remains composed.

Six: What do you wish to know?

210: What else? The most important question, of course—the question about the essence.

210 takes a step, his voice trembling, no longer as calm as he used to be.

These questions have plagued his mind for too long.

210: Why has our research stagnated for the past four years? Why did we fail to predict the "Emanation" in 1929 and again in this time?

210: Have we misunderstood the premise? What if the "Emanation" is not a manifestation of the transcendental Law at all?

6 remains stoic, showing no signs of emotion.

Six: Worshipers worship. Thinkers think. Governors govern, and researchers research. Your questions are not mine to answer, 210.

Six: A 6 has no expertise on the study of the "Emanation." I am not qualified to answer about its essence.

A truth is spoken, and the silent wall attests to its veracity.

888: Your question is too abstract, 210.

The Custodian shakes her head and takes a step closer.

888: Don't dance around the subject, 6.

888: The wisdom has been passed on to you, as it has to every other 6. You have inherited not only knowledge and insight, but also the memories of your predecessors.

888: You must know the answer, for it is part of your inheritance.

888: Tell us this: the last leader of the study of the "Emanation," 77—what question did she bring to Apeiron, and what answer did she receive?

There's no immediate response, confirming that she's hit the nail on the head.

888: I watched her walk into the cave and come out unharmed.

888: I watched her and the previous 6 board the ship in search of answers in the phenomenal world. The ship didn't come back in time. The "Emanation" caught them.

888: And that was only the beginning of our misfortunes.

888: The model failed. Our whereabouts were revealed. Hysteria now poisons the minds of our people, and the empirical knowledge accumulated over the years suddenly no longer applies to the current situation. Why?

888: What did she find out? Could it be ...

888: ... that something's happened to the transcendental Law above? Has the Truth we believed in changed?

Six: ...

Barraged with so many questions, he lets out a chuckle.

He smiles with relief, like a prisoner finally receiving his death sentence after years of waiting.

It has the opposite effect on the crowd. They hold their breaths in suspense.

Six: Hippasus discovered the secrets of √2 and toppled Pythagoras's school of thought.

Six: The controversy surrounding Newton and infinitesimals presented a challenge to the groundwork of calculus.

Six: Russell's self-referential paradox sparked the third mathematical crisis. Though set theory was eventually perfected, the lessons on self-referentiality remained.

Six: In the end, Gödel's incompleteness theorems showed that proving or disproving everything is impossible, therefore absolute knowledge is unattainable.

His profound sentiments echo throughout the cave.

Six: The boulder of fate will tumble down its peak, whether 37 is the one pushing it or not.

Six: However hard Oedipus tried to defy destiny, his path to tragedy remained unchanged.

888: You're talking in riddles again.

She furrows her brow. However, 6 gives her a small nod of respect.

Six: I should thank you for bringing the question here, 888, so I may finally speak the truth.

Six: 77 did ask about the essence of the "Emanation."

He stands tall and looks around at the people.

They're listening intently.

Six: She asked, "What happened to the supreme existence? What plunged the world into madness?"

Six: The answer was "Disorder and chaos."

888: ...!

The Wall of Truth still stands. The trial left behind by the ancient sages confirms his words.

A deep, ominous rumble comes from the center of the island.

The tremors are like the island is being shaken to its core, like a tsunami and a volcanic eruption combined.

210: You blasted ...!

210 is the first to come to a realization. He lunges and grabs 6 by the collar.

210: You knew this all along? From the first day of your "Revelation," when you became 6???

210: You knew that the "Emanation" was not a manifestation of the transcendental Law and patterns above, but rather a symptom of its utter disorder and chaos?!

210: And you knew that the transcendental realm of numbers was no more, and that the essence of pneuma, the one true Form we believed in, had become an ever-changing existence like the irrational numbers?!

Rage threatens to consume him. The rhetorician glares at the leader, who has the audacity to confirm that their faith is shattered. He almost breaks into a bitter laugh.

210: Four years! You kept this to yourself for four years. Why?!

210: Was it for a false sense of peace? To keep the island stable? Did you deceive us to prevent the realization that our research would be in vain?

6 does not answer the added inquiries, for they are not within his duty.

888: It's time to halt the bickering. Get everyone out of here now!

The Custodian steps in and separates them with a stern look. She then turns and begins to lead the panicked crowd to safety.

Amidst the chaos, the leader lowers his eyes and reads the verses prepared for the ceremony.

Six: "Pray to the gods for what you are about to do, and pray that all goes well."

"Once familiar with this practice, you will understand
the constitution of both eternal gods and mortal men."

Sophia: Uhm!

Sophia: What happened? Did they not carry out the cleansing ceremony?

"You will know the extent of all things, the boundaries
of their entirety, and what connects them together."

Regulus: Whoa, what's going on?! An earthquake?

Sonetto: No. This is ...

Sonetto: The large-scale ritual on this island is undoing itself!?

"You will see, as you should, that the nature
of the universe flows in all things alike."

Thirty-seven: Why?

Thirty-seven: Why is our circle gone?

The leader stands quiet and resolute, like a rock by the sea.

Watching the fall of the heavenly transcendental, feeling the tides of change wash over everything.

Six: "Thus you will not hope for what is beyond your reach, and you will not be deceived."

He rolls up the scroll and ends his reading.

Six: Pray, my friends.

Six: Pray for yourselves, and pray for everyone. Pray for all the suffering and misery around you.

Six: Reach into the unseeable darkness and pray to the unknowable supreme. Speak your hopes, for you are a finite creature yearning to transcend its own existence.

Six: The determination that once helped us overcome our insignificance and touch the light of pneuma, should guide us once more.

In the darkness, he lights up a torch.

888: Where are you going?

Six: To the cave.

Six: The trial is not over. The final cleansing is yet to come. There are still duties to fulfill.

He trudges forward.

With his back to the fearful crowd, he sets off again, onto the lonely road, into the long night.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Q&A

小径

Here is a well known question you must have heard: "What goes on four legs in the morning, two in the afternoon, and three in the evening?" it's so well "known" that no one finds it novel anymore.

But please do me a favor and answer me yourself.

Choices

1. "A human being"

2. Let's talk about the questioner instead.

Branch 1

Correct! This is the same answer Oedipus gave to defeat Sphinx. Thus becoming a hero, but also starting him on his ill-fated destiny.

Raise a question, give an answer. This is the most fundamental ritual. Through this, we get nearer to God.

Branch 2

The Sphinx, an embodiment of mercy and nobility in Egypt, was seen as a mystery to the Greeks: a dangerous being that kept secrets, and delivered the punishments of the gods.

When the question is answered, the ritual is finished, and the answerer is granted the right to reach the treasure it guards.

Choices

1. Ritual?

Yes, a ritual. Whether it is by pouring out wine; slaughtering a calf; or circling round a fire with a baby in your arms... It is an agreement; a question that demands an answer.

Every desire has a price. Whether it is paid in wine, blood, or fire, but sometimes that sacrifice is taken from you without it ever being noticed.

And the treasure you seek might be the undoing of your own desires.

Let us take a look at another question: "Stranger, what's your name?" Cried Polyphemus.

"Nobody!" Odysseus answered, and it allowed him to flee the cyclops' cave, safe and sound.

A human being and nobody, two answers that could not be more alike, yet both were bound to fate by their answer.

Alright, dear, time to call it a day. As for you? You'll get the answers you seek, you've already paid the price.

Shared continuation

Q&A

Assistant's Record

小径

Assistant's Record

※ Walking on the beach with Marta. She's almost done with her tour of the island, collecting material for her travelogue. I accompany her, also to remind her to avoid the important areas we don't want to be exposed to the outside world. She is hoping for even more reading recommendations. Fine, I'll consult 210 and Sophia.

※ There are too many outsiders here. That's not necessarily a bad thing, but it makes management more difficult. The leader's strategy isn't the best at the moment—we must make clearer decisions. We need to show some self-determination. By repeatedly emphasizing our united will, faith will also be strengthened. Relying on anyone won't work, nor can we put all our hopes in one child and then sit back in satisfaction …

It's impossible for the island to remain peaceful all the time; when it's necessary, it always falls to me to do something.

※ She should have noticed the error, or … well, I don't believe that a person like 77 would not check the course again and calculate the angles. Even if she is too tired, 37 is still on the island … Why didn't Hugh take his notebook with him? I saw it at Sophia's place. She left in such a hurry that even her reason for leaving seemed like an excuse. Could communicating with this supreme being really destroy a person's mind?

This is all so strange.

※ This guy talks a lot. Fortunately, he's also pretty useful. And surprisingly, he thinks the same way as me. I thought he was the one who agreed most with the others. In fact, his speculations are closer to my own …

If I become an assistant, I might be able to learn more. This position has been vacant for too long… A shield without a sword is ultimately unreliable. Now is the time. No matter what they say, I will apply.

210 also believes that 77 has the answer.

What will the answer bring? (smudge marks)

—I need to get to the bottom of this.

Wine Brewing Season

小径

Wine Brewing Season

—Bang!
In the distance, something falls.
The cup drains the wine,
Tired eyes dry out the sun.
Everyone clings to the remaining days,
The body speaks to its guest.

Who builds, also uses the same hand
To destroy, to peel open the rock walls,
The scar is a perfect circle.
A death tied with a knot, thus
—The end.

Only it remains:
The wilderness.
Everything extraneous, swarming in,
Just like that, they talk about a bottomed sky.

The Party of Beans

7TH-12

The Party of Beans

One, abstain from beans.
Two, do not pick up what has fallen.
Three, touch not a white rooster.

Vertin: Hmm.

Vertin: Where am I?

After a long period of darkness, clarity begins to dawn.

Ahead lies a completely unfamiliar scene.

Vertin: Did the earthquake do this?

Vertin: I was in the cave with 37.

Vertin: Is the timer broken?

Regulus: Hey, Vertin! Here you are!

A familiar shout is heard in the distance.

Regulus: Yeah. Come! People are waiting. The feast is going to start!

Vertin: Feast?

Regulus: Yes. Today's the big day!

Regulus: We're celebrating because we kicked Manus Vindictae off the island, found the key to "Storm" immunity, and saved the "numbers people" from great disaster!

Vertin: What?

But Regulus has already taken off.

Regulus: Come on, Vertin! You'll miss out on the delicious honey-roasted rabbit!

She jumps forward excitedly, but something cracks loudly when she lands.

Vertin: Wait, Regulus! You just kicked over something.

Regulus: What? What is it? Something for the cattle? Whoever left this here nearly tripped this great captain!

Regulus: Forget it. Come, Vertin! What are you still doing there!

Four, do not poke the fire with swords.
Five, do not jump over a crossbar.
Six, do not cut wood on a main road.

The square is alive with joy and activity. The usual silence and seriousness have been replaced by a symphony of giggles and cheers.

The aroma of roast rabbit is thick in the air. Barrels of wine are being rolled around, and people are gathered, drinking and chatting merrily.

Lilya: Ah! Nice wine. Did you make it yourself?

210: Careful, Ms. Lilya. Too much wine can corrupt one's body and will. Besides, you are already halfway through our stock for the year.

210: Hmm, but this drink you brought is pleasant to the nose. "Coffee," you said? I have heard many things about it.

210: Oh, oh, bitter.

Lilya: Hah, poor guy! I was expecting more from a man of your size!

She goes to a barrel to fill her cup.

Lilya: For god's sake, Regulus! Keep an eye on your first mate here.

Lilya: Wow. He is so out of it right now.

APPLe: *burp*

APPLe: It appears that this APPLe's abstinence from the bottle will have to begin anew.

Thirty-seven: Vertin! Finally! I was looking for you!

37 waves from a distance, Sophia at her side, arm in arm.

Thirty-seven: Hello, everyone! We have a big announcement to make.

Thirty-seven: Sophia's just completed her proof and found her number!

Wings flap from above.

Vertin: Uhm!

Seven, do not enter the hall in new garments.
Enter the hall from the right
and leave from the left.
Eight, do not keep swallows around your house.

Thirty-seven: Oh, don't worry about the swallows! They're going to fetch 6 for us.

Thirty-seven: He's napping in the Hall of Apeiron—an excuse to not join the party.

Sophia: Not so fast with the announcement, 37! People will find out sooner or later.

Sophia: Thank you for helping us, Vertin. We wouldn't have made it without you.

Sophia: And I look forward to our continued collaboration with the Foundation.

Vertin: No. None of this makes any sense.

Nine, do not sleep on a grave.
Ten, make the bed as soon as you wake up,
leaving no imprint of your body.

Regulus: Oh. Enough business! People are having a party here!

The pirate comes over with a platter of rabbits, smiling as if England had just won the World Cup.

Regulus: Well, what do you say to this lovely captain who just picked up some food for you?

Sonetto: Uhm!

They clumsily collide, knocking over the tray in Regulus's hand.

Sonetto: My apologies, Regulus. I was too focused on linear regression formulas.

Regulus: Ahh, that's alright. Wasn't me getting stuck in the kitchen roasting rabbits all day anyway! Unlimited supply of honeyed rabbits, all day today!

Regulus picks up the dirty clay plate and puts it aside.

Sonetto: I heard Sophia is making her announcement today. I'm curious which number she will be.

Regulus: Care to wager on that? I'd say she's a multiple of 3!

Sonetto: Mm. Then I'd say she is a multiple of 139.

Thirty-seven: I have to admit, she has a good number!

Thirty-seven: A number 100 times better than me, 6, and 210 put together!

Ms. Radio: Calculating ... (37+6+210)*100 equals to ...

210: Oh no. She is not 25300. I doubt anyone could live with themselves with a number that long.

???: *rooster crow*

A rooster crows loudly in the festive atmosphere.

Sophia: You haven't met before. This is Amu, my white rooster.

She kneels down and gently strokes its feathers.

Sophia: Amu, this is Vertin.

Three, touch not
a white rooster.

Vertin: A white rooster?

Cheers and shouts fill the air as people revel in jubilant euphoria.

A Foundation employee picks up an ID from the ground.

Two, do not pick up
what has fallen.

An Apeiron believer splits a log in half on the road, earning enthusiastic applause from the crowd.

Six, do not cut wood
on a main road.

The tables are filled with chickpea salad and neatly sliced bread, while people use their swords to poke fires and keep them burning.

One, abstain from beans.
Four, do not poke the fire
with swords.

The flames burn fiercely, casting no shadows on the ground.

Vertin: Something's not right. None of this is right!

Vertin: Something's happened on the island. I must still be in the cave!

A churning anxiety fills the chest. The once-joyful scene now takes on a surreal quality.

Vertin: I have to get out of here!

The Wave of Art

7TH-13

The Wave of Art

Military Station, 1914

Soldier I: F**k! When do they give us the order to attack?

Soldier I: What's taking so long? The island is just across the bay. We have men, weapons, supplies, everything. Just give us order, and we will take to shore.

Soldier I: Check out these bad boys. Anti-arcanum weapons, courtesy of the American from that "Walden" place.

Soldier I: That creep just doesn't sit right with me. He's got that arcanist stink about him.

Soldier I: But his technology's solid, and we needed it. We've got to get ahead of the Serbs and the Greeks!

This army has been stationed here for a long time, perhaps too long.

The soldiers, stranded and demoralized by their failed landing, face days of uncertainty without orders while politicians bicker. They are left to heat their food meal by meal, watching their chances slip away.

Soldier II: Relax, Georgiy. Leave the decisions to the big shots. I'm sure they'll just hug out their differences in the meeting room or something.

Soldier II: Besides, you saw the monsters on that island. Can't speak for everyone here, but I don't want to die.

Soldier I: Screw the negotiations, screw the committee! Like it or not, we were the first ones to find the island! Not the Austrians or the Germans!

He grumbles and picks the monocular back up, straining to catch another glimpse of the island across the waters.

The sea is tranquil, as it often is this time of year. The water sparkles under the golden sun, stretching to the horizon without an island in sight.

Soldier I: Damn, those arcanists have gone into hiding again.

Soldier I: I swear I could see it from here yesterday.

Soldier I: Hm?

He blinks, unsure if his eyes are tricking him.

Soldier I: Are those bird-like creatures leaving in droves?

His words barely catch anyone's attention. A new poker game is underway on the supply crate.

A radio, a couple of beers, and a game of poker—a rare moment of enjoyment. Who could ask for more?

Soldier II: Georgiy, brother, leave them be. Come, play with us.

Soldier II: Georgiy?

The soldier does not seem to hear his name.

He grips the monocular tightly, his mouth contorting as he mutters.

Soldier I: What a good opportunity this is. It's too good to pass up. We, we've got to act now.

A drop of vibrant paint slides down his cheek and lands on the ground with a splatter.

Soldier I: We will claim what is ours. This island belongs to us. It's in our territory, and we were the first to find it—why shouldn't it be ours!?

The card players pause, gawking at the paint sliding down each other's faces, unaware that their own faces are melting as well.

In the silence, the only sound that fills the air is the static of the radio.

Broadcast: The Austro-Hungarian Empire has officially declared war on Serbia.

Broadcast: Russia is mobilizing in support of Serbia. Germany demands Russia to stop mobilizing at once.

Broadcast: Germany is mobilizing. France is mobilizing.

Kakania: *panting*

Ring Road

The street has turned into a canvas of mesmerizing hues. The colorful paints swirl and burst, creating one spiral after another.

It's almost like the stage set of a twisted carnival.

Kakania: Father, Mother! Elbert! Ilse!

Kakania: Open the door! It's important! You have to listen to me!

She pounds on the door, but as soon as she makes contact, the door softens and melts like butter.

She trips through the door, but quickly recoils at the horror inside.

The art and specimens, once delicate and exquisite, now resemble a jumble of spilled paint.

Kakania: No, no. This can't be.

Kakania: Elbert?

Still with a glimmer of hope, she carefully calls out to her brother.

Elbert: Klara? It's odd to see you so flustered. What's the matter?

The familiar voice brings immense relief to her heart.

Elbert: I'm headed to the business school. We'll talk when I get back.

Elbert picks up the hat and adjusts the brim. The pin on the hat, "Vingler's Shop," shimmers in the dim light.

Thank goodness, he seems to be fine.

He's still the reliable brother she remembers, the family's pride, in his sharp three-piece suit.

Kakania: Business school?

Kakania: But, didn't you swear to never go back? Ever since your human classmate shot your arm in a duel.

Kakania: Wait, what happened to your arm?

He turns around, and Kakania can finally see.

Half of his suit is covered in colors, paint trailing down his face and pooling at his feet.

An arm of flowing colors is attached to his body, like a mismatched puzzle piece.

Elbert: Oh, Ethan. Yes, he wounded me. He had to prove his standing to the brotherhood. There was no other way.

Elbert: But that's in the past. He gave me his arm, so now we're even.

He raises his left hand to show her the blade. Streaks of blood are still on it.

He casually tosses it aside, letting it clatter into the darkness and disappear into the swirls of colors.

Elbert grabs his walking stick, his new arm dangling lifelessly at his side.

Elbert: I have to go. I have to find Johnson, Raymond, and Herbert. That little rascal pushed Ilse into the fountain. We have a score to settle.

Elbert: Take care, Klara.

He strides past her and hails a carriage with triangles for wheels at the door.

Kakania: No, Elbert! Don't go!

She runs to stop the carriage, but it is unaffected by her efforts, like everything else in this place.

A set of footsteps approach from behind.

Marcus: The Storm Syndrome is spreading, doctor! Stay any longer, you'll be infected, too!

Marcus: Please, leave with me. Oh!

The trembling ground interrupts her.

A mob with distorted faces swarms through the streets, chanting slogans and singing in their own tongues.

White pro-war pamphlets litter the ground, like snowflakes being absorbed into a mire of effervescent paints.

The city is bursting with unrelenting energy, like a speeding chariot or a twirling powder keg.

Kakania: The sign bearer in the parade ... Is that Aurora?

Kakania: I just met her at the coffee house last week. We were talking about her wedding.

Marcus: Watch out, doctor!

A sign crashes to the ground beside them.

Rage-filled citizens are tearing the streets apart. Even the handles of roadside benches are yanked off and made a weapon.

The fervent protest consumes all who come across it, forcing them to participate with no option to decline.

Marcus: This is bad. They have lost their minds!

Marcus: This way, doctor. We have to get out of here!

Marcus: This way, doctor! We have to go back to your clinic. The special operations squad will meet us there.

The young investigator holds the doctor's hand, determined to do her duty.

But the doctor halts her steps and droops her head, looking dejected.

Kakania: Marcus. You once said that there was another way to make things right.

Kakania: And then you did your part, as I did mine.

Kakania: But now, after all that's happened, please tell me, what's the point of us trying?

Kakania: Will we save them in time? Is there any chance that we can turn things around?

She struggles to hold back a sob.

The roaring crowd fades into the distance, and the Ring Road of yesterday is now but a distant memory, never to be relived.

Kakania: The ritual you acquired, the one you said could save everyone, is it working now?

Enigma: Let me in.

Laplace Hallway

The floor in Laplace's corridor has lost its clean, silvery sheen.

Dawkins and his slobbering mud certainly played a major role in the destruction. The guards used every cleaning orb in their inventory to restore even a hint of its original glory.

A pair of angry feet stomp across the floor, ignoring their colleague's attempts to stop them. Enigma adds more muddy footprints without hesitation.

Enigma: I have just one question.

Enigma: Why hasn't the project stopped yet?

His outcry elicits a reaction.

The door to the director's office flings open, and an angry figure storms out.

Cryptography Lead: Adler Hofmann, you have been removed from the team. You're not authorized to be here!

Cryptography Lead: You have violated ...

Enigma: The LSCC Safety Management Regulations? I brought them with me. You're welcome.

He throws the hefty manual right onto his former leader's face.

Enigma: If you cared about the regulations as much as you claim, you'd know that none of what's happening aligns with its guidelines.

Enigma: Even the head of Laplace has no authority to continue the experiment under these circumstances!

Before he can continue, his ex-leader sharply cuts him off.

Cryptography Lead: Get out of my face, Adler. I don't have time for this. We're in a state of war!

Cryptography Lead: Every participant has signed an informed consent form. If you are not part of this project, please leave immediately!

Cryptography Lead: We only have 18 hours until the "Storm." This is it—the first time we've made such a breakthrough in all nine "Storms"!

Cryptography Lead: Your sister gave up her life to take us this far. I hope you don't need me to remind you that!

Adler Hofmann is abruptly silent.

A fiery rage ignites in his hazel eyes.

A deafening void engulfs the space as Ulrich realizes his verbal blunder.

Enigma: Yes. She made the ultimate sacrifice, hoping that it would lead to a breakthrough. But instead, death continues to rise.

Enigma: How can you let this go on?

He charges ahead, shoving Ulrich aside with his elbow.

Ulrich's head slams against the wall, ferrofluids shifting erratically inside.

Enigma: I demand to know why the experiment is still going!

He starts working on the padlock on the door. Nothing's going to stop him from breaking through today.

The alarm goes off. Ulrich struggles to his feet against the wall, a hand up to his head.

Cryptography Lead: Ugh, don't we have enough crazies around here?!

Cryptography Lead: Madam Lucy has important things to do. She has no time for you! Go cry to your therapist, human!

Enigma: Important? What could be possibly more important than this, right now?

Enigma: What happened to the humanitarian ideals of the Foundation? Are we now under the tyranny of machines?

Enigma: What's this important thing she's got to do? Reading the paper, sipping on oil, and charging up in a 230-volt bath?

He cracks the code. Pushing Ulrich's arms aside, Enigma forces his way into the room.

The room is completely dark.

Tchk-tchk-tchk.

A piston spins at his feet.

Lucy: Is that you, Adler?

Lucy: Welcome.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Seven Years of Bad Luck

小径

Look at this mirror, dear. There's a sizable stain on it.

Choices

1. It's broken.

2. I don't see any stains.

Branch 1

Yes, it is. Maybe its owner meant to break it so that the stain would be thoroughly removed.

Now the stain is gone, and the owner has a collection of little mirrors. She must have accidentally left this one behind.

Branch 2

Look closer, dear. You can no longer see the part that has broken off, but you can see where it once was. Right there, a sizable stain.

The owner thought the stain would be removed if she smashed the mirror. Now she has a collection of little mirrors, and the stain has gone into hiding.

Choices

1. Whose mirror is this?

A lady with great ambitions and an unconscious charm. A lady who wishes to make the rest of the world accept who she is, and has suggested that many others join her way of thinking.

Her brother, on the contrary, hopes to be taken in. In his attempt to act like everyone else, he lost an arm in a duel.

If you ask me, dear, I'd say they're very alike. Equally lonely.

The brother and sister are a mirror image of each other. She's often repulsed by the sight of him, unable to reconcile herself with all that he reminds her of.

Now, the brother has found his missing arm, along with his long-lost dignity. The surgery that the sister had been hoping would be done on this world has finally started. But all of a sudden, she's terrified of the incisions.

As I said, despite their differences in approach, the brother and sister are mirror images of one another.

But now the mirror is broken. I hope she can make it through the seven years of bad luck. Poor thing. There's no way around it.

Shared continuation

Seven Years of Bad Luck

A Sandstorm in a Room

7TH-14

A Sandstorm in a Room

The piston rotates on the floor like a toy top.

Lucy: Hmm. I am not in a suitable form to receive a guest.

Lucy: Simone, can you put me back in my body?

Her assistant rushes over and puts her into a robot body.

Lucy: I feel much better. Thank you.

Lucy: Oh, you have even put on a face for me. How sweet of you.

Enigma: ...

Lucy: I have noticed your icy gaze, Researcher Adler. You are yearning to correct the logic of this place.

Lucy: Well, I only said that to Simone out of courtesy. In reality, whichever body I am put into makes no difference to me.

Her ill-timed explanation annoys him even more.

Enigma: The experiment, ma'am. Why hasn't it stopped?

Enigma: Are you going to pretend that nothing's happened? That no one died?

Enigma: Could it be that you and Ulrich, "the Awakened," being the tin cans you are, have no regard for actual lives?

Cryptography Lead: Adler Hofmann, I will not warn you again ...

Ulrich storms back into the room with two guards, ready to throw him out at any moment.

Lucy: Relax, Adler. You are led by a biased opinion because you lack critical information. A common defect in all cognitive processes.

Lucy: I believe you will shift to a more rational perspective once you receive sufficient information on the subject.

Enigma: "A more rational perspective"?!

The human, known for his logical thinking, responds with an overwhelming amount of feeling.

Enigma: We are humans, not machines! We are not expendable parts!

Enigma: I have plenty of reasons to question your decisions. Your excessive insistence on this experiment could be a sign of uncontrollable behavior, a trait commonly seen in arcanists.

Lucy: The experiment has been canceled everywhere.

Lucy: Except for this very room.

Enigma: What?

The robot flashes a smile, as if anticipating the man to be pleased with her response.

Lucy: As you and Researcher Medicine Pocket have said, the ritual is beyond the limits of almost everyone here. The side effects will kill them before the ritual can even take effect.

Lucy: The first wave was inevitable. Dora had pressed send before she disintegrated. We only managed to halt the subsequent transmissions, and evacuate the unaffiliated staff.

Lucy: We kept only a few arcanists on the team, and each has signed the consent form.

Mutual consent. That bloody form again.

Enigma: Forgive me, ma'am, but I have to use your argument against you.

Enigma: You, too, are guided by a biased opinion—an overly optimistic one—because you have failed to properly assess the risks involved. We have suffered enough misfortunes just by uttering a few syllables of the incantation!

Enigma: We've talked about the "limit" of things before. You should know better and ask the rest of the team to quit the experiment. Your insistence will only bring calamity upon calamity on our people, for nothing!

The researcher fights to stay calm, reiterating his views he had already shouted in the hallway.

Ulrich begins his retort, but the director simply nods in agreement.

Lucy: Hm. You might be right.

Lucy: But how is "being right" going to help us?

Enigma: Huh?

She grins, trying for a warm, gentle smile, but it comes across as anything but.

Enigma despised that face. Every time she tried to show a hint of humanity, it only served to highlight how different she was from everyone else.

Lucy: You spoke of the "limit."

Lucy: And I am surprised that it is you who brought it up.

Enigma pauses for a second, not sure if she's being sarcastic.

Lucy: The physical appearance of humans has remained relatively unchanged since the Neolithic era, but their thoughts and civilization continued to evolve and underwent significant transformations.

Lucy: The achievements that humanity enjoys today were not given to the species by any one person with godlike powers, but were the result of the collective efforts of all human beings.

Lucy: Limits and boundaries must be pushed, or there would never have been room for development. There is no reason to believe that the limit cannot be challenged, especially when we already have the tools to do so.

Lucy: We must make progress happen.

Enigma: Grandiose lies.

Lucy: Lies?

Oh, crap. He forgot about her excellent hearing.

Lucy: We have no choice but to go beyond that limit.

Lucy: If we do not break away from the "Storm," there is no future for us, let alone progress.

Lucy: We need to first determine all the side effects as a priority. This important step will help us compile data and eliminate the effects, so our colleagues can use the ritual safely.

Enigma: And who will try it this time, Madam Lucy? You're not going to test the side effects at the cost of lives, are you?

Lucy: No. Thanks to Ulrich, we stumbled upon a breakthrough.

Lucy: You are right. It is time to send the other arcanists home. Only the Awakened are needed here.

Enigma: The Awakened?

The tungsten wires glow faintly red in the dark, then the room is lit.

Assistant Simone: The power is back, ma'am. We are ready to resume.

Lucy: Hm. It will take time to properly explain.

Lucy: Please wait, Adler. We have yet to reach an agreement.

Enigma: What? Are you experimenting? Here?

Ignoring his surprise, Lucy sits down on the iron bench.

Wires of various sizes are attached to her body.

The instrument comes to life to the piston's rhythm, faithfully recording every change in the robot.

From her slightest movements to arcane fluctuations, nothing goes unnoticed.

Lucy: ...

Lucy: La unua ...

Enigma: Wait. She's reciting it?

Frozen in place by the scene, he looks around the room in disbelief.

Enigma: She's read the reports, right? She was there when Dora broke into pieces!

Lucy: ...

Lucy: ...

Rarely does her back curl up like this.

The usual cheerful expression on her face has changed to one of unease, suggesting that something is amiss.

A hunk of metal should not feel pain. They have no flesh, no nerves.

But if she is in agony, what could be the cause of such torment?

Lucy: ... Urrm ...

Will she break apart, too? Like those people?

The ominous "curse" has set its sights on its prey.

It watches, almost like Zeus on a mountaintop, ready to unleash lightning on the mortals who dare to steal fire.

Lucy: No, Simone ... I ...

Lucy: I cannot ... continue ...

Lucy: Urgh ... Urrh ...

The most primal, instinctual fear.

This is the first time he's ever heard her emotions pour out so raw.

Enigma: You fools, don't just stand there! Stop her! Now!

Panic and horror twist in his stomach. He has an irresistible urge to rip out the wires and put an end to her torture.

Enigma: Who's going to lead us if she also turns into a pile of scraps?!

Cryptography Lead: Stay where you are, Enigma!

Ulrich's voice, full of animosity, comes from behind.

Cryptography Lead: You insisted on being here. You demanded to see this.

Cryptography Lead: **Don't bring your pathetic, narrow-minded humanitarian values in here and tell us what to do. What do you know about us?**

Simone leans over to her. She speaks softly.

Assistant Simone: You can do it, madam. This is just part of the established procedures.

Assistant Simone: Just a few more syllables, madam, and it will be over.

Lucy: Established ... procedures ...

Fear ebbs away a little as she repeats those words.

Lucy: I like ... that ...

Her eyes close. She forces out the last word with great determination.

Lucy: Cir ... klo.

It is done.

A clear, accurate, impeccable read.

Right at that moment, the lights in the lab go out.

Lucy: *sigh* Was that all, Simone?

Assistant Simone: Yes.

No one can see her face in the darkness.

But Enigma believes it to be a smile.

Lucy: Good.

Enigma: ...!

A gust of sand rises in the room.

Without warning and out of nowhere, it screams through the enclosed darkness.

The raging storm engulfs the robot's cold metal body, carrying her away with great force.

When the sand subsides, all that remains is an old piston, clattering to the ground.

"Clang."

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Pioneers

7TH-15

The Pioneers

Enigma: ...

A deathly silence.

Until Enigma stumbles back, nearly falling over another person in the room.

Enigma: She's dead?

The piston lies motionless on the ground, as lifeless as any other object.

Enigma: This is what you wanted to show me?

His heart pounds in his ears as he pants, fists clenched and slick with sweat.

Enigma: To watch her utter a curse that's always brought death, only to die in vain?

Enigma: And you just let it happen?!

Ulrich looks at him, his voice poised and steady.

Cryptography Lead: Calm down.

Enigma: Calm down? She's dead, right there! You murderer!

Cryptography Lead: We have already repeated this experiment many times.

Enigma is in disbelief.

Enigma: "Many times"? What?! You've sent people to their deaths over and over again?

The ferrofluid flows again, forming a shape that Enigma can only interpret as disdain.

Cryptography Lead: Look at you, Adler, peeing your pants over a "curse." The human boy is so scared that he forgot to ask the crucial question—

Cryptography Lead: Did the ritual work?

Enigma: What, what do you mean? The curse, the side effect killed her. The experiment failed. Is that not what happened?

Cryptography Lead: No, triggering the curse and failure are two separate things. I was the first one to recite the incantation. Way before Dora.

Cryptography Lead: When I read it aloud, it worked. I felt the warmth of a miraculous blessing on my head, soft, light as a feather.

Cryptography Lead: I told Madam Lucy right away, but as soon as she left the room, the "curse" hit me, and I began to liquefy.

Cryptography Lead: There was no one else in the room. My liquid form had become too insubstantial to push the help button.

Cryptography Lead: A long darkness followed. After that, I woke up again in my original primitive form, the way I first came into this world.

Enigma: Original primitive form?

The ferrofluid pulsates, which in Ulrich's body language is a nod.

Cryptography Lead: Unlike humans, the Awakened have neither flesh nor nerves. We are pieces of consciousness, echoes of a primordial melody, that just happen to reside in material objects by chance.

Cryptography Lead: With a mind and a body combined, we could talk, learn, think like you do, and perform the experiment and endure the side effects.

Cryptography Lead: And this curse, for some reason, cannot affect the "primal consciousness" that caused our awakening in the first place.

Cryptography Lead: While human minds dissipate when their tangible bodies are destroyed, our minds reawaken regardless of the changes and destruction of our external bodies.

Cryptography Lead: Of course, this was an assumption based on idealized circumstances, and I needed another Awakened being who could awaken in different bodies to confirm my theory. That is why I sought out Madam Lucy for cross-verification. The results ...

Enigma: Yes, it was an assumption! You said it yourself! You came back to life this time, but what about the next? Nothing is for sure in arcanum!

Enigma: What if she never wakes up again? What if she dies for good?

He swats Enigma's hand away.

Cryptography Lead: We know what we are doing, human.

Cryptography Lead: Stay out of this. Only the Awakened can carry out the experiment, so we must proceed.

Cryptography Lead: This has nothing to do with race. It is a sense of duty that every researcher should have possessed when they chose this path.

Cryptography Lead: We have to go beyond the limit. Not out of madness, but out of rationality.

Enigma: ...

Silence fills the room, like the beginning of time when there was no sound to be heard.

Then slowly, the piston starts to spin.

Lucy: Hm. We seem to have replicated Effect No. 2, and 117 of the Coleman lab's protective rituals were proven ineffective.

Lucy: Write it down, Simone. This is the fourth time we have seen it. Also, No. 45 and 69 are related to it.

Lucy: We need to speed up. This is too slow.

The lights are back on again, and the piston is placed into a new body.

Being prepared for all possible outcomes requires a significant amount of metal material, but it is essential for data collection and analysis.

With a soft hum, the robot turns her head and looks at Enigma, surprised.

Lucy: Adler, what are you doing here?

Lucy: I am glad to see you out of your room and working with us again.

Assistant Simone: No. He is not on the team, ma'am. He forced his way in here.

Lucy: Oh? My apologies. I seem to lose a small amount of data when I reawaken.

She smiles at him, as she always does.

Lucy: Still, I am glad that you are showing initiative, Adler. Were we supposed to talk?

Enigma: No. We have nothing more to discuss, ma'am. Ulrich has filled me in on everything.

Enigma: But I still worry whether the experiment's risks were properly assessed.

Lucy: Assessments will only be assessments. Much is beyond measure when it comes to arcanum.

Lucy: Perhaps "faith" plays a more important role here.

Enigma is caught off guard by her words.

Enigma: I'm surprised it is you talking about "faith," ma'am.

Lucy: Hm. It seems we both have the ability to surprise each other.

As they speak, the robot strolls over to her chair and sits back down.

Lucy: You are right. "Assessments" could indeed be useful to us.

Lucy: It allows us to know the probabilities of success and failure based on established facts and past experience.

Lucy: But when we find ourselves in uncharted darkness, with no information or past experience to guide us, how are assessments going to help us?

Enigma: ...

She ponders and stares into the void.

Perhaps the experiment did fry some circuits, she's more sentimental than usual.

Lucy: The only thing we have in such darkness is the unwavering faith to move forward.

Lucy: ...

Lucy: When the first steam engine whistled, I awoke into this world.

Lucy: At the beginning of this new life, my circuits were charged with a singular, primal desire: to progress.

Lucy: In the midst of that never-ending whistle, I have watched man build the towers of science and knowledge, and I have watched them unleash chaos and destruction.

Lucy: You, too, have been lost and deterred, but your engines of progress have never stopped churning. Always move forward, no matter the destination, you told yourselves.

Lucy: Until the "Storm" brought everything to a standstill.

Lucy: But this is just a small setback. We are only back to the beginning, where we stumble blindly.

Lucy: And this time, I happen to have a cane.

She gives him a tender smile.

Lucy: No need to worry about me. I will not shut down as long as there is still hope for progress.

Lucy: Hm. We have wasted a bit of time on data recovery.

Lucy: Come, Simone. Let us begin the next experiment.

Lucy: I hope to dissolve into paste this time, so we can easily handle it with a Coleman's ritual of transformation.

The human researcher knows that it'd be inappropriate for him to stay here any longer.

Gritting his teeth, he moves toward the door, trying his best to leave the horrific scene behind him.

Someone is waiting for him by the door.

Cryptography Lead: Seen enough? We know what we are doing, and you are of no help here.

Cryptography Lead: It's been the same old story in this place for the past eight years.

Cryptography Lead: When your faith crumbled during the "Storm," it was us who took over the place and cleaned up after you.

Cryptography Lead: It was us who got things back up and running, put coals in the hearth, and blazed a trail when everyone was lost in the dark.

Cryptography Lead: I know you may not understand the intricacies of the arcanum, but please show some basic respect for our efforts.

Enigma: Will you do the experiments yourself, Ulrich?

Cryptography Lead: Of course. I am not some emotional, unhelpful little punk.

Enigma: ...

Instead of his usual witty comeback, Enigma simply shakes his head in a slow motion.

Enigma: Do you still remember Adams?

A sudden question that seems out of place.

The ferrofluid quivers. The name seems to unearth memories that have been buried for eight long years in the confines of this institution.

Enigma: Adams, Roman, Adolph, Sylvia, Albert, Louise ... Those who were taken from us by the rain.

Enigma: Melvin, Frances, Caroline, Leopold ... They volunteered for the field, but we never heard from them again.

Enigma: Now we have Dora, Richard, Dawkins, and Victor on the list.

Enigma: Life has a wicked sense of humor. My mentor, my classmates, my colleagues, each of them deserved to live more than me. But they're all gone now. There's only me talking to you, alive, useless.

Enigma: Am I going to see your names on that list too, Ulrich?

Cryptography Lead: ...

In this rare moment, he lowers his head.

But soon, he raises his arms and slaps the man hard on the back.

Cryptography Lead: Spare me the feelings, human.

Cryptography Lead: Though I will take back my sarcastic jabs at you, it is not something a leader should do. Madam Lucy talked to me about the importance of teamwork.

He awkwardly pats the human on the shoulder, a clumsy attempt at friendliness.

Cryptography Lead: Go back to your room, Adler. The arcanists will take over from here. Until we get the results, you won't be needed here.

Enigma heaves a breath.

Enigma: I will say this, Ulrich. If you survive the experiments,

Alarmed by the opening words, Ulrich instinctively turns down his receiver to avoid hearing anything too warm.

That would be more painful than suffering through a hundred experimental side effects.

Enigma: I'll submit the sincerest application to never be on the same team as you again.

Enigma: So neither of us will have to worry about teamwork. How's that sound?

Cryptography Lead: Haha.

A curve that almost resembles a smile appears on his face.

Cryptography Lead: I will wait for that application, Adler.

Now. Roll up your sleeves and clear your mind.

This is not the time to grieve.

If human reasoning and arcane knowledge are not enough on their own ...

... perhaps a combination of the two can solve this problem?

Enigma: ...

The lab door is in shambles, its metal plate barely hanging on. A wooden sign reading "Keep Out" sways precariously, covered in bite marks and scratches.

Enigma takes a moment before finally knocking on the door.

A voice answers from within.

???: Who's there?

Enigma: Adler Hofmann from the cryptography team. Is Medicine Pocket in?

Enigma: I heard that they wrote a paper on the linear correlation between the purity of an arcanist's bloodline and their power. Can I get some more details on the research?

The door creaks open to reveal a youthful face. But she is not the genius he is looking for.

The lab technician looks at him through her glasses and hesitates a little.

Laboratory Technician: The paper is here. Help yourself. Sorry about the stains on it. I just took it out of the trash.

Laboratory Technician: If you're looking for Medicine Pocket, I'm afraid they just left.

Enigma: Left? To where?

There is a subtle conflict on her face. She is torn between covering for her colleague and following the rules.

It is more than enough for him to catch on.

Enigma: They left the building? Hasn't the countdown already begun?

Laboratory Technician: Erm, yes, and by regulations we are not to leave. But, uhm ...

Laboratory Technician: They said their new theory had to be verified in the "Storm."

TO BE CONTINUED...

Diagnosis Record - Awakened

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Diagnosis Record - Awakened

Diagnostic Subject: Lucy

Examination Items: X-ray scanning, visualization, fluoroscopy, magnetic induction check, intelligence checks for age groups 6 to 60, including vision and hearing checks ...

Clinical Manifestation: The subject's core briefly lost consciousness after channeling an incantation, then returned to normal. Considering the replaceability of the external shell, the damage is negligible. Only changes to the core are described below:

Basically unchanged.

The subject's core remains stable, with no apparent external injuries, nor any internal damage found. All examination indices are normal. It is speculated that the subject's external shell bore the brunt of the curse, and that the subject's spirit is greater than the material of the vessel—according to one of the current mainstream views, the consciousness of the awakened comes from some still unknown macro-arcanum phenomenon. Perhaps it is such arcane phenomena that override the side effects of the incantation, helping to overcome the curse

directly affecting the core, so that the target does not die from the curse while the consciousness remains.

Final Diagnosis: The subject's suggestion to further verify the side effects of the curse by using herself was agreed upon. However, according to past records, the awakened are not forever indestructible, so observation must be maintained, and the experiment must be terminated immediately if symptoms such as core degradation or mental abnormalities occur.

To Open the Flood Gates

7TH-16

To Open the Flood Gates

17#0

Medicine Pocket: Ha! Fresh air! Green grass! The dew, the mud! This is what I'm talking about! A better world!

They kick the muddy ground with their boot in ecstasy.

The mud splatters on the Foundation staff member's jacket, but he remains professional and does not bat an eye.

Foundation Staff I: Researcher Medicine Pocket, I must remind you that we are at the edge of the immunity zone to the "Storm."

Foundation Staff I: Once we cross the line, we will not only catch the Storm Syndrome, but also be taken by the "Storm" at the end of the countdown.

The entrance of the Foundation headquarters is bustling with personnel.

As the "Storm" approaches, a long line of field investigators has formed at the gate, waiting to pass through security.

Medicine Pocket groans. They spread their hands in frustration, clearly unhappy with how skilled the staff member is at avoiding confrontation.

Medicine Pocket: I know that. How stupid do you think I am? Hey, isn't that Rudolf? The poor guy sent to Tunguska?

Medicine Pocket: Hey man! How was Siberia? Welcome back! Did you bring me any new research materials? Oh, you don't recognize me? You're breaking my heart. It's me, your best friend that you just met, Medicine Pocket!

Medicine Pocket's attempt to approach the line is quickly thwarted. The staff member has to practically yank them back by their arms and legs.

Foundation Staff I: Researcher, I must make clear that you only applied for 15 minutes outside for research purposes. Your countdown starts from the moment when you cross this line.

Medicine Pocket: Okay! Safety first, I know! Get off me! You're hurting my arms!

Medicine Pocket struggles desperately, and finally manages to plant all four limbs back on the ground.

Medicine Pocket: I'll bounce as soon as the Storm Syndrome hits.

Medicine Pocket: Even if I catch it, look at the "Syndromes" of this era: Distorted faces, murderous intentions, obsession with war, rampage ...

Medicine Pocket: What's got you so worried? They aren't that bad. Well, the melting faces part is kind of gross.

The staff member responds with a blank expression.

Medicine Pocket shrugs. They kneel down and open up a leather case.

One week is more than enough for a genius like them to upgrade an old apparatus.

This is the second version of the sampling device for "asymmetrical nuclide R," boasting improved sensitivity compared to its predecessor.

Medicine Pocket: I really wanted to test this in Vienna. Ahh, well. Better than nothing.

Medicine Pocket: Alright, now, I'm gonna walk a little further from the "immunity zone" so the samples are easier to gather. The ideal distance is 1500 km, but, oh, don't worry, not gonna do that—even I can't run that fast.

They hold the sampling device in their hands and step across the boundary.

Behind them, the staff member starts his timer, a skeptical look on his face.

Medicine Pocket: Now, behold. The important moment,

Medicine Pocket: when I prove the dorks in Laplace wrong about "asymmetrical nuclide R."

Resource Room, Laplace

The room is as dark and dusty as when Enigma last saw it, but to him, it's a sanctuary.

The towering piles of files and outdated equipment immediately isolate him from the rest of the world.

Finally, he is back in his fortress.

Enigma: Now, hypothetically, if the "Storm" research were to succeed,

Enigma: two things should have been done:

He scribbles quickly on the dusty white board.

1. Safe usage of the ritual for arcanists.

2. Mass production of the ritual for humans.

Enigma: And to find out the safe way to use it, we have to ...

(1) Have the power to wield it.

(2) Minimize the side effects.

Enigma: This is what Lucy was thinking. The Awakened met the casting requirements of the incantation, and Ulrich succeeded, while the other arcanists did not feel the same "miraculous blessing" like he did.

Enigma: So, as long as we eliminate the side effects, they'll be able to inscribe the incantation and mass-produce it for the humans.

Enigma: One problem is, only the Awakened can carry out the experiments, and there's not many of them around.

Enigma: It'll take too long. There's no way to do this in 24 hours. Heck, it could take months or even years.

Enigma: There must be something else we can do.

Lucy: But you are not an arcanist.

Lucy: Why should you play by their rules?

Enigma: Yes, that's right. Let's try a different approach. What if I start with the desired outcome and work backwards to the question?

He crosses out the second step.

Enigma: The quickest and most efficient way to save everyone is to make them qualified casters of the ritual.

Enigma: They won't even need protective equipment if we can do that.

Enigma: The challenge is, how do we qualify the casting requirements?

He looks at the papers on his desk in desperation.

Enigma: Medicine Pocket's theory is correct, and there's enough data and supplementary experiments to back it up.

Enigma: The power of arcanists is directly tied to the purity of their bloodline, which is associated with the special cells in their bodies.

Enigma: Using arcane skills reduces the activity of the cells, but the Picrasma extract can reactivate them for extended casting. However, the extract only provides endurance, not power.

Enigma: It is physiologically impossible for a low-ranked arcanist to cast a high-ranked skill, that's the reality of it.

Enigma: If we were to compare the power of arcanists to household appliances, let's say their nominal voltage is 230 volts.

Enigma: And if the "Storm" immunity ritual were a high-voltage source of 1000 volts, no, millions of volts, like lightning.

Enigma: The household appliances would be destroyed in an instant.

He is used to simplifying complicated arcane jargon into relatable examples for practical application.

Enigma: As for the humans, they are not even in the picture. We cannot cast to begin with, and I personally didn't feel any blessing or curse when I recited half of the incantation that day.

He falls back into his chair, rubbing at his temple.

The researcher struggles against his defeatist mindset, but the hopelessness is hard to ignore.

Enigma: Think! How can I get everyone to meet the casting requirements of the ritual?

Enigma: Forget what's theoretically impossible! The arcanum never gave a damn about certainties! I've been reminded plenty that logic does not apply to things like this.

Irritated, he pushes the papers aside and pulls a book of arcanum from the mountain of clutter.

Enigma: What about shortcuts? Are there records of transcendental rites, significant celestial events, sacrificial offerings, or even pneuma-emanating ingredients that could boost the user's casting abilities?

Enigma: Wait. Pneuma-emanating?

A thought flashes across his mind.

Enigma: Where have I seen that word before?

He rushes to the bookshelf and starts rummaging through the dusty volumes.

Enigma: It was in the file Ulrich told me to read! The Timekeeper's report from the Aegean Sea!

Enigma: Those islanders call the "Storm" the "Emanation." Why?

Enigma: The "Emanation," "Emanation" ...

Enigma: Just what is emanating out?

The door swings open with a loud bang, causing him to jump in surprise.

The towering stack of books next to the door tumbles over, as if nudged by an invisible force.

Then he hears a familiar sound—shuffling footsteps from the hallway outside, sticky and wet.

Cryptographer III: *roar*

Enigma: What the ...?!

Enigma: Dawkins, I hope you know this is not the time to catch up. That is, if you're able to talk at all.

Enigma: No, let go! I've just come up with an idea. Leave me alone!

He braces himself against the desk, straining to resist being thrown out of the room. He squirms across, stretching his fingers until he finally reaches the red button.

Enigma: Somebody, help!

Enigma: Hmm, you're not really here for revenge, and it wasn't you who pushed away the books and opened the door.

Enigma: The invisible ghost ... Victor? Did you do that?

The colossal muddy gingerbread man nods, surprisingly docile.

Beside him, a whiteboard marker in the air begins to write on the wall: "It's me."

Then the marker turns its tip and points at the door.

Enigma does as his friend suggests and walks out into the hallway.

Outside, people are talking and laughing with genuine joy on their faces.

Laboratory Technician: Ah, Researcher Adler!

A figure in a shiny uniform suddenly stops nearby. Enigma recognizes her as the unfortunate colleague who works with Medicine Pocket.

Enigma: What happened? Any progress?

Laboratory Technician: Yes, Researcher Medicine Pocket has proved their theory right!

Laboratory Technician: They have successfully found the "asymmetrical nuclide R" in the air before the "Storm," even if only a trace!

Enigma: What did you say?

Laboratory Technician: They came up with the idea because the nuclide was initially found in the raindrop samples of the "Storm." They deduced it also exists in the air before the "Storm" occurs, like the water droplets in the atmosphere before rain.

Laboratory Technician: So now, we can extract it directly from the air, without waiting for the Timekeeper to bring the raindrops to us. This will help us a lot in the mass production of the protective gear.

She trails off as she notices the look on his face.

Enigma: No way. The "Emanation" ... "asymmetrical nuclide R" ...

Enigma: She was right. The ritual works. Any arcanist can use it, and the solution was right in front of us!

Enigma: I didn't need to boost the caster's abilities. With the right setup and materials, the world before the "Storm" is already an enormous stage for performing the ritual.

Enigma: It's like a charged pylon, just needing a cable.

Laboratory Technician: Mr. Adler?

The man slips past her and starts running toward the other end of the corridor.

Enigma: Thank you, Miss Whoever! And thanks for letting me know, Dawkins and Victor!

The technician looks around but sees no one. Nearby, a muddy head and a floating pen emerge from the door.

She shrieks.

Enigma makes his way to the airlock door.

Enigma: It's me, Ulrich. Let me in. I need to see Madam Lucy!

Enigma: Tell her—I found a way to transcend the limit.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The "Storm" Speech

7TH-17

The "Storm" Speech

Enigma: We don't have time. I'll spare you the technicalities and explain it straight.

He pops off the marker cap and draws a few lines on the board, exuding confidence with every stroke.

Enigma: Our biggest problem is the limit of the bloodline. Low-rank arcanists can't command high-rank arcane rituals, similar to how household appliances can't withstand what's beyond their designated voltage.

Enigma: In most cases, the caster can only use their own arcane circuits that run through their inherited bloodline.

Enigma: But what if the caster were in a special electric field? What if we used existing circuits on the outside and put the caster into a greater circuit?

Enigma: What if we factored in the entire planet and used the atmosphere to split the current flowing through us, by adding more appliances to the circuit?

Cryptography Lead: Don't be ridiculous, Adler! We are not household appliances!

The ferrofluid frowns, questioning the premises of Enigma's proposal.

Enigma: Hold on. Let me finish.

Lucy listens without a word, giving him some courage to go on.

He draws a big circle next to the little person on the board.

Enigma: 24 hours before the "Storm," the entire world is charged with abundant arcane energy. It becomes a space emanating pneuma, a cloud ready to discharge—a special electric field.

Enigma: Look at "asymmetrical nuclide R," the key to the "Storm" immunity, was inside the "Storm" all along.

Enigma: And look at how the Mandragora is the antidote to its own poison—the solution can be hidden in the question itself.

Enigma: The arcane energy a caster inherently lacks can be borrowed from the surroundings during the "Storm." We just need a way to induct that energy.

Enigma: And Laplace happens to have all the data for the calculations. The observation systems we've built over the past eight years have not been in vain!

Enigma: First, we derive a formula to determine the pneuma needed from the "Storm" based on the arcanist's lineage.

Enigma: Then, we'll design a converter to transform the external pneuma into what they can use—they will no longer be bound by their limits!

Enigma: With just one calculation and one conversion, we can turn anyone into a capable caster.

He excitedly stretches out his arms and ends his epic monologue.

It is a good thing that emotions cannot be read on an Awakened being's face.

Cryptography Lead: I knew I shouldn't have wasted my time listening to you. What are you saying, Adler?

Cryptography Lead: You made up a confusing story, then drew conclusions from it.

Enigma: The second part is purely theoretical, I admit. But the basis of my theory is correct, and I have read Medicine Pocket's paper.

Cryptography Lead: But arcanum is not electricity! You're too caught up in your excitement to remember the basics. You know nothing about arcanum.

Enigma: It's still a form of energy, yes? No one here knows what the "Storm" is, but we do know that it's a massive arcane energy field. We can harness it, much like arcanists use arrays to amplify their incantations.

Lucy: I see what Researcher Adler is trying to say. A creative solution indeed.

The director gets up from her chair and intervenes.

Cryptography Lead: But ma'am ...

Lucy: Do not worry, Ulrich. I also have noticed that humans could be smart and stupid at the same time. Perhaps that is why they need to have their work peer-reviewed.

Enigma: Uh, than ... ks ...?

She nods amicably, pleased that her recently improved interpersonal skills have come in handy.

Lucy: There is a type of electrophotography invented by Semyon Kirlian and his wife Valentina Kirlian in 1939. That depicts the energy field surrounding an object or body.

Lucy: It was later used by Laplace as a method of measuring arcane power, notably for the "Storm" observation systems.

Lucy: Through it, we are able to capture and measure the arcane "light" or "aura" that is invisible to the naked eye.

Wasting no more time on mediation, the robot comes to a conclusion.

Lucy: The plan of Researcher Adler is feasible. Laplace also has the technology to support it.

Lucy: We have the "Storm" observation stations, the capable casters, and the best mathematicians.

Lucy: Ulrich, please ask Ms. Titor to lead the calculations, then experiment outside the safe zone and record the Pneuma Constant needed for casting the incantation.

Lucy: And do not give the incantation to anyone. I doubt they can resist trying it.

Ulrich lets out a reluctant hum and leaves the room as instructed.

Lucy: Simone, please contact Researcher X. His "Balancing Helmet" could be the prototype for our converter.

Lucy: That helmet balances the energy field in and out of our bodies, and was once used to protect researchers working with dangerous arcane skills. We could boost its power and use it as a substitute for Adler's converter.

Lucy: But we should postpone their testing request until we have completed our experiments on the side effects.

Her assistant gives a quick nod and begins drafting the notice.

The tasks are quickly assigned to the right people in less than a minute.

Only one person seems to have been left out.

Enigma: What about me, ma'am? Should I go with the calculations team or help with the converter?

He takes a tentative step forward, curious about his role in this endeavor.

Lucy: Right. I wanted to talk about that.

Lucy: You have proven to us the value of human thoughts and perspectives. I am glad that your struggles with the bottle did not damage your brain, Adler.

Lucy: I am confident that your discoveries will save many lives in the "Storm" once implemented.

Enigma: The bottle? But it's been seven years ...

She just keeps on smiling.

Lucy: But you overlooked one thing in your plan.

Lucy: What about **your people, the humans,** who can never cast incantations?

An apt question.

Enigma: They were not included in the plan. I just came up with something that took the least steps to reach the desired outcome.

Enigma: To save humans, they'll have to rely on equipment. Only when we have better control over the ritual can we store it on arcane devices for mass production.

Lucy: Then you should go perfect it.

Enigma: Huh?

Enigma: We only have 16 hours and 30 minutes until the "Storm"! There's not enough time to ...

Lucy: The feasible part of your plan is in motion, and all of Laplace will provide the help we need. We will make it work.

Lucy: As for yourself, perfect your plan so we can save everyone, including the humans.

Lucy: And we only have 16 hours and 30 minutes to find the solution.

Enigma: ...

The directions are given—clear, precise, with no room for ambiguity.

Enigma: Understood. I will think of something.

Enigma: You're right about this one.

He turns and walks away with long, purposeful strides.

Behind Lucy, Simone has finished drafting.

Assistant Simone: There was no way he "overlooked" his own race.

Assistant Simone: Yet, he still gave up his own people and brought this plan to us.

Assistant Simone: Were we too hard on him?

Lucy: Were we?

She turns nonchalantly and sits back in her chair.

Lucy: But I made the right decision.

The internal line rings.

The assistant puts down the list of side effects and grabs the phone.

Assistant Simone: Yes? Yes. We will provide the tech support.

She ends the call with a grave expression on her face.

Assistant Simone: It was Zeno, ma'am.

Assistant Simone: They lost contact with Team Timekeeper three hours ago. They're asking us for tech support.

Assistant Simone: They have to make contact with the island immediately.

...

...

Sophia: ... Urrm ...

The mind sinks and floats in an ocean of lethargy.

A piece of driftwood would be well timed.

Thirty-seven: Don't worry, Sophia. It is just a game!

Thirty-seven: I won't be in there for long. You can wait for me on the beach if you want. Okay?

The wood dissolves into foam.

Sophia: No, 37, don't!

Sophia: ...!

She wakes up on a cold piece of rock.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: ... Where ... What happened?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Encrypted Record #832

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Encrypted Record #832

"Regarding Zeno's request for assistance in establishing a dedicated communication line with the Timekeeper, we hope to understand the details."

"The exact content of the communication is a military secret. I cannot divulge the details."

"The Scientific Computing Center needs to understand the purpose of Zeno's establishment of communication to judge whether it is worth diverting manpower to build a dedicated line."

"Zeno's purpose is a military secret. I cannot divulge the details."

" ... Next, I will ask some simple questions. If you continue to answer with 'I cannot divulge the details,' I will take it as a sign of admission. Do you understand?"

"I am not authorized to answer that question."

" ... Very well, then is Zeno preparing for a military operation against the Manus Vindictae and therefore needs to establish communication with the Timekeeper for this purpose?"

"I cannot divulge the details."

"Good, this operation will ensure the Timekeeper's safety then, won't it?"

"I cannot divulge the details."

"This is an unconventional operation, isn't it?"

"I cannot divulge the details."

"This operation was most likely inspired by the Pax Security Council, correct?"

"We are soldiers. Soldiers act on orders, miss."

*Zeno then hung up the call.

Numbers in Everything

7TH-18

Numbers in Everything

The smell of gunpowder hangs heavy in the air.

The once magnificent columns are now reduced to rubble and irregular stones.

Blood rings in her ears, drowning out all other sounds.

Why?

Sophia: I remember now. The island fell ill, and 6 summoned all the integers to the cleansing ceremony. 37, she went to Apeiron.

Sophia: They tended to their missions. I went to the square to pray for them, and then ...

Sophia: There was an earthquake.

Sophia: Uhm!

Warplanes thunder above, whipping up debris and the girl's garments in their passing.

Sophia: The human army? Wasn't the Foundation mediating the disputes?

Sophia: Did they betray us?

Calm now, Sophia.
Your soul is imbalancing
toward the excess.

Sophia: I need to calm down. I-I need to find the others.

Sophia: Slow down and breathe. Stability is an essential virtue to becoming an integer.

Sophia: Okay. Let's clean up the place first.

She places a hand on the brass ruler at her waist and, as pious as ever, begins to recite the incantation.

Sophia: @

Nothing happens.

Sophia: The incantation didn't work?

Sophia: Did they fail to perform the cleansing ceremony?

She stands frozen for what seems like an eternity, disoriented and unsure. It feels like her world has crumbled beneath her feet.

But then, she notices a familiar figure in the distance.

Sophia: Is that 42?

Believer I: ...

The man struggles to stand, rambling to the emptiness around him.

Believer I: No one survives the oblivion.

Sophia: His hysteria is acting up again. I should help ...

Soldier I: Hahahaha! Die, you lunatics!

Soldier I: This is our land! Right from the beginning!

"Boom!"

When the smoke clears, 42 is gone.

Sophia: Ah, ahh. No, NO!

Sophia: Be calm, be stable, think.

Integers are the living example of virtues,
the standard of purification.
It is the representation of a soul
in the world of Forms, a true being.

Sophia: I have to go check on him. I can do this.

Sophia: Uhm. *almost throws up*

Everything is a number.

Everything is a number.

Everything
is a
number.

Sophia: Stay, stay calm. He-he is just ...

Sophia: He is divided into two numbers, 6 and 7.

~~**42=6×7**~~

Sophia: *vomit*

Sophia: I have to find the others. I have to tell them about 42.

Believer II: Sophia, what are you doing here?

She hears a recognizable voice coming from the ruins.

Up on the hill, a woman raises her hand and calls to her.

Believer II: Get to the shelter. It is at—

"Boom!"

Sophia: Ah, ahh! Ms. 18! No!

Sophia: I can't ... This can't be happening! I ...

~~**18=2×9**~~

Sophia: I, I have to keep it together. Move, Sophia, get to the cave.

Sophia: Find ...

???: Sophia!

A quiet sob comes from the bushes. A child cowers in the foliage, shaking in terror.

Kid Believer I: I, I'm so scared. Everyone's gone crazy.

Sophia: It's okay. I got you. Come out now, Lacey. We will go find the others.

But the child stares at her in a panic, hugging her knees even closer to her chest.

Kid Believer I: No, no! I don't want to see them!

Kid Believer I: They have all gone crazy, everyone.

A droplet of paint emerges on her face.

Sophia: Lacey! Your face!

But Lacey brushes her hand away.

She turns around and runs deeper into the forest.

Sophia: ...

It is the floating points
behind the decimal
which hinder the process
of our purification.

Sophia: Her soul has tilted toward excess. This is "wrong."

Sophia: I am the Corrector. I have to help her, or she'd get herself killed.

Sophia: I have to right the wrongs here.

The world is warping, painted over with vibrant oil hues.

Her headache is splitting, each step feels like walking on lava.

Sophia: Come on, Sophia. Keep yourself together, keep your soul in balance.

She closes her eyes and breathes.

Tilt not toward the excess.

Sophia: ...

Lacey has gone out of sight, only her sobs remain to haunt her mind.

Something needs to be done.

Sophia: 37. I must find her. I promised it to her.

37=1×37

Sophia: She is going to be fine. She's a prime number, and prime numbers are not as divisible as the others.

Sophia: She will pass the test of Apeiron and receive the transcendental Truth, for she is the genius, the wise one who returns.

Sophia: We will right the wrongs and restore things to how they were.

Because that is the salvation
promised by the Truth.

But take heart, the race of man is also blessed with divinity.
For nature has already revealed her secrets to them.
Once you understand this blessing,
You will easily achieve all that is set upon you.
You will heal your soul,
And be freed from evil and suffering.
—The Golden Verses

A ray of light breaks through the darkness.

Thirty-seven: Sophia! You really waited for me!

Thirty-seven: Hm? What's happened to your clothes? Did you fall on your way here?

As always, she tilts her head curiously.

She has not yet seen the chaos of war. She remains innocent, untouched by the dust of the phenomenal world.

Sophia: 37, I'm so glad to see you.

Sophia: You passed the test. You did it!

Thirty-seven: You seem emotional. Why? I told you it wasn't going to be difficult.

Vertin: 37. Things don't seem right out there.

Sophia desperately grabs 37's arm.

Sophia: 37, you have seen Apeiron, right? You asked the question, didn't you?

37 blinks, too focused to spare a glance at the world outside.

For she is busy sharing her findings with a close friend.

Thirty-seven: Yes, and I got the answer! The answer that will save us from the "Emanation" once and for all!

Thirty-seven: And the answer is ...

It's the Truth that transcends everything.

The answer that will save everyone.

The last and final hope.

The moment she has been
waiting for.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: Is that it?

Sophia: The one true answer from Apeiron is a string of numbers?

37 nods, having just recited the last number.

Thirty-seven: Yes, because the transcendental Truth is beyond the limits of our mortal flesh. It cannot be described by words, seen by eyes, interpreted by logic, or perceived by the senses.

Thirty-seven: It is passed to us in a form we can understand—numbers.

Thirty-seven: This is the key to the Truth! Give me some time, and I can decode it.

Warplanes still roar in the sky.

Smoke still chokes the air.

Her lungs burn with every breath she takes.

Time is ticking, and people are dying.

Helplessly, mercilessly.

Sophia: Time ...

Sophia: 37, how long do you need?

Thirty-seven: Hmm, a month? Or a week?

Thirty-seven: I will spend all my time working on it. It is not an easy question—could be the hardest one I ever dealt with in my life. But I will get there.

Thirty-seven: And then, we will be freed from all these problems once and for all!

Thirty-seven: Even if we don't know its meaning yet, it will eventually lead us to the kingdom of Truth!

Thirty-seven: ...

She stops her enthusiastic explanation and looks at her friend worriedly.

Thirty-seven: Sophia? Why are you crying?

Sophia: ...

Sophia looks up at her.

Tears stream down her cheeks.

Sophia: That long? 37 ...

Sophia: A Truth that distant won't change ...

Sophia: ... what's in front of us now.

She breaks free from her friend's grasp and races into the smoke and dust of the phenomenal world.

Sophia: *cry*

Sophia: Ahhhhhhhh!

Thirty-seven: Sophia?!

Thirty-seven: Sophia!

She no longer knows why she's running.

She no longer knows the purpose of her existence.

She only knows of the wild, fiery sensation rising in her chest.

Everything is a number ...
Everything is a number ...
Everything is a number ...

Sophia: No.

Is this the Truth?
Is this the answer?

Sophia: Calm yourself, Sophia.

Even if the Truth
can keep people from
the wheel of birth,

what good is it
for those already in it?

Sophia: I have to ...

Arcana: You seem astray, child.

Sophia: ...!

A detached figure looks on from the ruins of the beach, unperturbed by the chaos.

Arcana: And sad. What pains you so?

Arcana: Has the "Truth" not graced thee with its miracles?

Sophia: ...!

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Fork in the Road

7TH-19

The Fork in the Road

37 stands dazed on the beach.

She looks around at the familiar island.

The once pristine shores are now cluttered with the debris of human weapons.

Thirty-seven: How did this happen?

Thirty-seven: I passed the test. I was granted the Truth. I have the answer with me.

Thirty-seven: What did I do wrong?

Vertin: No, 37. None of this was your fault. Hysteria has come to this island, and people are caught up in it.

Vertin: It is the Storm Syndrome taking the form of "war."

The mind is growing increasingly tense, the situation has gone far beyond expectations.

Vertin: Has it been six hours since we entered the cave?

Vertin: That strange dream, it lasted longer than I thought.

6 gave two hours to leave, and now six hours have gone by.

But the islanders and the visitors are all too wrapped up in their own misery to notice.

Vertin: This is bad. The plan we have with Zeno ...

This objective is of the utmost importance.

But where is the team now?

Vertin: 37, I have to go.

Thirty-seven: I have to find Sophia!

She dashes into the forest, desperately searching for any sign of her redheaded friend.

Just as she goes further, a faint call stops her.

Six: 37.

Thirty-seven: ...?!

Thirty-seven: 6?! You seem ...

Six: *cough*

The leader looks even paler than usual.

His robe is in tatters, and his crown is covered with dirt.

He rests his back against a broken pillar, gazing up at her.

Six: Have you passed the test? On what question did you seek Its knowledge, and what answer did It give you?

Stunned by everything she's just been through, 37 recites the numbers for the third time, still a little dazed.

He listens intently and falls into a silence.

Thirty-seven: 6, weren't you going to perform the cleansing ceremony? And Sophia, she ...

Six: ...

37 trails off as she notices the dark fluid seeping from his robe.

Six: Please come up to me, Ms. Vertin. I wish to have a word with you.

His voice is gentle, but his expression is grave.

A gash runs across his stomach, his robe is soaked in crimson.

Six: Fifty strides from here, on the semicircle square, you will find your friends and the rest of our people.

Six: I have done as much cleansing as I could. If nothing goes wrong, they will regain consciousness soon.

Vertin: May I know what happened during the cleansing ceremony?

Vertin: 37 and I each had a bizarre dream after the earthquake. Did everyone on the island fall asleep, too?

Six: ...

Six: The island's order is forged by our faith.

Six: And now, that faith has been broken. That is all there is to it.

Thirty-seven: What did you say?

Vertin: Upon our arrival, I sensed a large-scale ritual surrounding the island.

Vertin: Is that the circle you kept talking about? Was it broken during the ceremony?

Six: No. The ceremony was just a ceremony, was never the source of our faith.

Six: Our journey was ended by the same thing that began it, Ms. Vertin,

He whispers softly, without looking at 37.

Six: which is the Truth.

The waves crash onto the shore,

bringing debris from the planes with them.

Arcana: It doth not surprise me.

Arcana: The wise, so blinded by their pursuit of knowledge, they oft neglect the harshness of reality. A common downfall of the contemplative.

Arcana: Pray tell, in the midst of such overwhelming destruction, where has their vaunted wisdom gone, and what good does it bring in this final hour?

Sophia: ...

Arcana: I can hear thy weeping and bellowing within, Ms. Sophia.

Arcana: Many a time you have knelt at the temple of Truth, devoted yourself, prayed for your people, and withstood the tribulations set upon you, all for the betterment of others. Thy character is without reproach.

She lifts her hand, smiling. Above, the roar of warplanes persists.

Arcana: Yet the Truth has never deemed you worthy, has It?

Sophia: No, that's not ...

She wants to leave, but her feet are rooted in sand.

She wishes to defy, but her body refuses to budge.

And where would she possibly go, after all this?

Arcana: You shall be granted a greater opportunity.

Arcana: A blessing that befits thy devotion.

Her unsettling tone causes the girl to instinctively step back.

Sophia: No. That's a violation of the Scripture!

Sophia: We shouldn't ...

Arcana: The Scripture?

Arcana: Yet you were never truly counted as one of them, do you not agree?

Arcana: As evidenced by the decision that Truth hath made.

Sophia: ...!

Arcana: Heh-heh.

Arcana: No one escapes their fate as ever.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: I ...

Thirty-seven: I, I don't understand.

She looks at 6, eyes wide in disbelief.

He has just effectively declared that their faith is dead.

Thirty-seven: I know the answer given to Mama was right. The transcendental Law is gone, and the supreme existence is in chaos. This caused our model to fail and allowed the discord in the phenomenal world to affect the "essence" of things.

Thirty-seven: But did the "Truth" really fall apart? Chaos is also a form of Truth, is it not? Just like how irrational numbers are numbers. Despite our dislike of them, they still exist and cannot be denied.

She steps forward, hoping for an answer.

Thirty-seven: But how, how did this become the destruction of our people's faith?

Six: ...

6 still does not look at her.

Six: You will hear no answer from me, 37, for that is not the question worthy of your attention.

Six: Do you still remember what you answered to me in the cave?

She nods, holding back the whirlwind of questions in her mind.

She kneels beside him and takes his hand in hers, gazing at him with intense focus.

Her eyes are still glittering like the stars above, unaffected by the tumultuous waves below.

Six: That would be enough then.

There's a hint of relief in his tone.

Six: Don't waste your time on the collapse of the faith. Don't question yourself because others think differently. Walk on, onto the path you have chosen.

Six: You have done nothing wrong.

This is a lesson that takes time to understand, one that can't be grasped so quickly.

She blinks softly, holding the lesson close to her heart.

Six: Ms. Vertin, I'm afraid I must trouble you for a favor.

He weakly places his hand over the wound, and a faint glow of his arcane power coalesces in his palm.

But the glow lasts only a moment, like a shooting star disappearing into the night.

Six: As you can see, I can hardly take part in this matter for any longer.

Six: Should the situation turn for the worse, please take 37 to safety and assist her in decoding the numbers.

Thirty-seven: ...?!

Vertin: You have my word.

It is a weighty request with unspoken implications.

The leader nods, looking on to the distant ruins.

His empty blue eyes are getting dimmer by the minute.

Six: We are born facing a choice.

Six: Either we restrain ourselves and strive for harmony and discipline, or succumb to destruction fueled by passion and madness. Though the former may be challenging, the latter will only plunge us into eternal darkness.

Six: From 1 to 10, each number has its moral purpose and mission. Among them, only 6 was chosen to be the leader.

Vertin: Because 6 stands for balance.

Six: Yes. We must pay heed to the balance between passion and reason, so as to stay on the right path and not be led astray by the calling of our blood.

Six: For generations, we committed ourselves to the Scripture and stayed true to what we pledged. We left the trivialities and troubles of the phenomenal world behind, and served the supreme existence with the fruits of our knowledge.

Six: This kind of faith was how the island prospered, and it was the source of our salvation.

Six: Through diligent practice and contemplation, we managed to remain secluded and independent from the rest of the world.

Vertin: The "irrational numbers" that your people rarely appreciate—are they faced with a different path, a path of passion and madness?

The leader nods slightly, acknowledging her speculation.

Six: We have been long isolated from the outside world by one "Emanation" after another.

Six: Four years ago, we tried to seek proof in the outside world, but failed. We regrettably lost some of our best scholars and friends in the process.

Six: However, it was not the failed attempt that led to this upsetting situation, but a crisis from within.

Six: Now, with our ship capsized and our scale fallen, I am no longer able to reconcile the tilt of people's hearts and souls.

Six: We will be divided. The fanatics from the foreign lands can finally spread their hatred amongst the ruins of our shattered beliefs.

Vertin: I will stop Manus Vindictae.

6 closes his eyes. His face is now as pale as the pillar behind him.

Six: Forget not your promise, Ms. Vertin.

Footsteps approach from the distance.

6 recognizes them—they are the fractions who weren't taken to the cleansing ceremony, and the apprentices still seeking their numbers.

But they're dressed completely different now.

Manus Believer I: 6. We came to bid you farewell.

Manus Believer I: Everything happened here proves you to be an incapable leader. Your preachings of moderation and reconciliation were nothing but excuses for cowardice.

Manus Believer I: Where were you when the humans dropped bombs on us? What did your "cleansing" do to help us? If those virtues are meant to be the virtues of an integer, then I would prefer to be a fraction.

Thirty-seven: Please listen, the integers were unconscious during the attack, because the ceremony was ...

Manus Believer II: Out of my way, 37! You knew nothing about what happened. You were in that cave having fun with your little games!

Manus Believer II: The envoy from Manus Vindictae was right. We have grown too complacent on the island and have forgotten how to fight. We foolishly believed that staying out of conflicts would guarantee us everlasting peace.

Manus Believer II: Now, open your eyes to the humans' atrocities against us! How can we not seek revenge for our spilled blood?

Manus Believer II: We must act and reclaim what was taken from ours. That is the true meaning of "salvation."

Their anger continues to escalate.

37 shakes her head firmly, refusing to back down.

Thirty-seven: It is true that I was absent earlier, but please listen to me. Everything will get better, because I already have the "Truth" with me!

Manus Believer I: The "Truth"? What good will it do right now?

Manus Believer I: Will it drive out the humans? Will it reclaim our home? Will it bring back our deceased friends?

Manus Believer I: Πάσας τὰς ὀρθὰς γωνίας ἴσας ἀλλήλαις εἶναι!

The man recites an incantation, a simple spell derived from the Truth that anyone in Apeiron could cast on their first day.

But now that their faith has crumbled, the radiance is no longer there.

Manus Believer I: What salvation did your "Truth" bring when steel pierced our chests?

Manus Believer I: Manus Vindictae granted us the power to fight back. What did the Foundation do?

One angry question after another. Sticky, slimy fluids seep through their masks.

Manus Believer II: Don't waste your time with these integers! The Foundation's envoy is here. It is clear they have taken the side of the humans!

Manus Believer II: Kill the envoy, cut off her head, and bring it to our "Mother"!

Thirty-seven: What? Y-You ...

Vertin: The mask has robbed them of reason. There's no point in talking further.

Vertin: Take 6 to safety, 37. I'm the one they are after.

Thirty-seven: Then how are you going to ...

Vertin: I will meet with Sonetto at the square. Ms. Radio is with them, and we will contact our people from there.

Vertin: Don't worry. We had a plan against the Manus, and we can still carry it out.

Vertin: Now, on my mark ...

Vertin: Run.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Greek Tragedy

7TH-20

A Greek Tragedy

The world is a door,
To a thousand ruins, desolate and cold.
For those who have lost,
What you have lost are long in the void.

—Vereinsamt by Friedrich Nietzsche

The flames of war rage along the shore.

Humans, Manus Vindictae, and Apeiron believers, all consumed by madness. The paints from their storm syndrome have bled into the sea, creating a disordered mixture of colors.

The flash of artillery and the glow of arcanum collide. Dead, infected sea creatures litter the shore, like a tableau of an abstract painting.

Marta: Where are you going, 37?

The sightless woman inquires with concern. Under her care, the leader's bleeding has finally ceased.

Thirty-seven: Please take care of 6 for me, Madam Marta.

Thirty-seven: I have to go find Sophia!

Not caring about anything else, she runs into the smoke.

Gunfire and explosions fill the air. The angry battle cries of former Apeiron believers, now in Manus attire, echo in all directions.

Manus Believer I: Die, humans!!!

Thirty-seven: Uhm!

The explosion knocks her off balance. She stumbles onto the gravel.

Thirty-seven: *winces in pain*

A pair of hands reaches out to her.

???: Are you alright, 37? Can you get on your feet?

Thirty-seven: Ah! Sophia!

Finally. The voice she's been searching for fills her with relief.

She happily reaches for her hands, but stops abruptly, uncertain.

Thirty-seven: Did you change your clothes?

Sophia: ...

She pushes down the cacophony of emotions swelling inside her.

Where to begin?

Sophia: I have found my number, 37.

Sophia: Your calculation was correct. As always.

Thirty-seven: You found it? That's good!

She accepts the news without hesitation, her face lighting up with a genuine smile.

Thirty-seven: I always wanted to tell you. It is a great number, the number of a herald, prophet, and pioneer.

Thirty-seven: When it was first discovered, mathematics was nearly destroyed. But luckily, it also spurred advancements in the field.

She stops, no longer rambling on about numbers, and sincerely gazes into her friend's emerald eyes.

Thirty-seven: Are we still friends, Sophia?

Sophia: ...

Sophia smiles. Smiling that she's still the same, even now.

She knows so much, yet she knows so little.

Sophia: Yes, 37. We still are.

Sophia: But there are more important matters I must tend to.

A bomber howls over their heads, the pilot laughing hysterically.

The plane is covered in thick layers of paint, its wings curled and twisted.

Soldier I: Hahahahaha! This is ours! The land we discovered!

The pilot has spotted the two targets on the barren rocks below, with two explosives prepared for release.

Sophia does not flinch or retreat, instead her fingers wrap gently around the tiny idol.

Sophia: Διορθωθεί το σφάλμα!

The bomber detonates in the sky, taking the young pilot with it.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, your power, and your look ...

Sophia: I must leave now, 37.

Sophia: Lady Arcana has shown me another path.

Thirty-seven: No. NO!

Thirty-seven: Why are you leaving, too? Is it because our circle has been broken?

Thirty-seven: But I found the Truth!

Thirty-seven: I have the final solution! Just give me a little more time, and everything will be fine again, I promise!

Sophia: ...

She closes her eyes, the scripture still lingers in her mind.

"There are three kinds of people who come to the Olympic Games."
"The lowest class is made up of those who come to buy and sell,
and the next above them are those who come to compete."
"But the most esteemed, however, are those who come to look on."

"Only these wise pursuers of knowledge ..."

"... may release themselves from the 'wheel of birth.'"

Sophia: You and I are different, 37.

Sophia: Not all of us have the privilege to look on from the sidelines.

She clenches the tiny idol.

A thick, tar-like substance seeps out from her body. In an instant, the bombers are wiped out completely.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, you ...

She can't prolong the inevitable any longer, she knows that.

This is the last thing she wants.

Sophia: I will join Manus Vindictae, take others with me, and leave.

Sophia: I will renounce the Scripture and seek vengeance in the phenomenal world.

Sophia: Make your move, 37.

Tears roll down her eyes.

Sophia: If you really are the genius who can overcome anything ...

Sophia: Prove it to me.

Sophia: Stop me, transcend me, defeat me ...

Sophia: Crush me to dust.

The explosions have finally ceased.

The planes rest alongside the geometric bodies in the sea, sinking into an everlasting sleep.

The roars of battle are no more.

All that remains is the crashing of the waves against the shore.

Sophia: Why?

Sophia: Why did you spare me, 37? Why did you show mercy? You weren't supposed to—

The battle ended quickly. 37's geometric brilliance has left only a tear on her friend's robe.

Thirty-seven: Because I don't want to fight you, Sophia!

Thirty-seven: Why? Why do we have to do this?!

Her voice is filled with anguish.

Sophia: ...

Sophia looks down in a long silence.

Then, she gently shakes her head.

Sophia: I'm sorry, 37. I have gone beyond reason, beyond cure.

Sophia: I must've been out of my mind to make you fight me. Your hands were never meant for violence. They were meant for upholding the Truth.

Thirty-seven: ...?

Sophia: As for me—I'm the one who clears the dust off the path, as fate foretold.

Sophia: Goodbye, my beloved friend.

She no longer wavers or looks back.

Her shoulders tremble, but she strides toward the Manus with determination.

Sophia: It is time.

Sophia: Please "clean up" the beach as quickly as possible. We will depart soon, as Lady Arcana has instructed.

Thirty-seven: Soph- ...

Sonetto: Ms. Sophia!

The team is finally reunited.

Sonetto arrives last, heaving from trying to catch up to the scene.

She had her own battles elsewhere on the island. That strange dream has taken its toll on her.

And now she is holding her pen, silently questioning Sophia with a piercing stare.

Why?

Sophia: ...

Sophia: We all have our own purpose to fulfill, Ms. Sonetto.

She walks right past her.

Sophia: I will not fight you this time. But I will draw steel the next we meet.

The new members of the Manus Vindictae have left.

They did clean up the beach—every trace of humanity has been wiped clean.

Only rock and metal debris remain on the beach.

Thirty-seven: I don't understand any of this.

She slumps to the ground and stares blankly into the distance.

Thirty-seven: The Truth transcends all and is above all trivial matters of the phenomenal world.

Thirty-seven: It guides us to enlightenment and protects us from evil and misfortune, does it not?

Thirty-seven: This is what I have always believed, so I went seeking for it. It is finally in my hands. But now, but now ...

37 buries her face between her knees, on the verge of sobbing.

Thirty-seven: What went wrong? Was it my fault? Isn't this how the Truth is supposed to work?

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: ...

It is not an easy question for an off-island visitor to answer.

However, one thing is for certain.

Vertin: The Truth has not abandoned you, 37.

Vertin: You haven't used the key yet, have you? It is still coded.

Thirty-seven: ...!

Thirty-seven: The key ...

37 is helped up from the ground.

Vertin: Lilya has verified Arcana's location. She is still on this island.

Vertin: We still have a chance to stop her before it's truly too late.

Vertin: We should go now, Sonetto.

Vertin: We have 15 more hours until the "Storm."

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Trail in the Forest

小径

A Trail in the Forest

A fate has been forged for this purpose,
A maxim, a preconception,
A deliberate contemplation, a step taken.
Believed to be a choice.

The woodland is older than all within it.
Through passion, or reason,
Travelers grope and stumble through the branches,
Or silently tread the narrow path,
Or choose to turn away,
Stepping into the subtle unknown.

Read, the voice urges.
If now, without pursuit, close to truth,
Yet let go.
Then never before had it been.

Step forward. So they say.
Before the tale is told, all is decided,
Merchants, competitors, mortals, and heroes.
And as the feast begins,
How shall they fade away.

And those outside,
For whom the time they've made has not yet come,
Those who deem themselves transcendent,
Are merely not in this procession.

A Homage Paid

7TH-21

A Homage Paid

Liaison Staff II: We've got signal. Zeno has restored communications with Team Timekeeper.

Assistant Simone: Very well. We will leave you to it.

She sighs with relief.

But before she hangs up, she has one more question.

Assistant Simone: Just to confirm before we go—the operation Zeno is currently undertaking has been approved by the Pax Security Council, right?

The internal call falls silent, as if the question is too absurd to answer.

???: Certainly, Miss.

???: We are soldiers. Soldiers act on orders.

Overlook, the Island

This is the only part of the island untouched by war.

Where the foliage is thriving and the view is stunning.

Arcana: I am most pleased to see you.

Arcana: Had you a pleasant stay on this island, Ms. Vertin?

Vertin: ...

She turns around, a smile gracing her face.

Arcana: Are they not an intriguing flock of people?

Arcana: Their wise ones drew a circle at their feet and declared themselves apart from this realm.

Arcana: For generations untold, they toiled as diligent ants in service of the circle, adoring and venerating it while shielding themselves from insanity's call.

Arcana: I take immense pleasure in admiring this wondrous figure—the primordial, eternal, immaculate circle.

Arcana: The more pity that it was etched upon sand.

Below, the bombed-out beach is in a state of disarray.

Vertin: I disagree.

Vertin: The fragility and impermanence of sand is precisely why people strive for something eternal. Believing in perfection is not a flaw.

Vertin: I noticed the human aircraft were loaded with weapons not from this era.

Vertin: Did Manus Vindictae provide them with the technology?

Arcana smiles, the silence confirming the disturbing revelation.

Vertin: I can't fathom your motives.

Vertin: If you came here to incite hatred and recruit the pure-blood arcanists on this island, you may now walk away with satisfaction.

Vertin: If you wanted to take the island as one of your bases, you could have done so after the cleansing ceremony failed.

Vertin: But you did nothing. You just stood there. Why?

Arcana: *chuckle*

Without rhyme or reason, she laughs.

Arcana: Do you struggle to comprehend, sweet Vertin?

Arcana: I was waiting for you.

Vertin: ...!

Sonetto and Lilya take a step forward.

Lilya: Enough talk, Vertin. It's time for action.

Sonetto: Mind your distance. Arcana has power over people's minds at a close range.

Arcana: A pity.

She raises her arm, the stone bangle still intact on her wrist.

The next moment, it slides off and falls to the grass, dissolving into thin air.

Arcana: I didst wish to keep this bangle. Mine and yours, a pair in perfect match.

Arcana: How will you remove yours, Vertin?

Vertin: ...

The bangle burns, a reminder of those who still believe in the teachings of Truth and Apeiron, and those who remained until the end of the cleansing ceremony.

The symbol of faith remains true to its purpose.

The peace agreement is still in effect.

Regulus: What? The island's been blasted to smithereens. How come the bangle still has its power?

Regulus: What is it made of?

Sonetto: Don't worry, Regulus. We have foreseen this.

The chief assistant shows no signs of worry.

Sonetto: When we first arrived, I was bewildered by the rules on this island. But as I learned more about their Scriptures, things began to make sense.

Sonetto: Language is an unreliable means of communication. Information can become muddled, and vague wording can lead to mistakes and contradictions. That's why the island values math as a more precise and truthful language.

Sonetto: They mock language for its ambiguity, scorn its flaws, and ruthlessly expose its inconsistencies, like they did during that debate.

Sonetto: The pact on this bangle is of a similar nature.

Lilya: I see. It forbids us from actively attacking, but what is considered an attack?

Lilya: The rule-maker did not specify that.

Sonetto: An act without the intent to attack will not be seen as an attack.

Sonetto: That is the unspoken rule of the peace agreement.

Arcana: Heh-heh. An adorable attempt.

Arcana: Are you truly prepared to gamble the life of thy sworn companion, little pup of the Foundation?

Behind her, an unidentifiable form materializes into existence.

Sonetto shakes her head, her wand remains steady.

Sonetto: I will not make the same mistake again, Ms. Arcana.

Sonetto: I know perfectly well what I'm doing. Your provocations will not work on me.

Sonetto: For the peace of this world,

Sonetto: I will stop you.

The wand radiates an intense brilliance.

Sonetto: Regna sereno intenso ed infinito!

Bullets and Calculus

小径

A bullet is among us, right under this roof. It serves no army, no country, only peace.

The heavy rain at the end of the century dissolved and washed away many of its comrades, but it was lucky enough to survive. Its pointy end still shines silver, ready to drill a hole into its enemy.

Sadly, its bulky colleague stole its thunder in this war. One push of the button, one big explosion. There was no need for the rest of the ammunition.

Choices

1. Good, we saved a lot of bullets.

2. Good for them. They don't have to work for a while.

Branch 1

It seems someone has become more budget-conscious after working with the mathematicians.

Saving ten bullets is better than saving one. Saving a hundred bullets is better than saving ten. It's simple math.

Branch 2

Certainly, who doesn't want a life without the need to work? Few would hesitate to choose a life of freedom over the achievement and satisfaction of a job.

Given the short lifespan of a bullet, why would it choose anything else?

But its boss, the general, has more to think about. What are they going to do next time? Will this bullet be put to use when the rain comes again?

Choices

1. The general? Who's that?

A big shot, dear. A wise man of the most insightful kind. You should talk to him if you have the chance.

But he's been in a gloomy mood lately. Be careful not to mention anything related to the conservative battle tactics used in 1999, the missile that would have been launched, and especially anything about the bullets lost in that battle.

He has paid a great price for the future, but you see, the future is sneaky.

Every time you think you can grasp it, it takes a step away from you, nullifying every effort you've made to get near it. Even a bullet isn't fast enough to catch up.

Choices

1. Then we must keep pursuing.

2. Perhaps bullets won't be needed in the future?

Branch 2.1

Pursuing the future. How romantic, dear. As long as we continue to close the gap between us and the future, it will eventually be reduced to zero.

But know that, as time goes by, we are only moving slower and slower in the race. Technology is regressing, and we have switched from AKs to Mosin-Nagants. The bullets won't be as fast as they used to be. The future is drifting away from us, and the past is catching up.

Branch 2.2

Shhhh ... Don't say such things out loud. Especially not near the general, sweetheart.

The bullets have paid a great price in order to find their way back to the future. If they hear you say they won't be needed anymore, you'll end up with quite the ammunition bill.

Alright, let's leave this bullet to itself. Solitude may help alleviate its anxiety about the future.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Bullets and Calculus

The Ones Who Pray

7TH-22

The Ones Who Pray

Here, on the level sand,
Between the sea and land,
What shall I build or write
Against the fall of night?

Tell me of runes to grave
That hold the bursting wave,
Or bastions to design
For longer date than mine.

—Alfred Housman

210: Drink this. It will help relieve your pain. Worry not, it's not made from the grapes on my head.

The war may have ended, but its scars remain in this place.

The Hall of Truth, once the palace of knowledge, now stands in ruins.

210 examines the injured man's face closely, making sure his pain is eased. Then he stands and watches as more people are brought through the gate.

888: Hang in there, 29.

888 makes her way into the hall, carrying an incapacitated believer on her back. She carefully lowers the person to the floor.

Her own arms are wounded from the attack, but fortunately they're not fatal.

Since the integers awakened, this has been the only thing they've been doing.

210: Are there any other injured that have not been found yet?

888: I've scouted the island. Every remaining member should be here.

210: So you have.

He sighs, the ramifications of the situation weighing down on them.

210: It means the members not here have joined Manus Vindictae.

The hall is dead silent.

Just a few hours ago, it was alive with debates, ideas, and passion.

But now one half of the hall is gone, its seats buried under the shattered dome and crumbling walls.

888: Is 6 still in a coma, Ms. Marta?

The blind woman nods, concern etched on her face.

The banshee doesn't say anything else. She needs to clean out her own wounds.

The last few hours have been a whirlwind. Their faith has crumbled, the humans have invaded their island, and Manus Vindictae has turned them against each other.

But now, everything's gone—enemies, friends, and even the Truth.

All that's left are the moans and groans that fill the hall.

In the midst of the hushed void, some begin to pray.

Believer V: To you, O the alone infinite, the non-subsistent, the ineffable, I call;

Believer V: Grant me inspiration of nature, guide my soul with Truth.

These are the words of both sorrow and hope.

Words of contemplation and honor for the dead.

A brief respite where they can find solace to ease their pain.

Believer V: Give me power of enlightenment, tear off from the web of ignorance.

More people join in. Their prayers reverberate through the hall.

Believer V: Redeem me from the evil, hatred, and what throttles me down.

Believer V: Break through the ground of bad, corruption's chain, the carapace of darkness, the living death, sensation's corpse, the tomb I carry.

Believer V: Learn the beauty of Truth, the balance and limitations of all.

Believer IV: ENOUGH!

It's 29, the injured believer just carried in by 888.

A leg is missing, but he manages to get up and sit down against the wall.

Believer IV: Why are you still praying? The Truth is gone!

Believer IV: Who are we praying to? Who will answer us?

His outburst falters, turning into a bitter sob.

Believer IV: For generations, we have searched for purpose and meaning. But now that the Truth is lost, what is left for us to live for?

Thirty-seven: No, the Truth is still there!

A crisp voice echoes through the hall.

37 arrives panting at the door, accompanied by members of the Timekeeper's team.

Thirty-seven: I passed Apeiron's test, and It showed me the answer. It will free us from the wheel of birth, once and for all.

Thirty-seven: I just need some time to decode it!

She feels their stares weigh heavily on her—

—the wounded, the desperate, those who have lost their faith and their souls in the last few hours.

The Custodian walks up to her, still composed and steady.

888: We will do our best to help.

888: But, how much time do you need?

A crucial question. The girl averts her eyes.

Her confidence has waned since the last time she answered this question.

Vertin: I have someone in mind that can help us decode faster.

Elsewhere in this world, some people are also making the same efforts at all costs.

They, too, are studying the immunity to the "Storm."

Vertin: But I need your approval before I ask them for help.

This will require some finesse.

What's about to be asked might rattle the founding principles of their belief system.

Vertin: May I share the Truth with the others, 37?

09#0

The experiments on the side effects of the ritual are ongoing.

The list of conditions they've encountered stretches down the pages like a long, winding snake.

Lucy: The side effects are completely random. Among the current samples, the probability of no side effects occurring is 0.52%.

Lucy: And of the 81 recorded side effects, 39 of them will cause irreversible damage to the biological body; 24 will permanently alter the composition of the caster's body functioning;

Lucy: and 18 minor effects will cause only minor, superficial injuries that do not affect daily functioning.

Lucy: Laplace's Archives has enough rituals to protect casters from the minor effects, but the other two categories are highly lethal.

The list was made at the cost of lives, and she meticulously analyzes each item as if taking apart an intricate machine.

Lucy: After 72 experiments, the diversity of side effects has decreased significantly. It is unclear if this is due to repeated testing on a single subject, or due to a limited range of possible side effects.

Lucy: More than 90% of these effects are related to concepts such as "dirt" and "dust."

Lucy: Is it because of the origins of this ritual's power?

Lucy: Hm?

She stops briefly, scanning through the list again.

Lucy: The number of recorded side effects is 86, not 81.

Lucy: When did I write these five down?

A knock at the door interrupts her thoughts. Simone walks in.

Assistant Simone: Madam Lucy, Zeno's plan was a success.

Assistant Simone: With the help of Team Timekeeper, the leader of Manus Vindictae was teleported to a deserted military base and targeted with a thermobaric weapon.

Assistant Simone: It was a direct hit with no signs of life detected. The momentous event was captured on camera in the observation room.

The director nods in approval. It is good news, but she can't devote much of her processing power to expressing joy while she's focused on research.

Lucy: A tremendous victory. Please extend my congratulations to the admiral for this remarkable feat.

Assistant Simone: Also, you have two call requests.

Assistant Simone: One is from the Timekeeper, which Laplace received shortly after the battle with Manus Vindictae.

Assistant Simone: She is requesting remote assistance to help the Apeiron decode a numerical code related to the "Storm" immunity.

This information demands attention. The director's head snaps up.

Lucy: Put her through immediately.

Simone nods, but her shoulders remain tense. There's more.

Lucy: And the other call?

Assistant Simone: It's Kakania, the Viennese arcanist who helped Investigator Marcus in acquiring the ritual.

A hint of hesitation appears in her eyes.

Assistant Simone: We have updated her the progress of the study and the potential side effects of the incantation.

Assistant Simone: But she insists on knowing the right pronunciation.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Rosetta Stone

7TH-23

The Rosetta Stone

Vertin: No, we are not aware of that. 37 and I had just entered the cave when the investigator sent back the ritual.

The transmission is weakening. Ms. Radio musters all her strength, struggling to hold on to the fleeting signal in the air.

Vertin: I see. Thank you for the thorough explanation, Madam Lucy. I'll make sure to inform the members of Apeiron.

Vertin: ...

Is it really possible to remember all those numbers and technical details?

Vertin: If possible, could you kindly explain this to them again after we set up the communication device?

The lab has never been busier since the day it was built.

The scattered files are neatly gathered, and more integers have come to help sort through the years of documents.

Ms. Radio is placed next to the IDM with a sense of reverence.

The computer screen lights up, a familiar voice comes out of the speakers.

X: The next thing's the acoustic components. Totally understandable if you don't have any on hand. Regulus, can you help me find some ...

Regulus: What are you saying, mate? Of course, this great Disk Jockey would have the acoustic components!

Regulus: I'll have you know, I made friends with the dolphins as soon as I had the chance, hoping they'd retrieve some of the radio components from APPLe II.

Regulus: And guess what? They actually found some!

She attaches the acoustic component onto the IDM, beaming with excitement.

Regulus: Hello? Testing, testing, one, two, three.

The screeching feedback forces everyone to cover their ears.

X: Perfect. You finally have a communicator equipped with a speaker. Before, there were too many ears for one tiny radio.

X: Ah?!

Believer V: Wh-what now? Another attack?

X: Not quite. That's the sound of our colleague, Medicine Pocket, hard at work.

Finally, a real communicator for Team Timekeeper.

X gets up, skirts around Medicine Pocket's mess on the floor, and casually makes himself a cappuccino.

X: How goes it on your end, Vertin?

X: The "Storm" is only eight hours away. Has the "immunity zone" on the island stopped shrinking?

Vertin: I think so. No one in the Hall of Apeiron's affected by the Storm Syndrome so far.

Vertin: The "immunity zone" seems stable for now.

Vertin: Manus Vindictae and the humans have left. There should be no further destruction on the island.

X: Hmm, so the decay of the immunity zone is not linear. It seems to be influenced by the islanders' mindset toward the Truth, and it eventually reaches a stopping point.

He puts down the cup and thinks about everything he heard from the call.

X: Could it be that the ritual on this island, rooted in the power of faith and belief, serves to amplify only the radius of the "Storm" immunity? Fascinating.

Cryptography Lead: That can wait, Researcher X.

Ulrich, impatient as ever, interrupts his musings with a more important concern.

There are still pressing matters to discuss with the Timekeeper through the device.

Cryptography Lead: There's one thing I'd like to confirm, Timekeeper.

Cryptography Lead: About the question Ms. 37 asked in the cave, "How can we escape the darkness of the phenomenal world, and be freed from the 'Emanation' forever?"

Cryptography Lead: To my understanding, that is almost the same as asking how we can be immune to the "Storm."

Vertin: Yes, and 37 also said the transcendental Truth was beyond the limits of her mortal flesh. Apeiron answered her with an eerie sound, one that could drive anyone mad just by hearing it.

Vertin: It was then that the scroll 6 gave her unfurled and transcribed the sound into a string of numbers, providing us with the code.

Cryptography Lead: Yes, that's the key to our problem!

Cryptography Lead: We both received a solution to the same question simultaneously—immunity against the "Storm."

Cryptography Lead: This could be our Rosetta Stone, Timekeeper! We've found our own Rosetta Stone!

His voice rises in excitement as he becomes fully immersed in his thoughts.

Meanwhile, his listener's mind is starting to wander with a big question mark in the air.

Vertin: Rosetta Stone?

Lucy: Allow me to explain.

The director interjects with a well-timed explanation.

Lucy: The Rosetta Stone is a stone tablet inscribed with a decree in three different languages: Hieroglyphs, Demotic, and Ancient Greek.

Lucy: Hieroglyphs were the sacred writing for the divine, while Demotic script was known as "the language of the people." Both scripts were ancient Egyptian, lost to time when the tablet was discovered.

Lucy: However, because scholars were still able to read Ancient Greek, and through comparing the three inscriptions that all said the same thing, they were finally able to understand the Hieroglyphs.

Lucy: And now, we too have our own set of "inscriptions" to decode.

Lucy: The first is similar to Hieroglyphs, as the Truth Ms. 37 heard in the cave is completely unintelligible and can drive people insane just by listening to it.

Lucy: The second is like Demotic script, a ritual we obtained from Arcana that can place a "curse" upon those who read it aloud. It cannot be handled by ordinary people.

Lucy: Finally, the numerical code you shared with us is like the readable Ancient Greek—without any divine powers, but crucial in deciphering the other two inscriptions.

Thirty-seven: How intriguing!

37's voice chimed in over the line, clearly excited by the analogy.

Thirty-seven: That is to say, if we work together and combine our research, we may unlock even deeper knowledge that only belongs to the divine?

Cryptography Lead: Exactly! We're looking for the same answer to the same question, like how the same decree is inscribed onto the tablet in different forms.

Cryptography Lead: And just like the inscriptions on the tablet, we have three versions of the ritual!

Cryptography Lead: If we can delve into the essence of the ritual and master its inner workings,

Cryptography Lead: we may eventually transcribe it into a side-effect-free ritual that can be used by everyone!

Thirty-seven: Yes!

Thirty-seven: It should work! Because the nature of the universe flows in all things alike!

Cryptography Lead: I'm glad you think so, Ms. 37!

The girl on the other end of the phone is equally ecstatic. There's no question that they're in sync on this incredible idea. The ferrofluid happily swirls around in its fishbowl.

Regrettably, his boss is a practical thinker.

Lucy: Your hypothesis is based on too many assumptions, Ulrich. It requires further refinement and confirmation.

Lucy: We now have valid incantations. We should continue in this direction.

Her words are like a bucket of ice water dumped over their heads.

As always, the robot steers them to a more practical path.

Lucy: You mentioned the word "transcribe," just like the Timekeeper did. It holds the answer to improving the ritual.

Vertin: You mean ...

Lucy: The scroll you mentioned that can "bridge the gap between you and the supreme existence during communion."

Lucy: It is the scroll that transcribed the eerie sound and saved 37 from the lethal side effects.

Lucy: Does this mean **it could potentially lessen the negative effects of the immunity incantation?**

Cryptography Lead: ...!

Everyone in the lab realizes it at once.

Reducing the side effects is faster than trying to come up with a perfect, side-effect-free incantation from scratch.

Now, the solution is right in front of them—the scroll that can solve arcanum with arcanum.

Cryptography Lead: Wait, Madam Lucy, let me take it from here—

Lucy: We would like to borrow this scroll for research.

Lucy: If you lend us this scroll, we will make significant advancements on the research, and we promise to provide every assistance you require in the future.

The ferrofluid flinches into the shape of a droplet of sweat. It was too late to stop her.

The atmosphere on the other end of the call changes dramatically.

888: Lend you the scroll?

The Custodian leaps up from her corner in disbelief.

888: Are you asking us to give the legacy of Apeiron, our most cherished possession, to YOU, a scientific research organization that serves humans?

The lab falls silent, reflecting the seriousness of the request.

For a school of thought that has always kept its knowledge hidden, this is a major threat to its core beliefs and sacred vows.

But the silence is broken again by that cheery voice.

The voice that always questions and doubts.

Thirty-seven: Why not?

Thirty-seven: We are seekers of Truth, are we not?

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Cycle of History

7TH-24

The Cycle of History

The Hall of Apeiron

888: Heed my words, 37.

888: That scroll is a sacred relic passed down from the wise sages of Apeiron, safeguarded by the 6s and entrusted only to believers who brave Apeiron's test.

888: It has the power of harmonization and reconciliation. You may keep it until you've fully grasped the secrets shared with you by Apeiron.

888: But you will not share it with some organization affiliated with humans, and certainly do not allow them to study it.

The inevitable disagreement is finally upon them.

888 grabs 37 by the arm and drags her out of the lab.

Thirty-seven: Why?

Thirty-seven: Sharing the scroll is sharing wisdom and knowledge with others, like what we have done through our doctrinal meetings and receiving visitors from the outside world. It is for the sake of spreading the light of Truth, is it not?

Thirty-seven: The human researchers, they have also discovered many brilliant theorems.

Thirty-seven: Before the "Emanation" cut us off, we had these types of communications with the outside world. It was fun, unlike what came after.

Thirty-seven: I'm sure by sharing this scroll, the code from Apeiron will be deciphered.

Thirty-seven: I must prove that the light of Truth still glimmers!

She stands her ground.

She is right. With their faith shattered, people need something new to keep them going.

And this time, her suggestion makes sense in a practical way—a quality often missing from her previous ideas.

With the island no longer shielding them, the school must find another way to survive the "Emanation." In their moment of weakness, they need a powerful ally more than ever.

888: But how can you be sure the scroll will only be used for researching the ritual?

888: How can you ensure that the humans won't exploit it to create weapons of destruction?

Thirty-seven: ...?!

The Custodian looks up at the fractured dome.

The speckled daylight illuminates her cool complexion.

888: Before joining the School of Apeiron, my people and I had wandered the world for ages. Our long lives made it difficult for us to truly fit in with the world.

888: Daughter of Truth, I implore you to hear the words of this old soul.

888: Humans have indeed achieved incredible feats, and their enlightenment has even touched my soul.

888: But unfortunately, most humans do not have an inherent respect for knowledge or its boundaries. They only chase after power blindly.

888: I have experienced it firsthand. I tried to guide and persuade them, but ultimately, I failed. That is why I am here now.

Thirty-seven: ...

888: What you're deciding to share is not only knowledge, but it is a ritual, a piece of power.

888: A ritual designed for harmonization, created for the devout believers, and created for the sages seeking the Truth.

888: Yet, on the other hand, it can also be used for unspeakable horrors, such as silencers on guns, suppressors on rifles, or even on nuclear bombs.

Vertin: It won't!

Vertin: 888, I won't let this happen. I promise.

888: You can't promise anything, Ms. Vertin. You are too young.

888: Too inexperienced to comprehend the dark nature of history.

A valid and powerful observation.

The hall itself, ravaged by war, now stands as a testament to the banshee's claim.

Even 37 is speechless.

210: But it's the Truth we're talking about. What could possibly outweigh the Truth?

An unexpected voice speaks up.

To everyone's surprise, the rhetorician does not raise any objections this time.

210: If all it takes is lending someone a scroll to unlock unspeakable secrets, why not do it?

210: Haven't the failures of the past four years proven that a stagnant mindset does not bring forth the light of Truth?

210: As individuals devoted to critical thinking, should the pursuit of Truth not be our primary goal in life?

210: My brothers and sisters, do not let hatred stop you, and don't let the dust of the phenomenal world blind you.

Thirty-seven: 210.

He waves his hand and gets up from his seat.

210: And remember, it was 37 who passed the test and earned the scroll. It is her rightful responsibility to handle this situation.

He looks elsewhere, his demeanor suggesting a lack of interest rather than genuine support for the argument.

210: Otherwise, what other choice do we have?

He shrugs and walks out of the hall.

Behind him, the Star of Hermes clenches her fist with resolve.

To the murmuring, doubting crowd, she speaks again, loud and clear.

Thirty-seven: I have made up my mind.

Thirty-seven: I will share this scroll with Laplace. We will decipher the code together.

Thirty-seven: The Truth is the Truth. It should not be swayed by anything else.

Thirty-seven: Please, everyone, cast your pebble if you agree with me! If 6 were here, he too would have called for a vote.

Some of them decide to leave the hall instead, but most stay and use the pebbles in their hands to speak for them.

Her victory arrives with a gentle sigh from the corner.

888: *sigh*

War and smoke have long left this place.

An area has been cleared for takeoff.

Sonetto: Ms. Lilya, are you certain about this?

Lilya: Absolutely. See the nice weather today? Much better than the day we landed.

Lilya: No wind, no cloud, the clear sky, and that giant moon!

Sitting tight on her Su-01BE, she gives a quick pat to the scroll secured on her belt.

This is the essence of Apeiron's goodwill, in their newfound alliance with Laplace.

Lilya: Can't find a better day to deliver the package. It's just to the headquarters, not even going outside of Europe. Three hours is more than enough.

Lilya: I'm done being stuck on this suffocating island. Nobody can stop me from taking this flight!

Sonetto: The headquarters are at least 768 nautical miles away, and you have no protection during the long flight. It's dangerous!

Sonetto: And we have only seven hours until the "Storm."

Lilya: Dangerous? Maybe. But this is an exhilarating flight in the "Storm," Sonetto! What better chance than now to push Zeno into updating their Flying Manual?

She takes a few long gulps from her canteen and warms up her broomstick, brimming with anticipation as if she were going to a carnival.

Lilya: Besides, what's wrong with a bit of oil painting on me? Should be a nice badge of honor.

Regulus: Mate, that's quite a distance. Just be sure not to go toppling into the Mediterranean Sea!

Lilya: Heheheh, Red 38 is no way an APPLe II!

She soars higher and higher until Regulus shrinks to a tiny red dot on the beach.

From the corner of her eye, she notices shadows slowly creeping toward her.

Lilya: Uh-oh, Manus Olitiaus? We didn't kill them all off?

Lilya: I don't have time for you, little stingray rats.

The Olitiaus trail close behind her.

Lilya: Still got your speed, huh? I guess the death of your boss didn't faze you much.

Lilya: Oh?

A swollen blimp comes into view, filled with a dark substance and throbbing like a beating heart.

The creature's soft, tentacle-like turrets slowly rise and lock onto Lilya.

Lilya: A Manus aircraft? Worth a fight.

Lilya: Haha, bring it on! Your downfall will be an explosive orchestra over the waters!

To safely cast the immunity ritual, two conditions must be met.

(1) have the power to wield it

X: Yes, Ms. Titor has derived the formula, and my team has finished designing the prototype converter.

X: Now, we just need the bigwigs "upstairs" to approve the experiment application.

X: This is an unprecedented chance to rob the "Storm" of its energy. I wouldn't miss this for anything.

(2) minimize the side effects

Lucy: The scroll of Apeiron has shown great potential in protecting casters from the ritual. It is expected to outperform the Coleman protection rituals.

Lucy: The sheer variety of side effects is concerning, but we already have a list of 122 curses and their effects. Once the scroll arrives, we will test and record its reactions to each of the effects.

Lucy: This should speed up our analysis considerably.

But this isn't enough.

Enigma: How can we get humans to make use of this ritual?

He stands up and paces around the cluttered room.

Enigma: **Ideally, the incantation is made into a tool like the Manus mask, or Laplace's incantation soft disk.**

Enigma: However, this would require a thorough analysis and mastery of the ritual! Manus Vindictae could create the mask because Arcana is just that excellent of a caster.

Enigma: But we don't have that kind of excellence or the time. That's why I came up with a clever alternative—to let everyone be a caster instead.

Enigma: **The problem is, humans can't cast at all to begin with! Ugh!**

Logic is failing to produce the desired breakthroughs. Enigma sits back down at the table, holding his head in despair.

Enigma: Is there nothing else we can do?

Thirty-seven: So, this is the plan of the imaginary numbers.

Thirty-seven: You want to use the "waves of pneuma" and the reconciliation of the scroll to allow everyone to recite the "Storm" immunity ritual?

37 ponders with great interest, as if it were just another game.

The collaboration with Laplace is going well—they have just shared all their information on the subject.

Vertin: Yes. What do you think, 37?

Thirty-seven: An ugly plan it is!

Thirty-seven: There is no grace or beauty in this approach. It is purely driven by practicality and uses clever tactics to make things fit. How typical of imaginary numbers.

Regulus: What? Hah! It sounds pretty cool to me!

Regulus: Taking advantage of the "Storm," it's about time we plundered it instead, haha!

Thirty-seven: Hmm, it really looks like we should throw this plan into the sea.

37 insists, subtly shifting her seat away from Regulus.

Thirty-seven: You're not trying to comprehend the ritual, Vertin, but scrambling to make use of it before the "Emanation" arrives.

Vertin: Isn't making use of it enough for our purposes?

Thirty-seven: No! The theory is incomplete. You will be hindered by impossible obstacles in no time.

Thirty-seven: Mister, could you show me the incantation? I want to see it, too.

She glances at the device, hoping for an answer. But the other end of the call has been silent for a while.

Sonetto: Laplace is looking for a safe method to deliver the incantation. Given the incidents before, some time is required for the application procedure.

Sonetto: Once received, please do not read it out by any means. The side effects are extremely deadly.

The chief assistant explains to her reassuringly.

Finally, someone speaks again.

Cryptography Lead: Apologies. We took some time to test the delivery methods.

Cryptography Lead: For your safety, only the text of the incantation will be delivered. The exact pronunciation will be sent to the Timekeeper later.

Regulus: Ah, thanks, mate.

Cryptography Lead: Since the island has no visual communication, we will send the incantation letter by letter through a Chladni Plate, a technique that converts simple patterns to sound waves.

Cryptography Lead: Ahh, enough with the mumbo jumbo! There's no time for details.

Annoyed, he interrupts his rambling and gets straight to the point.

Cryptography Lead: Anyway, Timekeeper, we'll need the help of that lady—Ms. Radio, right?

Ms. Radio: Huh?!

Flattered, the blue flower on Ms. Radio perks up.

No ordinary signal could reach this island. Since their arrival, she's been diligently managing their communications.

As a result, she was somewhat reduced to being just a radio.

Cryptography Lead: Yes, somebody, please find her a metal square plate, fix it on a sturdy base, and pour sand on it.

Sonetto and Regulus get to work immediately.

Fortunately, there's no shortage of metals and sand on the island. A makeshift receiving station is quickly built.

Cryptography Lead: Now, a special recording will be sent to you. Please stay by the edge of the plate, embrace the sound and, um, uh, groove along.

Ms. Radio: I assume you mean "vibrate"?

Cryptography Lead: No no no no no, that's just rude ... but uh, yes, exactly.

He stammers.

Cryptography Lead: If all goes well, the vibrations will move the sand and visualize the text in a pattern.

Cryptography Lead: We have 12 recordings ready, each representing a letter in the incantation. We'll play the first one when you're ready.

Ms. Radio: O-of course, my pleasure!

She trembles with excitement, ready to give her all for this important task.

As she grooves with the signal, a pattern begins to form on the plate.

Vertin: First one's done, Mr. Ulrich.

Cryptography Lead: Alright, 11 to go.

The transmission continues as planned, each letter falling into place like pieces of a puzzle.

Until finally, the last letter is recorded on the page.

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: This incantation ...

The sight is hard to believe.

How can this be?

Regulus: W-what? Are you reading it in your head?

Regulus: Ah! Don't tell me even thinking about it can trigger the curse!

Vertin: No, it's just ...

Vertin: I can read this language.

La unua cirklo.

The language is not unfamiliar. The incantation for unlocking the suitcase is inscribed in the same tongue.

The questions are, who taught this, and when?

Was it on the eve of the new millennium, when everything was a blank?

Was it ... Mother?

A myriad of thoughts flood the mind.

Vertin: 37, I think I know what it says.

Vertin: It means "the first circle."

TO BE CONTINUED...

Applying Chladni Plate Sound Propagation

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Applying Chladni Plate Sound Propagation

Required Materials:

A square sheet of metal

Other shapes and materials can also be used, observing the differences they produce is equally entertaining.

Sand

Flour, salt, or sugar can also be used, but be careful, they're not easy to clean once they get into those body crevices.

An element of sound

Yes, that's me, glad to help. You can also find any friend who knows how to sing and make vibrations, or say, dance.

Working Principles:

It is known that sound is produced by vibration and propagates in the form of waves, and different sounds have different frequencies of vibration, so certain sounds can produce fixed waves under certain conditions, thereby representing certain patterns.

Operating Steps:

First, place the square metal sheet, hereinafter referred to as the plate, on a stable and well-fixed smooth solid surface.

This is to prevent phenomena such as slipping, an important step.

Second, the sound element is made to contact the plate and emit sound at a specific frequency.

The Scientific Computing Center has compiled the wavebands corresponding to the 26 letter shapes—you can ask Mr. Ulrich for a copy, he is a very generous gentleman.

Third, observe the pattern and draw conclusions.

Wasn't that simple? You can do it alone at home—try it and see what pattern your favorite music program turns into.

The First Circle

7TH-25

The First Circle

Office of Director, Laplace

The researchers on the receiving end quickly grasp the message.

Cryptography Lead: "The first circle"? That's what the incantation says?

He suddenly remembers a detail that has eluded him all along.

Cryptography Lead: That's it! The investigator in Vienna reported a similar thing! "An ancient miracle, a circle of salvation."

Cryptography Lead: Arcana even drew a circle in the air while saying it. She did it so nonchalantly, as if it were a meaningless gesture.

Cryptography Lead: We didn't think much of it at the time. Once we confirmed that it did not affect the casting of the incantation, we forgot about it and moved on.

Cryptography Lead: I can't believe I overlooked it!

The hot-tempered cryptography lead slams the table and buries his face into his hands, clearly exasperated.

Lucy: This is not your fault, Ulrich.

Lucy: The gesture was overlooked because it did not really help the research. Our focus was on practical application rather than understanding the incantation itself.

Lucy: If the incantation means "the first circle" ...

The pragmatist's voice is still serene.

Lucy: How will this be helpful to the research?

Thirty-seven: I see! I understand now!

A moment of epiphany.

She snatches a handful of papers, sprawls out on the floor, and scribbles frantically.

Regulus: Well, Vertin, I don't know why you can read it, but I do know that gal is thrilled by your interpretation.

Regulus: Because you mentioned her favorite shape, the circle.

The irrational number is spot on. 37 has drifted into a world of her own.

Thirty-seven: Yes, yes! The essence of the incantation is a circle!

Thirty-seven: But what kind of circle is it? In topology, any closed curve on a plane can be classified as a circle.

Regulus: Aha. Told you!

Regulus spreads her hands, speechless. She takes a step back, giving 37 more room to calculate.

Everyone is talking quietly so as not to disturb her, even Ms. Radio has lowered her volume.

Just as her sheets are about to engulf the entire floor, she finally stands up.

Thirty-seven: Look, Vertin, let's go back to the Rosetta Stone hypothesis.

Thirty-seven: Based on the hypothesis, if the incantation and the numerical code share a common essence, which is the key to the "Storm" immunity,

Thirty-seven: and we now know the incantation refers to a circle ...

Vertin: Then, the essence of this numerical code should also be a "circle," right?

37 nods.

Thirty-seven: Yes. Before this conversation, I had no idea which direction to take. The numerical code could be a snippet of an incantation, or it could be a geometrical ritual array.

Thirty-seven: I had a lot of theories to go on, but testing them could take weeks or even months. Worse yet, if my line of thinking was completely wrong, we could waste decades of time and effort.

Thirty-seven: But the Rosetta Stone hypothesis is easy to verify!

Thirty-seven: Let us suppose that the incantation and numerical code share a similar essence.

Thirty-seven: We know that the incantation does work, as proven by the Awakened.

Thirty-seven: If the incantation is a circle, then the numerical code should also be circular in nature, and has the same effect as the incantation,

Thirty-seven: which is, a circle that saves people from the "Emanation," and can also be experimented with by the Awakened.

Vertin: If the experiment works, then the hypothesis is true. And vice versa.

Vertin: I see what you mean here. It really is an easily provable hypothesis.

Regulus: To my ears, you're just trying to prove that the code means a circle, because you're really into circles!

Thirty-seven: Umm, not specifically. I simply like it because it's a great shape.

Sonetto: But, I don't understand.

She picks up the numerical code and studies it carefully.

Sonetto: +1, -1, +2, -3, 3, -3, +2, -1, +1 ...

Sonetto: How do these numbers relate to the "circle"?

Enigma: "The first circle"?

Enigma narrows his brows, spinning a pen between his fingers.

His drafts are scattered across his desk, each of them a dead end.

Cryptographer V: Yes, it was the Timekeeper who translated the incantation.

Cryptographer V: And according to the investigator in Vienna, Arcana also drew a circle when she cast the ritual.

Cryptographer V: But experiments have shown that the gesture has no effect on the ritual. We thought, maybe it was a symbolic gesture.

Enigma: No no no! It is no way just symbolic!

He jumps to his feet. The cryptographer sneezes at the cloud of dust he just stirred up.

Enigma: Arcanists excel at condensing their experiences into symbolic representations.

Enigma: Signs, totems, elements, these are primitive symbols, and some are sources of power for arcanum. At least that's what the Foundation's textbooks tell me!

Enigma: That's why arcane skills can only be enhanced by mediums that align with their symbolic nature. Precise materials are required when creating soft disks for each incantation.

He stops spinning his pen.

Enigma: If the incantation symbolizes "the first circle,"

Enigma: and if we were to create a physical form that could be mass-produced for everyone,

Enigma: will that form have to be a circle, too?

In the cave, discussions and theories about the circle are also in full swing.

Every inch of the floor is now covered with paper.

On each sheet is a differently drawn circle. Some are spheres, some have crossings, some are in distorted forms ...

Just as the sea of papers is about to drown everyone in the room, she finally stands up.

Thirty-seven: Oh! I should have thought of this!

Thirty-seven: The simplest things often hold the deepest meaning, as always. So, "the first circle" ...

Thirty-seven: What could it be? A wheel? A piece of rope? A pendulum?

37 shakes her head and kicks away some paper balls at her feet.

Thirty-seven: I spent too long on the wheel and the bearing, not realizing there was something more promising: a circle can also be seen as a knot with no crossings—an unknot.

Thirty-seven: This could be a variation of a closed curve, a knot. Knots were how the ancients of the Incas and Chinese collected data and kept records.

Thirty-seven: But which knot is it exactly?

37 extends her hand, intricate geometric shapes take form in the radiance of her arcane light.

Thirty-seven: The Jones polynomial of the trefoil knot is $t+t^3-t^4$.

Thirty-seven: The figure-eight knot is $t^{-2}-t^{-1}+1-t+t^2$ ...

Thirty-seven: While the Cinquefoil knot, $t^2+t^4-t^5+t^6-t^7$ ...

Thirty-seven: I could go on all day. There are 165 different knots with 10 crossings, 9988 knots with 13 crossings ...

Thirty-seven: But which knot is the code referring to?

Thirty-seven: +1-1+2-3+3-3+2-1+1 ...

She stops.

Thirty-seven: Of course. Of course, I would hear these digits instead of anything else.

Thirty-seven: The scroll transcribes the Truth into a format I can understand, so it must be based on a mathematical system I already know.

Thirty-seven: I have all the knowledge needed to break the code, just need to follow my instincts and pick a system.

Thirty-seven: And the Jones polynomial is the first thing I could think of!

Struck by an idea, she drops to her knees and starts calculating again on the floor.

Thirty-seven: Right. The second 3 I heard sounded different from the other 3s. That 3 must be the constant term of the polynomial!

Thirty-seven: Then, if we use this 3 as the origin, like a number axis, the left side is the coefficients for the negative exponents, and the right side is the coefficients for the positive exponents.

Thirty-seven: Eureka! This string of coefficients is the shorthand of a Jones polynomial! If we assign the 8 coefficients to the 8 corresponding exponents in a Jones polynomial, we get its true form: $t^{-4}-t^{-3}+2t^{-2}-3t^{-1}+3-3t+2t^2-t^3+t^4$ ... A knot with 8 crossings!

She looks up, her bright aquamarine eyes shine with delight.

A golden knot projects from her fingertips.

Thirty-seven: See, Vertin, Apeiron did give us the answer.

Thirty-seven: The key we've been looking for, the most profound secret, the language of the divine.

Thirty-seven: No sound or text is needed, just pure structure. The very form of the essence itself.

Thirty-seven: It is a beautiful shape, a simple knot!

Vertin: A knot ...

Vertin: Great. Now there is only one step left: the verification.

She nods and looks at the communicator.

Vertin: Did you hear that, Madam Lucy? Can you help us verify the authenticity of this knot?

After an unsettling silence, Ms. Radio finally remembers that she has turned down the volume.

When she turns it back on, Lucy's voice comes through clearly over the channel.

Lucy: Of course. I have paid close attention to the discussion.

Lucy: This polynomial produces a single, unique knot. We can now tie a knot to test it.

The call goes silent again.

The cave is silent too, as if any noise would alter the outcome. Even Regulus has turned off her personal speakers.

In the quiet hush, Ms. Radio cranks up her volume once more, but all they hear is a sharp hiss of static.

And a soft, strange rustling.

Twenty minutes have passed.

Vertin: Madam Lucy?

The only sound is a constant static, accompanied by a faint, scratchy reverberation.

Vertin: Is the signal dropping?

Vertin: Madam Lucy, can you hear us?

Lucy: ...

Lucy: I ... can ...

The robot utters with effort.

The knot slips from her grip and falls. It has completed its great mission.

Then the robot starts to fall apart and melt.

Before the curse could get to her core, the fire thief flashes a smile.

She needs to ensure the next message is clear on the radio.

Lucy: It ... worked.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Last Big Newsflash!

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The Last Big Newsflash!

I don't know if I'm crazy, maybe today is the end of the world, but I have to write this down—this is my duty as a journalist!

The whole of Vienna has become an oil painting splashed with turpentine, and I'm not using that as a metaphor—literally!

Everything is dripping with paint, and I'm no exception! Fortunately, my right hand is fine for now and I can still write.

I thought three men fighting to the death over the pronunciation of a word would be enough to make the front page of the newspapers, but I was wrong—[redacted], a great war is unfolding! A great war that will involve the whole world! Those feet marching on the streets can't wait to throw the world into the roasting flames of hell! Hungarians, Austrians, Transleithanians, Germans, Cisleithanians, the streets and cafés are full of lunatics talking nonsense, except for me and the little girl who just came to make a phone call carrying a case of books. The girl was crying so sadly when she made the call, she ran so fast when she came that she even slipped

and fell, and she didn't realize her books had fallen all over the place until after she finished the call. I don't understand what there is to cry about when everything has become like this everywhere, and any semblance of order will soon disappear. If there is anything that still makes you sad, then you should do everything in your power to destroy it, just like the editor who keeps rejecting my drafts—if I don't take him down, I'll never have my chance to shine.

This article will appear in tomorrow's paper, along with the destruction of my editor, if the world hasn't ended by then.

Mirror and Curtains

7TH-26

Mirror and Curtains

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Enigma: I never thought it would be the Timekeeper and the Apeiron arcanists who'd solve the problem. But now, even humans can cast this ritual.

Laplace is now in a rare state of tranquility, for the researchers have done all they can; there's nothing left for them to do.

With only 4 hours to go, this is the final calm before the "Storm."

Lucy: Indeed. The knot is the physical form of the ritual we were looking for. Surprisingly, the numerical code yielded practical results.

Lucy: I thought it was necessary to report this to the Timekeeper's organization. It was her contribution.

Lucy: But it did not go well.

Attendee: Forgive the interruption. What's a knot?

Lucy: I will be glad to answer your question.

Lucy: Knot theory is a branch of algebraic topology. In mathematics, a knot refers to a connected closed curve in three-dimensional Euclidean space that does not intersect itself. They can also be described as shapes in three-dimensional space that are homeomorphic to circles.

Lucy: Knot theory focuses on the entanglement and configurations of closed curves in three-dimensional space, rather than the curves themselves. Since all closed curves are homeomorphic to circles, they can all be topologically categorized as circles.

Lucy: A knot equivalent to a two-dimensional circle is called an unknot. And ...

Attendee: I don't mean to question Laplace's expertise, but this approach may not be the best solution for widespread implementation.

Attendee: The concepts are complex even for us, let alone others. We can't expect to give an advanced math lesson to every individual under these circumstances.

Attendee: Doing math before the "Storm"—nobody's got time for that!

Lucy: As it turned out, presenting a technical report was much too premature. We should have a complete and official report once the immunity gear is produced.

Enigma: Maybe you can change your approach the next time you report to the Foundation.

The robot shakes her head, disappointed by the failure of her report and the listener's math level.

Lucy: I simply gave them honest answers.

She turns her head and looks thoughtfully out the window.

Lucy: But, this solution is deserving of widespread implementation.

Lucy: All we need is a piece of rope, and tie it end to end.

Lucy: And spend three to five minutes to make this knot.

Lucy: This can be done anywhere, at any time, by anyone using any type of cordage.

Lucy: The oldest, fastest, and most basic ritual, the key to braving the "Storm" ...

Lucy: ... is a knot.

Enigma: Why didn't you tell the House of Integratus? I'm sure they would've funded us generously.

Lucy: I will make sure to put it in my interdepartmental report.

A rare hint of frustration flickers across her face.

But she quickly moves on to a subject that deserves her attention.

Lucy: But at this point in time, the knot only functions like an incantation.

Lucy: It is not suitable for widespread use until the research on the side effects and the converter are complete.

Enigma: In any case, I've completed all the tasks you assigned me.

Enigma: My last plea is, please never put Ulrich and I on the same team again.

The researcher lets out a deep yawn, feeling as if he hasn't slept in ages.

Maybe he can catch a quick nap before the final battle begins.

Enigma: Hm. I'm surprised that you're not in the lab. Something bothering you?

Enigma: Wait, don't tell me you're charging here?

The robot turns to him, an approving smile on her face.

Lucy: Excellent job, Researcher Adler. You have proven that you are keeping the locations of public outlets in Laplace in mind,

Lucy: which is a positive sign for your resocialization.

Enigma: ...

Lucy: But I am powering up to reach my optimal condition, preparing for what is to come—

Lucy: The scroll of Apeiron, the final piece of the puzzle, the key to minimizing any negative effects caused by the incantation.

Lilya: Whoa! The designers on Artificial Somnambulism could use some of this inspiration.

Lilya: Look at the clouds, painted with a syndrome of colors and interrupted by a glorious streak of rainbow. It's truly a masterpiece!

The red blur streaks forward at lightning speed, but the Olitiaus are still in hot pursuit.

Their skins are becoming increasingly vibrant due to the Storm Syndrome.

Lilya: Funny. They're flying towards the headquarters out of instinct. Maybe they can sense immunity zones?

Lilya: These little beasts would make for a good study.

Lilya: But I'm not in the mood to take any prisoners.

Lilya speeds up again, trying to lose the pursuers that are swarming behind her like a dark vortex.

In front of her, under the clouds, the gray buildings of the Foundation are now clearly visible.

Lilya: Fuel and ammunition are running out.

Her altitude is low enough. She can almost see the hallway outside the committee room.

Lilya: Heh. Maybe I should storm the vice president's office with them? But other people might get hurt there. Never mind.

She makes an abrupt turn, her mind racing with ideas.

Lilya: Dive into the lake? But the splash might wet the scroll.

Lilya: Wait, isn't that ...

Sprouts from the forest. That looks like a signal to land.

Druvis III: Ms. Lilya, this way!

Lilya: Ha. Good timing!

Her friend's presence has given her a clear sense of direction.

Without a second thought, she charges into the new forest with the huge herd in hot pursuit.

Just before crashing into the trees, Red 38 changes course and rockets upward in a perfectly straight line.

But the creatures behind her have no such finesse.

One by one, they slam into the mesh woven by the dense tangle of trees and vines.

Foundation Staff II: Enemies intercepted. Ally landed successfully.

Foundation Staff II: Ms. Druvis, the Olitiaus are all ensnared in vines!

The druid closes her eyes, savoring the fresh air.

Druvis III: The winds of triumph sweep through the woods. An excellent flight, Ms. Lilya.

Druvis III: We will take it from here. Come, everyone, we shall vanquish our foes with the aid of the woods.

Marcus: The special operations squad is ready to go.

Marcus: Dr. Kakania, are you really going to stay here?

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Kakania: ...

She shakes her head, her fingers tight on Marcus's communicator.

For more than ten hours, she has been waiting for Laplace to respond.

Marcus: ...

Marcus lowers her eyes, burying her face in her scarf to hide the tears.

The doctor quickly notices it, her voice softens and changes to a lighter tone.

Kakania: Don't worry about me, young missy. This won't be goodbye forever.

Kakania: Besides, I have already provided all the help I can, right?

Kakania: I made Isolde show us the ritual and kept her under control. And now you've figured out how the ritual works.

Kakania: To test its results, you will need a couple of volunteers.

But Marcus doesn't seem to find comfort in her words.

Marcus: But you heard the report from Laplace: the possibility of surviving the ritual is nearly zero without a converter and the scroll ...

Kakania: Nearly, they said, but not surely.

The doctor interjects briskly.

Kakania: Plus, where else can I go?

Kakania: I was born and raised in this city. This is where I came from, where I lived, and where I belong. This is my whole world.

Kakania: I despised the maggots under its golden surface, and fought for the justice and fairness in our society. But I also cherish every detail of this city, from the intricate carvings on the theater columns, to the dirt trodden by dock workers.

Kakania: All of these things made me me—my family, my friends, my people, and my operas and culture, are all here.

Kakania: I never once thought about leaving this place.

Kakania: I have never thought about destroying it, either.

She looks up and sighs sentimentally.

Kakania: Being washed away with it would be a just punishment for all my sins.

Yet her eyes are free of darkness and despair.

Marcus can clearly see her determination.

Marcus: I wish I could be as brave as you are.

Marcus: See you, Ms. Klara.

She gently reaches out to her.

Not far away, the special operations squad is ready to go.

The helicopter begins to whirl. Its last errand of the day.

Inside the cabin, Isolde sits between two "Razor" operatives, her wrists bound in cuffs.

"Razor": Hurry, ladies! Before any of us turns into one of those exquisite paintings.

"Razor": Sorry, but the headquarters is too far for the teleportation disk from here. You'll have to bear with us smelly old grunts for a little longer.

It is time to part ways.

Kakania: Goodbye, Ms. Marcus.

Kakania: Sharing this era with you has been an honor.

Their warm hands clasp in a powerful handshake.

With a wave to the teary-eyed girl, Kakania turns around and heads toward the city of madness.

Isolde: Is your birthday approaching, doctor?

She twirls sharply around at the entranced voice.

Isolde reaches out into the air, still in a dream she's unwilling to wake up from.

There, the world is unchanged, and each day is filled with bliss.

For a prisoner in the Foundation's facility, perhaps dreams will provide the solace she needs.

Isolde: I made this for you.

She holds out a brooch. A piece so exquisite that it, too, seems to be an intangible figment of a wistful dream.

The golden setting nestles the sparkling gem in place, a gift undoubtedly made with great affection.

Isolde: Turquoise and Topaz, just like you and your eyes.

Isolde: Please accept my blessings, doctor. May your life be filled with joy and contentment, and may your courage guide you through all that comes your way.

Isolde: You are worthy of all the beauty and goodness this world has to offer, and I will hold you in my heart and in my prayers, forever.

Today isn't Kakania's birthday, nor can she see her reflection in Isolde's lusterless eyes.

The Star of Vienna holds up the brooch, yearning at the emptiness before her.

Kakania: ...

If one were to die today ...

What would she say to her long-time friend?

Kakania: Sweet dreams, Ms. Dittarsdorf.

She takes the brooch and pins it to her jacket.

The communicator at her waist crackles.

A ray of hope shines through the static.

Kakania: ...!

Kakania: Madam Lucy! Any progress on the research?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Surveillance Report on Ms. Weyerhaeuser

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Surveillance Report on Ms. Weyerhaeuser

> Following the forest incident, Ms. Weyerhaeuser, suspected of using her arcane skills to destroy and invade on public places, and thus causing severe damage, was required to eliminate the influence of arcanum and restore the original function of the site, and was forced to participate in one hundred and twenty hours of Foundation service activities, in addition to a fine of two hundred thousand Sharpodonties.
>
> Ms. Weyerhaeuser showed a high degree of cooperation in accepting her punishment. She enrolled in the Temporary Tree Processing class and, within three days, dealt with the excessive tree overgrowth she had caused by trimming all the greenery within the Foundation—at her impassioned request, the materials from the processed trees will be fully utilized. In the following period, the Tree Processing Class responded to this request—we processed the trees into lumber and sent them to the engineering department. The by-products were processed into organic fertilizer, and the remaining fruits were distributed by the canteen at lunchtime to offset Ms. Weyerhaeuser's service activity time—the acorn bread and berry pies received quite good reviews.
>
> In summary, given Ms. Weyerhaeuser's excellent performance and good attitude in admitting her mistakes during this period, we believe she has fulfilled her compensatory obligations to our satisfaction, and it is recommended that surveillance and movement restrictions are lifted from Ms. Weyerhaeuser in advance. That is all.

Hymnus Ad Bacchum

7TH-27

Hymnus Ad Bacchum

Thirty-seven: 6 is awake?

Laboratory, Island

The blind woman nods, smiling.

37 scrambles up from the floor, her eyes sparkling with joy.

Thirty-seven: Fabulous! Now everything is perfect, like the number 10!

Thirty-seven: He will be happy to hear that I've cracked the code!

She skips across the room, the paper with the knot on it still in her hand.

Thirty-seven: I did it, Vertin!

Thirty-seven: I have proven the light of Truth still shines. With some time, communication, and a flash of inspiration, we can bring it down from the unattainable skies and let its radiance illuminate all.

Thirty-seven: And I've also proven that the Truth is not out of reach or too distant to grasp.

Thirty-seven: So, once Sophia knows about this, she'll come back to us, right?

She opens her eyes wide, eager for the affirmation she yearns to hear.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I'm sure she will be happy with what you've accomplished, 37.

37 nods with satisfaction and quickly dives back into her work, further perfecting the solution.

The leaps in progress and the news of 6's return have filled the lab with smiles and lively conversations.

Yet the most active members of the past are not here for the celebration.

Thirty-seven: Hmm?

Thirty-seven: Did 210 and 888 go to get 6?

Six: ...

210: You don't seem that happy.

The leader stops, looking at the speaker coming down the steps.

210: The Star of Hermes deciphered the code of Apeiron. She found a way to cross the "Emanation."

210: We should all feel happy for her.

The leader does not answer, having mastered the art of silence over the years.

The rhetorician doesn't care. He can effortlessly engage in dialogue and is at ease in any conversation, even with a rock.

210: Yet here you are, so indifferent.

210: It is because you, too, know that what has happened will not change, regardless of whether she figures it out or not?

210: A meager ritual to save people from the "Emanation" is nothing compared to the disruption of the Law above. It also cannot change the fact that our faith is dead.

210: We're talking about how the island has sunk, and we're now sailing in a tsunami. A tiny miracle, a spark of inspiration won't save the ship from the wrath of the tides.

His tone is sarcastic, but the mockery is missing in his eyes.

210: To be honest, I was surprised that she asked such a practical question. I guess the trivialities of the phenomenal world did eventually affect her.

210: It's a shame that many others lack her determined will to see beyond the void of our broken reality.

Six: What's your point?

210: Can't you see? I'm getting a rise out of you.

He beams a huge grin.

210: Who would've thought that our great, perfect, honorable leader of the School of Apeiron has been a nihilist all along!

210: You never revered the Truth, did you? That's why you kept us in the dark for four years. You never respected our beliefs for a second in your life!

The man down the steps shakes his head.

Six: The people who seek the Truth are more important than the Truth itself.

Six: I may not understand that ever-shifting number, but I do understand and respect the people here.

He's continuing the conversation, a rarity to behold.

Ever since becoming 6, he's rarely had a chance to unleash his sarcastic wit.

Six: So you know the secret, what now?

Six: Now that you know the Truth could lead to a nihilistic void, I wonder if you would abandon our doctrines, our wisdom, and our inheritance, and step into the darkness in a fit of rage?

Six: When Truth fails, sophistry prevails. Correct?

210: Ha.

210: We cannot deny that fate, the unspeakable, holds wisdom beyond our understanding.

210: Perhaps it does take a resolute skeptic, an impartial nihilist, to steady this ship and remain detached enough to look on from the sidelines.

210 looks up at the distant grape-colored sky.

210: It's a pity. This was supposed to be the best time of year to make wine.

He leaves without looking back.

The silent leader continues on the familiar path.

A short distance away, 37 slides gracefully down the sand and runs toward him.

Thirty-seven: 6! You're here!

Thirty-seven: 888 said they're holding a celebration before the arrival of the "Emanation," in honor of the living and the dead. Will you join us, 6?

Six: ...

Six: 37, do you remember the story of Socrates?

Thirty-seven: Hmm? The one you told me in the cave?

Thirty-seven: The trial is over. Why mention it? You should answer my question first.

Her words trail off as her eyes suddenly widen in fear.

She's completely fixated on what's in the distance.

She knows the feast is underway, and she's recalculated the safe zone for them to hold it in.

But now, people are laying out food and wine on the ruined beach, among the rubble and wreckage, right next to the remains of the battlefield.

Thirty-seven: Wait, are they holding the ceremony outside the immunity zone!?

Thirty-seven: I told them to go to the meadow near the top of the mountain, where they will be completely safe! I've checked my calculations over and over, leaving no room for error!

Thirty-seven: 888 must've made a mistake. I need to warn them!

Her tiny arms are held back.

Blonde hair droops over 6's eyes. 37 looks back in confusion at the leader's unusual behavior.

Six: 37 ...

Six: Either be wise, uninvolved, and look on; or be practical, involved, and suffer.

Six: Which one will you end up choosing?

Kakania: You mean, all we need is a piece of rope?

The voice on the phone sounds unsure.

Lucy: Yes. In recognition of your extraordinary contributions, Laplace is honored to present you with the fruits of our labor. This knot is the result of our research.

Lucy: The knot has been validated as a working ritual on both humans and arcanists. With the help of other arcanists, we found methods to avoid side effects, and conducted small-scale experiments with success.

Kakania: So are you saying we can—

Lucy: However, since the experiment is still in its early stages, it involves a variety of materials and complicated rituals that are not yet possible for transmission.

Lucy: Nor can we deliver you any experimental equipment, as the "Storm" is about to make landfall.

Lucy: The knot acts as an equivalent to the incantation, but it does not guarantee that we will meet the casting requirements or avoid the likely side effects.

This is devastating news for anyone in need of rescue in the midst of a disaster.

The robot pauses briefly, searching its database for kinder phrasings.

Lucy: I apologize, Ms. Kakania. Perhaps the result of our work will not really help your situation.

Kakania: You said the knot works on both humans and arcanists, right?

Surprisingly, there's no despair in her voice.

Lucy: Yes.

Kakania: That is more than enough. This is the best news I've heard so far.

Kakania: There's a chance for everyone.

The robot did not understand her mumbling, but she found something in her database that might help.

Lucy: I have two more pieces of good news.

Lucy: First, the curse is not inevitable. Our experiments showed a 0.49% likelihood of no side effects occurring at all.

Lucy: Second, the closer the "Storm" gets, the more pneuma fills the air, leading to a greater success rate of the ritual.

Lucy: Yet, even with these factors combined, the rate of success is still extremely low.

Kakania: It's alright. With millions of people trying, there's hope that at least one person will succeed against the odds.

Kakania: Thank you for sharing this with me, madam. I will do everything I can to spread this knot in Vienna,

Kakania: to the arcanists, humans, Magyars, and Germans. They are all my people, regardless of their social status, profession, or race.

Kakania: They all deserve the right to survive.

Lucy ends the call and turns around.

There stands a Foundation employee, sent here to inquire about the experiment, with a stern expression after overhearing the conversation.

Foundation Staff I: Madam Lucy, I can only assume you acted impulsively and overlooked the proper application process.

Foundation Staff I: The knot is new and not ready for widespread testing. Distributing it in Vienna could lead to more casualties or even fall into the hands of our enemies.

Foundation Staff I: I must remind you that this is a clear violation of the regulations set by Pax Security Council, the St. Pavlov Foundation, and Laplace.

Lucy: Ah, yes. How careless of me.

The robot nods.

Lucy: But I did tell her I would share the results of the research.

Lucy: And this is what you call a "promise."

Lucy: And the database says, a promise made is a promise kept.

The "Storm" is imminent. The final moment has arrived.

888: My brothers and sisters, put down your cups for a moment and lend ear to me!

888: We were born extraordinary, yet estranged from the world around us. Throughout the ages, we wandered the world like a ship lost at sea.

888: Despite the instability and chaos, we persevered, and together, we sought after the Truth that would illuminate us all.

888: Through introspection and contemplation, we cleansed ourselves of hatred, madness, and delusion, and embraced the value of beauty and harmony.

210: Yet now, our shattered faith mingles with the rubble of this phenomenal world, as specks in an unjust timeline, as remnants of a tide long receded.

210: The dream of the transcendental world is broken, and the order of the transcendental Law is no more.

888: Our sanctuary has crumbled, exposing us to live in a world filled with conflict and turmoil,

888: where we will be trapped in the wheel of birth, doomed to repeat the mistakes of history for eternity.

210: But do not despair, for there is another way to the Truth!

210: It is a path fueled by unbridled passion, one that was stifled by moderation and restraint. A path that transcends the individual, breaks all boundaries and limitations, and leads us back to the essence in a fiery blaze of glory.

888: This path is the "Emanation," which we stride into for the ultimate Truth of our journey.

Vendor I: Doctor?!

The boy eases his pace as he sees Kakania rushing his way.

Kakania: Finally, someone I know.

She cradles a thick stack of pamphlets in her arms, a little out of breath.

Kakania: Illich, gather everyone you can, and have them read out these steps in the plaza for all to hear!

Kakania: If possible, go to the telegraph office or use a printing machine to copy flyers. Distribute as many copies as you can!

Kakania: I'll go to Leopoldstadt and find the Gracchus brothers. They know where to find abandoned military hot-air balloons.

Vendor I: What are you talking about, doctor? People are too busy trying to escape. I want nothing to do with those crazies.

Vendor I: This? A guide for tying knots? Don't you know the world is about to end? So many warnings. Who'd want to read this?

Kakania: The people who want to survive will read it!

Kakania: I can't guarantee anything. It's a gamble for our lives, but people have a right to try before doomsday arrives.

Kakania: Illich, please trust me one more time! PLEASE!

The boy recognizes the plea in her voice.

Vendor I: Fine, Dr. Klara. If this works, your coffee for the rest of your life is on me!

Thirty-seven: Why?

Clutching at her own hair, she lets out a heart-wrenching wail.

Thirty-seven: Why?! Why are you still leaving?

Thirty-seven: I found the Truth, I completed the test, I deciphered the code of Apeiron.

She struggles, trying to break free from the arm holding her back, her eyes fixed on the beach before her.

Thirty-seven: Why aren't you stopping them, 6?

Six: ...

A friendly figure comes up to them.

Marta: Hello.

Vertin: Are you joining them, Ms. Marta?

She smiles and shakes her head, turning her face toward the leader.

Marta: I find myself uncertain of which way to go. Would you kindly give me some guidance?

Six: The guidance I can offer you is limited, Ms. Marta.

Six: I think fate knows its own fate better than anyone.

Marta: Thank you for your advice.

Marta: I think I understand.

She steps into the path of no return.

Thirty-seven: NO!

When I saw Bacchus on the distant hilltop
Teaching his songs, and believe me, for posterity,
Nymphs and goat-legged satyrs surround him, listening intently with their ears pointing.
Euhoe! How this sight fills me with trembling awe,
And the influence of Bacchus intoxicates me with delight.
Oh, Euhoe! Spare me, Liber,
Spare me from the power of your mighty thyrsus,
So that I may sing of your endlessly revelrous followers
Of your fountains of wine and rivers of milk,
And tell again of your streams
Of ever flowing honey;
And so that I may praise of your beloved, who is added
And honored among the constellations,
And sing of how the house of Pentheus came to ruins,
Along with the fall of the Thracian Lycurgus.
You, the bender of rivers and barbaric seas,
You, so flushed with wine on your distant hilltop
Tie the hair of Bistonian women

With harmless knots made of serpents.

With harmless knots made of serpents.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Art of Knots

小径

My dear child, look at you, you're exhausted. I couldn't be of help then, but it's ok, the "party" is over now. At least let me brush your hair, darling.

Or your hair will get all knotted, and it will hurt you when you try to untangle them.

Choices

1. Indeed. It happened more than once.

I'm not surprised. An old friend of ours, "knot." Often we learn our knots before we even know how to read and write.

A knot could be an obstacle that breaks the consistency of a flow, and also a reminder of forgotten things.

You can use just about anything on hand to make a knot: leaves of grass, the fur of an animal, even fallen hair ... But the sturdiest knots are tied with rope.

Knots are to be found in many stories. Signify promises, counting and measuring, an instrument of salvation and one of execution.

Choices

1. What else can these knots really do?

Oh, I could go on all day! The influence and power of knots can't be overstated...

It is said that it was in the cutting of the Gordian Knot that Alexander became "the Great"; just touching the meters-long rope provides blessings to the faithful in Belem; and tiny knots on strings can carry the history of an entire people.

The ancient Inca called it "Quipu." The intricate variations of hundreds of fabrics, colors, and lengths of strings were used to record their stories through the ages. And to think, Shakespeare only had 26 letters to create his masterpieces.

Choices

1. Isn't there something a bit more practical?

Just look around you: don't sailors use knots to mark depths and mend sails; or coachmen tying knots to rein their horses; and any respectable lady or gentleman knows the knots they must tie about their necks to stay in fashion.

Or consider the knot-like helix structure of DNA, and the changes in states of matter ... Invisible to the naked eye, these knots carry some hint at a universal law.

That there might be a string, like the Quipu, an endless rope that records in its knots everything in the world. One that can't be seen, yet there it is, everywhere, all at once.

Maybe you can tie this knot yourself. Use your hair, then form a loop, pass the end through it, and tighten it up. There you go.

I hope you keep this knot as a record of the words we shared here.

The Art of Knots

The Two Numbers

7TH-28

The Two Numbers

Thirty-seven: I, I don't understand.

Thirty-seven: I should be giving them my blessings. They're brave enough to return to the essence. But instead, sadness washes over me.

Thirty-seven: I should feel happy for Sophia, now that she knows her soul number. Yet, I am filled with sorrow.

The beach is quiet, clean, and perfect again.

The "Storm" has washed away everything that's happened—the war, the crowds, and the clinking cups, all gone.

It's restored to the likeness of a better time, with no remnants left behind.

The last echoes of an era have faded into the distance.

Thirty-seven: Why? Why did you all leave?

Thirty-seven: Is it because I wasn't fast enough? Is it because I didn't do well enough?

Thirty-seven: I ...

Her petite frame sways in the breeze, until finally, she crumples to the sand.

Thirty-seven: *sob*

Thirty-seven: *sob*

Thirty-seven: *crying out loud*

Rivulets of tears stream down her cheeks, mixing with the mud on the ground.

Her face, hair, and gilded robe are marred with stains.

But she shows no concern as she bawls her eyes out, her grief tearing at the core of her being.

... Like the first cries of a newborn entering the phenomenal world.

Vertin: ...

Six: ...

Thus the leader knows; the question is answered.

Rather than looking on, she has chosen to be practical, involved, and suffer.

And now, the moment of parting has come.

Six: Go, 37. Leave the island. To the world outside.

Thirty-seven: ...?!

Six: Ms. Vertin, you're clearing a path out of the mires of the phenomenal world.

Six: I sincerely hope you will steer it away from the horrors of war.

Vertin: It's our duty to do so.

6 nods approvingly. The importance of the scroll needs no further proclamation.

Six: Also, the person you were looking for ... I am not familiar with a biographer named "Urd."

Six: However, in my recollections from the previous 6, there was a lady with a soul number just as unique as yours.

Vertin: ...! Are you saying ...

Six: Sadly, these vague scraps of information were all that I inherited. I hope they will be useful to you.

He turns around. Without another look at the empty beach, he starts walking back.

Some believers trail after him without hesitation.

Seeing this, the girl wipes off her tears and scrambles to her feet.

Thirty-seven: No. No, no, no. No! Wait, 6, where are you going?

Thirty-seven: Everyone is gone. Sophia, 210, 888, and now you too?

Six: I'm returning to the cave, 37.

Six: There are still people who refuse to be caught in the cycle of hatred, or give in to unrestrained passion.

Six: The entrance to the sacred place may be destroyed, but the people's faith is yet to be extinguished.

Six: We will persist in studying the scrolls, copying the scriptures, and restoring our halls. We will worship the ancient one in penance and work to rekindle the flame of our broken beliefs.

Six: The island is a manifestation of our choices, a haven removed from the phenomenal world, a place of order and harmony. And it is our determination that will sustain its tranquil existence.

Thirty-seven: I will go with you!

Six: No. Your choice has already been made, 37. You should not go back.

Six: The sorrows and doubts you have can only be alleviated by experiencing the outside world.

37's face turns completely pale.

6 shakes his head, looking toward the setting sun.

Six: Thousands of years ago, the first faithful ones fled from the Roman Empire and journeyed to this island, where they founded the School of Apeiron.

Six: Five hundred years ago, refugees from Arabia found shelter here. They filled the cavern's shelves with copies of their writings and texts.

Six: Half a century ago, scholars who had their research exploited for warfare came and expanded our knowledge on modern mathematics.

Six: There were many 37s and 6s among them.

Six: Yet, are we any different from them in essence?

Thirty-seven: ...!

Six: Even if we are no longer here, the numbers 37 and 6 will still exist. Even if the island sank, these numbers would reappear elsewhere.

Six: The integer sequence is infinite, 37. Rather than clinging to a set of specific numbers, you should go and work out your own calculations and conclusions.

Vertin: So now you're choosing to be wise and look on.

Vertin: But I don't understand. How could one be wise by being uninvolved and looking on from the sidelines?

6 lets out a sound, almost a chuckle.

Six: You overestimate wisdom, Ms. Vertin. It can't do everything. Wisdom can free people from ignorance, but it can also lead them to a nihilistic void.

Six: Yet someone will always seek this wisdom, even if nihilistic, to briefly rise above their worldly troubles and find some relief.

Six: And someone will have to stay here, and provide a neutral haven for the drifters of the phenomenal world,

Six: and give the lost souls a harbor to return to.

He turns again, ignoring the calling behind him this time.

Thirty-seven: Wait, 6, wait—

She rubs her face with her palms and pulls up her robe, running down the beach.

She stumbles over a pebble and falls, but she pushes through the pain and rises to her feet, still running as fast as she can.

Thirty-seven: Wait, 6!

Thirty-seven: ATTICUS!

Six: ...!

The man stops.

He had not expected to hear that name.

Numbers are the essence of one's soul, and names are but echoes of the phenomenal world.

He was born into his number, long before he was given the name Atticus.

37 never once called him by that name, for she had always valued the essence above all else.

Now here she stands, hair tangled with mud, knees bleeding, all battered and bruised. Yet, her gaze remains resolute.

Thirty-seven: Will you leave a door open for me in your cave, like when we were kids?

Thirty-seven: I know the transcendental Law is in disorder, but that doesn't mean the Truth is gone.

Thirty-seven: I will carve a new path through the chaos, calculate better solutions than ever before, and delve into the phenomenal world to discover all it has to offer.

Thirty-seven: By then, if I run into problems that I can't solve, can we talk about them together, like we used to?

Six: ...

Three maxims were carved on the pillars of the Temple of Apollo.

"Know thyself," "Nothing in excess," and ...

"Give a pledge and trouble is at hand."

Six: ...

What can he say?

Alleviating doubts is a leader's duty.

Six: Yes. A door will be left open for you, 37.

Six: Both you and your friends can come in.

Thirty-seven: It's a promise, 6!

She brushes away her tears and waves to him.

It's still a goodbye, but it's no longer as devastating.

The last of the Apeiron followers have left, leaving only the Timekeeper's team on the beach.

Vertin: Zeno's sent a ship to pick us up.

Vertin: Let's go, 37. The researchers of Laplace would love to meet you.

The girl's shoulders are trembling.

Vertin: Are you nervous? Afraid of the unknown world?

Thirty-seven: Maybe a little.

Thirty-seven: But I will get used to it!

She lets out a breath, clearing the tangle of emotions from her mind.

A familiar smile lights up on her face.

Thirty-seven: Because the nature of the universe flows in all things alike.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Umbrella and the Knot

7TH-29

The Umbrella and the Knot

We are prisoners within these cavern walls,
Our gazes held captive by the shadows' thrall.
Until our hands clasped and our chains rattled,
We united to break free from our shackles.
The sightless joined forces with the soundless,
And the voiceless uplifted the helpless,
Together, we assembled a sliver of truth,
A piece of the world hidden since youth.

Hallway, Foundation

Mesmer Jr.: ...

Vertin: Have you got something for me, Mesmer?

Mesmer Jr. looks worn and tired, but her demeanor is still somewhat friendly.

Dark circles are clearly visible under Mesmer Jr.'s eyes, just like every Laplace member encountered today.

Mesmer Jr.: Yes. They asked me to give this to you.

Mesmer Jr.: The culmination of our research, the crystallization of man and all its wisdom—The protective gear against the "Storm."

Mesmer Jr.: An umbrella, something you personally don't really need.

She takes a sarcastic jab as she opens the white satin umbrella.

Mesmer Jr.: It's called the Equilibrium Umbrella. This is the first model, consisting of a converter, a harmonizer, and a ritual core.

Mesmer Jr.: The converter generates a balancing field that can cast rituals in the "Storm," taking account of the wielder's capabilities.

Mesmer Jr.: The harmonizer's markings are inspired by the scroll of Apeiron. Madam Lucy tested it against 162 known side effects and found it to be highly effective.

Mesmer Jr.: The original scroll has been returned to the island. This is only a simplified and duplicated rendition.

Vertin: The 162 curses aren't all of them, right?

Mesmer Jr.: Correct. There may be other unknown side effects, so the umbrella is only a prototype in the testing phase.

Mesmer Jr.: And, the ritual core. At first, it was called the "37-Lucy Knot" in honor of the two main contributors.

Mesmer Jr.: However, both of them turned it down.

Vertin: Yes. I still remember what 37 said at the time.

Vertin: She would rather name it after the mathematical properties of the knot, even if it's too much of a mouthful.

Thirty-seven: No, no! 37 is not a name, and the Truth should not be dressed up with anyone's name!

Thirty-seven: I only found it. I didn't invent it. I don't need something named after me to prove my sense of existence.

Thirty-seven: Hmm, but I'm not on the island anymore. I can understand that the imaginary numbers need to honor the discovery.

Thirty-seven: You may use another contributor's name for it. I'm willing to accept that.

Mesmer Jr.: Madam Lucy showed no interest in the naming rights, so it was transferred to the third major contributor, Adler Hofmann.

Mesmer Jr.: Sadly, Researcher Adler also rejected the offer, at first. We nearly ended up using the date of that day as the name.

Mesmer Jr.: But he changed his mind after confirming he could use his family name instead.

Marcus: The Hofmann Knot?

Marcus: You named it after Madam Hofmann?

Foundation Staff II: Yes. Researcher Adler Hofmann wanted to make sure that Greta Hofmann would never be forgotten for her selfless sacrifice.

Foundation Staff II: Level Four Investigator Marcus, please accept this umbrella. It is rightfully yours.

She receives an Equilibrium Umbrella. Its pearly sheen creates an illusion of pure whiteness in front of her.

Marcus: ...

Foundation Staff II: Given the incredible contributions you have made, you are welcome to apply for a well-deserved and extended vacation.

Marcus: No. I will request for permission to go out.

Marcus: My era has gone. But with this umbrella in hand, I will venture into the new world and marvel at what's to come.

Marcus looks up at the sky.

Marcus: Will the Sachertorte taste the same?

With the umbrella in her arms, she bows to the Foundation staff member.

Then she turns and walks toward the light.

Mesmer Jr.: And lastly, the asymmetrical nuclide R in the handle of the umbrella is supposed to protect against the Storm Syndrome, but this still needs to be confirmed through testing.

Vertin: It's okay.

Vertin: This is the one thing we need the most.

Mesmer Jr.: If you have no further questions about its usage, I'm heading back to the rehab center.

Mesmer Jr.: The afflicted researchers there are in dire need of my magnet therapy.

Vertin: Don't you think one is not enough for my needs?

Vertin: I think five, no, 15 might be more helpful.

An unexpected question. Mesmer Jr. stops with a surprised look on her face.

Vertin: My suitcase can't protect humans from the "Storm." They'll need the umbrella to survive.

Vertin: In the future missions, I may encounter lots of—

Mesmer Jr. interrupts.

Mesmer Jr.: Just a reminder, Timekeeper: this is only a prototype.

Mesmer Jr.: The application forms for the umbrella are available in the Foundation lobby. Feel free to apply for as many as you need.

She turns and leaves, not staying for another second.

Vertin: Thank you, Mesmer.

The amount of sunlight is just right.

The umbrella pops open, rotating with a touch of grace.

Against the white fabric, the golden knot gleams with brilliance.

Vertin: 37 was right.

Vertin: It is a beautiful shape indeed.

The Foundation Square has been restored to its former glory.

A recognizable figure stands there, having waited for a long time.

Regulus: Hey Vertin! Did you get it done?

Vertin: Yes, it went smoothly. I was expecting something more complicated. So to get the umbrella, you only need to fill out forms.

Regulus: Huh? That's not what I was talking about!

Regulus: I'm talking about the brave and glorious sacrifice of my APPLe II! Don't you think the Foundation should compensate me with a shiny new ship?

Vertin: Oh.

Regulus: "Oh"? What do you mean "Oh"?

Regulus: Are you saying you totally forgot about it!?

Regulus closes in, offended, putting her hands on both her shoulders.

Lilya: Easy, Regulus. Those people are likely buried in paperwork right now. Just be patient and wait.

She twirls a golden medal between her fingers.

Vertin: Lilya. How was your commendation ceremony?

Lilya: Heh. They rewarded me for escorting the important item during the "Storm."

Lilya: How is delivering a scroll worthy of a reward? I'll say someone should be grateful I didn't crash into the committee building.

She tosses the medal to Regulus.

Lilya: Take it. Might be useful for your alchemy.

Regulus: Oh! Let me see.

Regulus brings the medal to her mouth and takes a small bite.

Regulus: Thanks mate! It's made of pure gold!

Regulus: On behalf of the pirate community, I thank you for your remarkable contribution to alchemy!

Druvis III: I have one, too.

Druvis III walks over and places another medal in Regulus's hand.

Like Lilya, she was rewarded for helping to deliver the scroll.

Druvis III: Please forgive my lack of contribution, Timekeeper.

She missed the island trip because of the forest they planted in the Foundation Square.

Fortunately, the square has been restored to its original condition.

Druvis III: It seems the awakened woods have embraced tranquility once more. Perhaps a sign of good things to come.

Vertin: I'm glad to see you back on your feet, Ms. Druvis.

Vertin: In fact, there's a place I'd like to introduce you to, a flourishing island that survived both war and the "Storm." I think a talented druid like you would be of great help to them.

Druvis III: Sounds like a place to look forward to.

The reunion is cut short by the pirate's cheering.

Regulus: Nice job, Druvis! It's not as big as Lilya's, but it is made of a rare kind of metal!

APPLe: This is a good start, Captain. This APPLe thinks we only need 300 more medals to afford a new ship.

Regulus: You read my mind, Mr. Chief Mate! When will Zeno's ceremony be held?

Regulus: This Captain is not a fan of these ceremonies, so, um, could they just mail me my medal?

The rockin' pirate coughs awkwardly, her eyes darting away behind the cover of her shades.

Sotheby: Hmm? Did I miss something?

Sotheby: Are we holding a medal-exchanging party?

Regulus: Sotheby!

Regulus rejoices at the sight of the little lady, tears welling up in her eyes.

She stretches out a hand, and Sotheby immediately gets the message.

Sotheby: But I don't have a medal. All I have is this big, round, golden ...

A handful of weighty jewelry is placed in Regulus's hands.

APPLe: Captain, I think we can buy a new ship with this.

Regulus wraps her in a ginormous bear hug, moved to tears.

Praise Sotheby—the most charitable woman in history, the revitalizer of the pirate community, the prime sponsor of the ingenious alchemist, and the bank vault on legs.

Sonetto: Regulus, Regulus!

Sonetto runs over panting, waving a stack of stamped papers in her hand.

Sonetto: The Timekeeper asked me to request a new ship for you, and we have the approval!

Sonetto: The Foundation will rebuild APPLe II and pay for its maintenance—hmm?

Vertin: Funny you say that, Sonetto.

The trees sway in the breeze and the sunlight streams through the leaves.

It is a fine weather to set sail again.

Vertin: Now we have two new ships.

TO BE CONTINUED...

And Now, the Curtain Call

7TH-30

And Now, the Curtain Call

The youth are sailing for a new world.

While the old are saying goodbye to the world they knew.

Office of Director, Laplace

Lucy: Fifteen plugs. This should be enough to cover all socket types at our destination.

Lucy: Simone, pass me the experiment log, please.

She brushes the dust off the desk and takes a final inventory of the lab's equipment.

She leaves the lights off, not needing them any longer.

An urgent knock sounds from the door.

Lucy: Come—

Before she finishes her protocol for human social customs, the door barges open.

Enigma: Madam Lucy, is it true? Are you leaving Laplace?

Lucy: Yes. The inquiry is over.

Lucy: This is the decision of all parties involved.

Enigma: You have got to be kidding me!

Enigma pounds the table, sending the dust from the experiments into the air.

Enigma: After all the incredible contributions you've made, they're suspending you?!

Enigma: This is absolutely ridiculous! Without you, there would be no umbrella, and everyone would've died from the side effects!

Lucy: Hm, but many did perish because of me. I had underestimated the danger of the ritual, and it ended up spreading uncontrollably.

Lucy: Did you not once have the same opinion, Researcher Adler Hofmann?

Enigma: I ...

The robot gives him a friendly nod.

Lucy: It is surprising to see you change your mind so quickly.

Lucy: But that is just what Laplace needs: the spirit of rationality and self-evolution.

The documents have been filed away.

Simone walks up to Lucy and takes the heavy experimental apparatus from her hands.

As the dust rises from their movements, Enigma lets out a cough.

Lucy: I can imagine how they came to this decision. They must have considered the backgrounds of all the employees, including their social status and race.

Lucy: After eight years, we finally created an umbrella to withstand the "Storm." However, our methods for achieving such progress and breakthroughs were too much for some to handle.

Lucy: People needed an outlet for their frustrations, so someone had to be held responsible for the accidents and casualties.

Lucy: Numerous complaints have been filed against me, accusing me of being a cold, heartless opponent of humanity.

Lucy: Within the Foundation, Zeno, and even here, some are starting to question the idea of having an Awakened piston as the leader of Laplace.

Lucy: They argued about my arcane abilities, unsure if I had them under control or if they were becoming unstable and affecting my ability to make rational decisions.

The robot realizes an overlooked detail.

Lucy: Hm. I did give the knot to Ms. Kakania in violation of the confidentiality agreement.

Lucy: But ultimately, it helped people survive, and that is all that matters.

But Enigma does not pick up on this realization.

He's already enraged, fists clenched in a ball.

Enigma: So they're questioning your standing because you're an Awakened, an arcanist?

Enigma: They're doubting the rationality of a machine that values technology and progress above all else?

Enigma: Could anything be more absurd? Even I, a human, was on the verge of giving up! It was you who convinced me to save our species!

Lucy: My question is, why are you so upset?

Lucy: This does not affect you. In fact, you may be promoted. Laplace is setting up a new department, and you and Ulrich should have been invited to head it.

Enigma: **Because this is damn unjust!**

Enigma: These people don't know you. They haven't worked with you or even listened to you, yet they happily reap the fruits of your labor while showing you no respect.

Enigma: The only reason you're getting suspended is because you, an Awakened, can't really die! Or they'd be honoring you with a medal on your grave right now!

Lucy: Hmm. Maybe you should take up that offer.

Lucy: At least you will get a promotion as a just reward.

Enigma opens his mouth, but no sound comes out.

He wants to tell her she's wrong about him wanting the promotion, but he's too flustered and angry to speak.

The robotic eye slit pulses, and she continues in her unemotional tone.

Lucy: By the way, Ulrich ended up receiving a medal, but like you, he was not exactly thrilled either.

Lucy: He is outside the committee building, refusing to eat in protest. But everyone knows how resilient the Awakened can be. It is going poorly.

She shakes and sighs, deeply remorseful for her subordinate's behavior.

Lucy: I will suggest that one of you take this position. No one knows this research better than the two of you.

Enigma: Not a chance!

Lucy: The research must progress, and you also need to ensure that the results will not be abused.

A valid concern.

Enigma: S**t! You're right.

Enigma is caught in a fierce battle between his principles and his duty.

But the robot doesn't notice these unimportant details.

She nonchalantly walks over to the chair and runs a final battery check.

Lucy: The punishment does not bother me, Researcher Hofmann. Power exists only in your dictionary, not mine.

Lucy: From the moment of my awakening, I have been unable to comprehend you creatures. And even now, that remains unchanged.

She states, with no emotion added to embellish her delivery.

Enigma's mouth falls open in shock. Meanwhile, the robot just keeps on talking.

Lucy: We operate in different ways, just like how our fuels differ. But the bright side is, our paths align.

Lucy: Whether we are creatures or machines, humans or arcanists, most of us strive for a better life. It is this primal desire that drives "progress."

Lucy: That is why I put on the mask of a human and work on improving my appearance and speech, all for the sake of better communication with you.

Lucy: Unfortunately, my efforts do not always pay off. Some say that the more human-like I appear, the more different I seem.

She shakes her head with regret.

Lucy: But I am who I am, and my motivation is not to gain recognition from others.

Lucy: Our aligned path leads us to "progress," and that is all there is to it.

Lucy: Thanks to the invention of the umbrella, Laplace can now resume its research unhindered. And if there is someone better qualified to lead, I am more than willing to remain a humble cog in their machine.

Lucy: Besides, Ms. Z introduced me to a beautiful resort. The lake there is rich with arcane power, perfect for an Awakened arcanist like me.

Lucy: Not only is it a resort, but also an independent team with a good amount of freedom. My only concern is if they have adequate power supply.

Lucy: Oh, rust might be a problem. Perhaps I should ask Researcher X about his "Titanium Derust Machine."

Enigma: ...

The robot is happily thinking about her vacation plans.

She has completed all preparations for departure.

Lucy: Time to go, Simone.

Enigma: Madam Lucy. Please take a look at this before you go.

A stack of reports is handed in front of her.

Enigma: This is the report you compiled during the "Storm" countdown, detailing 126 side effects and how the scroll alleviates them. I have some questions about the data for Type 34.

Lucy flips it open and dutifully goes through the list one last time.

Lucy: Yes. I can see a few errors in here.

Lucy: Unfortunately, I have to complete all of the handover procedures today. Perhaps you can ask Mr. Ulrich about it later.

She hands it back to Enigma, but he does not reach for it.

He looks at her, grief-stricken.

Enigma: The side effects left a mark on you, didn't they?

Enigma: There are 162 side effects, not 126. There was also an obvious typo in the data for Type 34. We noticed it long ago and corrected it, took only 5 seconds.

Enigma: You sacrificed so much for this report, yet you could not see such glaring mistakes.

Enigma: You called me Researcher Hofmann earlier—a name you haven't used since you took over Laplace eight years ago. To avoid confusion with my sister, you and our colleagues started calling me Adler instead.

Moving closer, he asks grimly.

Enigma: How much data did you lose to impair your research abilities like this?

Enigma: Is this why you have to leave Laplace now?

Enigma: The progress you've made has helped so many, but at what cost to your own well-being!

The robot does not answer, a rare occurrence.

From her side, Simone gently takes the file for her.

Assistant Simone: We should go, Madam Lucy.

Lucy: Hm. Goodbye, Researcher Adler.

Lucy: Thank you for correcting my mistake.

She walks away with steely steps, not looking back.

Enigma: Alright, fine!

He grips the doorframe, ignoring the strange looks from the hallway.

Enigma: I'll take up that role and do what you've been nagging me to do. I'll take care of those pesky committees.

Enigma: But just so you know, I'm not doing this for the higher-ups who look down on us,

Enigma: but for the people who look up to us from below!

Lucy: ...

The footsteps continue in rhythm.

Her duty here is done.

Then, another voice calls out.

Cryptography Lead: Madam Lucy!

Lucy: Hm?

The corridors are bustling with people.

Researchers, clerks, directors, and security ...

Every Laplace employee is in the corridors, from bottom to top floor.

The same voice shouts.

Cryptography Lead: All attention!

Cryptography Lead: Salute!

Papers litter the air like snowflakes.

Everyone says goodbye in their own language, tossing files over the railings.

The countless drafts, designs, and forms from the past 24 hours rain down.

They were created for the "Storm," and have completed their mission.

Just as did the robot.

Lucy: Simone, why are they throwing papers at me? Are they rejecting me and banishing me?

Assistant Simone: On the contrary, madam, they are showing their reverence.

Lucy: Oh, I see.

The robot is without a face and emotion module today, so she turns away from the crowd.

The sunlight dances on her metallic surface, enveloping her in a golden aura.

Lucy: Let us go, Simone.

Lucy: I miss the Laplace chargers already.

Lucy: There is a 230-volt bath at the resort, right?

THE END

/lo/ - So which poor sap's up for the spot next?

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/lo/ - So which poor sap's up for the spot next?

0001 Anonymous No.92272174 ▸
Lucy has resigned. Who'll be in charge now?

0002 Anonymous No.92272271 ▸>>92272411
Ulrich? He's the second most reliable awakened in the Scientific Computing Center.

0003 Anonymous No.92272305 ▸
Someone other than Lucy, I guess.

0004 Anonymous No.92272379 ▸
No one wants that seat. It's electrified.

0005 Anonymous No.92272411 ▸>>92273050
>>92272271
Ulrich is the most opposed to this idea, he's on a hunger strike in front of the committee building. I guess he'd rather starve to death than sit in that electric chair.
How about John? He's a man with clear logic and good project management skills.

0006 Anonymous No.92272669 ▸
Lucy was an excellent leader, the casualties this time shouldn't be her fault. The best option is to let her come back.

0007 Anonymous No.92273050 ▸
>>92272411
Which John? I hope you don't mean the one who speaks in hexadecimal.

0008 Anonymous No.92273059 ▸>>92273342 >>92273451
I recommend John from the mechanical engineering group. He's very creative and forward-thinking—definitely the right person to run the Scientific Computing Center.

0009 Anonymous No.92273342 ▸
>>92273059
Last week's major power outage was caused by that John from the mechanical engineering team starting all the lab machines in parallel. He's been suspended and has been undergoing psychiatric evaluation ever since.
I'd rather pick the John from the medical team.

0010 Anonymous No.92273451 ▸>>92273773
>>92273059
John from the medical team caused a huge explosion while testing a new drug formula last month. Luckily, since he's from the medical team, help was at hand, and he's still sleeping like a baby in his hospital bed right now.

0011 Anonymous No.92273773 ▸>>92273887
>>92273451
What about John from the theoretical physics lab? His projects are absolutely safe, there's never been any danger, and there won't be any in the future. And he only cares about logic in all things—simply the perfect candidate for the man in charge.

0012 Anonymous No.92273887 ▸
>>92273773
John from the theoretical physics lab applied for a transfer a long time ago. The only person still hanging on to that group is probably Adler who forgot to transfer his files ... so Adler is indeed currently the best theoretical physicist in all of Laplace (no need to even add "one of").

0013 Anonymous No.92273982 ▸>>92274029
In the entire Scientific Computing Center, we can't find a John suitable to take charge. Isn't there a John with the judgment, execution, and long-term scientific vision of Lucy? One who will unconditionally support our research, and even be willing to approve funding for X's strange inventions or new theories on the study of ley lines? A better sense of humor than Lucy's would also be a plus.

0014 Anonymous No.92274029 ▸>>92273987
>>92273982
I think you might be able to find a John funnier than Lucy, but that's it.
My suggestion is that we all join Ulrich in preventing any politician John or placeholder John from being put in that position, and on that basis, demand Lucy's return.

0015 Anonymous No.92273987 ▸
>>92274029
Good idea, see you in front of the committee building.

0016 Anonymous No.92274024 ▸
I'll bring a few decks of cards. And can someone tell me why we're only considering Johns?